

Fate's Edge

Complete Worldbook

A Gazetteer of the Known Realms

AS TOLD BY THOSE WHO LIVE THERE, BLEED THERE, AND OWE THERE

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Preface: The Ledger Bleeds

I am an Aeler Edgewalker. You call us mountain-dwellers who measure breath in silver bells and seal contracts in stone. How adorably naïve.

We don't just measure breathwe own the lungs that draw it. When a Tulkani chieftain swears an oath on his firstborn's life? That's not honourit's collateral I've already hypothecated three times over. When a Veiled Sister binds a demon to a corpse to prop up her corpse-throne? That's not terrorit's a futures contract on soul-debt, and I'm the broker who sold the short position before the ritual even began.

You see the surface as "full of problems." How quaint. Problems aren't obstaclesthey're inventory.

This book isn't a tourist's guide. It's a hit list with footnotes. I've marked the places where a well-placed bell doesn't just open a passit starts a war I've already shorted the bond market on. Where a forged seal doesn't just move a mountainit triggers a landslide I've bought mineral rights to before the first crack appeared. Where a single true story doesn't just buy a ship's loyaltyit buys the captain's silence while I sell his manifest to pirates.

You want to build journeys? Draw your cards. Set your clocks. Spend your Story Beats like they mean something. But remember: every Diamond you earn is a tooth knocked out of someone else's jaw. Every Debt you incur? I already bought it from your victim for half what you'll payand I'm collecting interest in your marrow before you finish reading this sentence.

The road isn't just a ledger. It's a butcher's block. Every gate isn't a clauseit's a throat waiting for the knife.

The Edgewalker

Part I

The Amaranthine Sea & Northern Shores

“The sea keeps a better ledger than any scribe. The reef remembers every secret whispered above its depths. Do not ask which flag flies highest ask which hull leaks slowest.” Dusana of the Raven Road

Chapter 1

Kahfagia

The Flag of Storms.

I was born on the tide, which is to say I was born owing. My mother was a net-mender who lost her fingers to a reef-cutter's debt. My father was a bell that is to say, he rang when the Admiralty pulled his string. I learned to read the lantern codes before I learned my letters, and I learned that every light is a lie waiting to be told.

The Admiralty runs this place like a pirate charter with a budget and oh, how they love pretending it's legitimate. They control the beacons that lure ships onto reefs, the booms that shatter hulls for salvage rights, and the tariffs that fund their champagne baths. But here's the secret the commodores don't want you to know: the lanterns are afraid of the dark too.

I've seen a Mirror-Keeper weep when her reflection showed her a daughter she'd sold for a pilot's license. I've watched a Privateer Captain kiss a silver coin before a raid the same coin her mother kissed before she never came back. This is not a city of heroes. It is a city of people who learned that the sea is cheaper than mercy.

If you want to move cargo through the straits without becoming fish food, get a convoy letter stamped with the Admiral's seal. Or get smart. Or get gone.

Captain Mira "the Lucky," Sidhi exile, pirate by convenience

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Salt fish porridgedried cod soaked overnight, boiled with hardtack and a splash of lamp oil. The oil is for calories. The fish is for memory. Every Kahfagian child learns to taste the salt and know which coast their grandmother came from.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count ships by their lanterns. Three lanterns means a Kahfagian merchantsafe. Four means an Oshiiran grain bargeneutral. One, low in the water, means a privateer. Run.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their hands. Dock-workers have rope-burned palms. Merchants have ink-stained fingers. Privateers have no fingernailsthey bite them off in storms.

What is the most common crime? False manifests. Every third ship carries cargo that doesn't appear on its papers. The Admiralty knows. The Admiralty takes a cut. The Admiralty calls it a "tariff surcharge."

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Mirror-Keepers are not bornthey are made. And the making requires a death. A sister, a daughter, a lover. Someone who drowned so the keeper could see through the fog.

Where do people go when they die? The tide takes them. Kahfagia has no cemeteries above ground. The drowned are weighted with chain and dropped in the deep channel. Their families light candles in paper boats and float them out at dusk. If the candle reaches the horizon, the soul is forgiven. If it sinks, the debt is not yet paid.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer your bell. Every Kahfagian carries a small brass bell on a leather cordthe sound of their name. Offering it to the wronged party means "I give you my voice. Speak for me." Refusing to return the bell after an apology is a declaration of blood feud.

What is the most important festival? The Beacon Lighting (midwinter). Every lighthouse keeper lights a new lamp from the Admiral's flame. If your beacon catches first, your year will be lucky. If it sputters, you will owe a death to the sea.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Admiral's lantern code has a ninth signalnever used, never spoken, burned into every keeper's memory. It means *"Kill the witnesses. Sink the evidence. The sea will hide the rest."*

1.1 Kahfagia — “The Creole Thalassocracy”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Every mirror is a blade, every beacon a promise. The sea obeys when we move the lights but the spiders weave in the mirror-towers.*

Admiral of Lantern-Law (Elite): “Every mirror is a blade, every beacon a promise. The sea obeys when we move the lights and woe to the fool who rows against them. Yet I have seen the reflection move before the hand that holds it. The tides are not the only ones with secrets.”

Dockside Factor (Commoner): “The pilots see farther than kings. A gesture in lantern-code can open ports, or close them. Keep your debts paid, and your lamps trimmed. And if a greyrobed stranger offers to adjust your mirror for free say no. The Lethaiar have long memories, and longer webs.”

Genre / Mood: Creole thalassocracy, signalandlane politics, eldritch tide, secret infiltration.

Starting Location: The Lantern Pier admiralty chapel, where votive ships hang from the ceiling and brine drips from the icon of a drowned saint. A seanotary unlocks a saltstained reliquary and produces a chart with gilt edges. “Fetch the contraband bell from the corsair galleass *Santa Dolorosa* before moonrise or the harbour names you accomplices. And watch for silk threads on the bollards. The Spider’s children are everywhere.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Kahfagia is the Creole child of Oshiira and the Vilikari a thalassocracy where Oshiiran ledgers meet Vilikari tidelaw. The Admiralty of Lantern-Law rules not by armies but by light, yet the real power flows through a tangled web of oligarchic families, each with their own spies, their own private navies, and their own seat on the Shadow Council. Above them all floats a central Admiralty fleet, charged with protecting the beacon monopoly and with watching the watchers.

But the oligarchs are not the only players. Unseen, the Lethaiar of Inaea have been infiltrating the mirrortowers for decades. A factor’s trusted secretary, a harbour master’s silent wife, a pilot’s apprentice with toostill eyes they weave their webs not for coin, but for *control*. They do not seek to destroy Kahfagia. They seek to *own* it, strand by strand, until the entire thalassocracy hums to the rhythm of the Spider’s mercy.

What you notice first: The constant chime of bell-buoys. The smell of salt, tar, and burnt oil from a thousand lanterns. The way everyone admiral to dockhand glances at the tide clock before speaking. And the faint, almost invisible silk threads tied around the bollards of the wealthiest piers.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never argue with a MirrorKeeper about where the channel lies. If they say the safe water moved, it moved. Your chart is already kindling. And if the MirrorKeeper smiles too widely, check the back of their neck for a spider’s brand.

Regional Mood: The Lantern’s Vigil & The Spider’s Web

Power is visible here literally. Every night, a thousand lamps burn along the channels, each a statement of control. To dim a light is to declare bankruptcy. To move a beacon is to declare war.

Commodores sit in their mirrortowers, watching reflections, while tideclocks tick down to the next auction, the next inspection, the next quiet murder.

But beneath the visible power, another war is fought in whispers. The Lethaiar agents of Inaea have spent a generation infiltrating the oligarchic families. A young heir who suddenly displays uncanny negotiating skill may not be talented they may be *woven*. A MirrorKeeper whose beacons never fail may be receiving guidance from a source that does not appear on any chart. The Spider's web is patient. It does not break the thalassocracy; it *guides* it.

Prominent NPCs of Kahfagia

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Admiral Zafira	Commander of Lantern-Law	Keep the beacon monopoly intact	She has never lost a ship to the reefs. Her charts are said to be drawn in water.
Mirza al-Qasr	Mirror-Keeper of the Pointe	Control the tides through light	Her face is never seen only reflected. Some say she has no shadow.
Ximena	Dockside Factor (commoner exemplar)	Profit from every cargo, legal or not	She keeps a ledger in lemon juice; heat reveals the truth.
Captain Rodrigo	Privateer with a crooked letter of marque	Raid the corsair fleet and pay off his crew	His ship flies three flags; the one he lowers last is the one that matters.
Sister Anabel	Healer of the Hospitallers of the Salted Veil (Temple of Light)	Tend the sick without asking payment	Her grey robes are said to be woven from old debts. They never stain.
Notary Farid	Admiralty magistrate	Resolve disputes before they reach the harbour master	He carries a waterclock in his sleeve to measure the shifting of legal moods.

The Harpist	Veiled	Lethaiar infiltrator (secret)	Woven the oligarchs, strand by strand	No one knows her face. She plays only in mirrorlit rooms, and her music leaves threads of silk in the listeners’ hair.
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The Oligarchic Houses (Shadow Council)

The true rulers of Kahfagia are not the Admiralty alone, but the **Shadow Council** of seven oligarchic families. Each controls a monopoly (spice, salt, silk, timber, pitch, shipbuilding, or intelligence). Each maintains its own private navy and network of spies. Each vies for the empty seat left by the family that the Lethaiar have already *woven* into silence.

- **House alKassam (Spice):** Oldest, proudest, most vulnerable. The Lethaiar have already replaced the family steward.
- **House Carrasco (Salt):** Ruthless pragmatists; they suspect infiltration but cannot prove it.
- **House Mirat (Silk):** Secret allies of the Lethaiar they trade webs for influence.
- **House del Puerto (Shipbuilding):** Neutral; they build for anyone who pays.
- **House Henares (Timber):** Deeply indebted to the Admiralty; the Lethaiar are slowly buying their notes.
- **House de la Vela (Intelligence):** The Admiralty’s own spy network and already compromised.
- **The Empty Chair:** Once held by House Morat, now vacant. The other houses whisper that the Morats were not destroyed they were *rewoven*.

Secret Faction: The Silk Vigil (Lethaiar Infiltrators)

Agents of Inaea, the Spider’s children have spent a generation worming into Kahfagia’s elite. They do not steal or sabotage they *guide*. A decision that benefits House Carrasco is subtly nudged toward the Lethaiar’s longterm goal: a unified thalassocracy that answers not to the Admiralty, but to the Web.

Signs of Infiltration:

- A factor’s handwriting becomes unnaturally precise, the loops forming faint eightshapes.
- A MirrorKeeper’s reflections show the same face in every tower a woman with chestnutbrown skin and eyes like polished jet.
- A ship that should have foundered instead limps to port, its crew speaking of a greyrobed passenger who vanished before docking.

Mechanical Hook: Once per session, a PC may roll Wits + Lore (DV 4) to notice a silken thread in an official’s collar or a spider’s brand on a dockhand’s wrist. On success, they identify a

Lethaiar agent. On failure, the agent becomes aware of their scrutiny and the Web tightens.

Names of Kahfagia

Inspired by the seafaring republics of the western coast, blended with Oshiiran and Vilikari influences: liquid consonants, soft vowels, and surnames that denote a port, a ship, or a founding ancestor.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Safir	Zafira	alKassam	<i>the Lantern</i>
Idris	Ximena	del Puerto	<i>TideKeeper</i>
Farid	Layla	de la Vela	<i>the Unlit</i>
Jabir	Aisha	Carrasco	<i>MirrorEye</i>
Rodrigo	Salma	Mirat	<i>BellBorn</i>
Tarik	Nura	Henares	<i>AshSails</i>

Spades — Places (Littoral/Lane/Law)

2. **Tidal Mudflat** — Hidden plankway at low water; smugglers' shortcut. *At ebb, the planks rise like the ribs of a drowned whale.* '[STEALTH]'
3. **Salt-Scar Pier** — Behind dawn spice auctions; where fortunes wash ashore. *Auditors check the saltscars white crust that proves cargo was cleaned, not stolen.* '[TRADE]'
4. **Reedbelt Creeks** — Smuggler paths where tax boats won't follow. *A hanged man's boots hang from a piling; those who pass tug their collars.* '[STEALTH]'
5. **Breakwater Gap** — Under repair; cutters slip at dusk through the works. *The stone is still loose. A wrong step, and the sea claims another toll.* '[TRAVEL]'
6. **Dredged Channel** — Fresh with temporary beacons; tomorrow's safe water. *The buoys are painted yellow the colour of "maybe."* '[TRAVEL]'
7. **River Sluice** — Tidegate and boomchain; access controlled by rope and writ. *The chain has a notch where a slaver's ship tried to flee. It still drips oil.* '[AUTHORITY]'
8. **Cutter Yard** — Narrowkeel vessels; apprentices work night shifts. *They sing old work songs the kind that skip the ninth beat.* '[LABOR]'
9. **Lantern Alley** — Foglane where beacons migrate with the tide. *Follow the lights. Two blinks means you're expected. Three? You're prey.* '[WEATHER]'
10. **Admiralty Quay** — Bonded warehouses under seal; law walks the decks. *The seal on the door changes with the tide. Today it's a serpent eating its tail.* '[AUTHORITY]'
- J **Red Shoal** — Quiet water, loud reputations; where deals are made. *Old barges moored together; a floating court with no bailiff.* '[SOCIAL]'
- Q **Mirror Tower** — Pilot station that certifies safe water today. *The mirror at the top shows not the sea, but the face of the last captain who argued.* '[JUSTICE]'
- K **Kassamira Port** — Presidial; auctions at dawn, courts by noon. *The auctioneer's gavel is wrapped in a page torn from a debtor's ledger.* '[TRADE]'
- A **The Pointe** — Strait of stormlights and wreckers' tales. *On still nights, you can hear the drowned singing the names of those who owe.* '[DEATH]'

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Tide-Runner** — Bell and rope; knows every tidetable by heart. *“The table says high water at noon. The moon lies. Trust my rope.”* ‘[TRAVEL]‘
3. **Pilot’s Apprentice** — Perfect memory for shoals; tomorrow’s navigator. *Touches a brass talisman before every sounding. No one knows why.* ‘[TRAVEL]‘
4. **Lantern Clerk** — Knows which lights moved, and why; keeper of the shifts. *Docks with a ledger that smells of smoke. Adds a surcharge for “recent adjustments.”* ‘[AUTHORITY]‘
5. **Oshiiran Factor** — Two ledgers; one for Kahfagia, one for truth. *The left ledger records bribes as “conciliation fees.” The right one is never shown.* ‘[TRADE]‘
6. **Dock-Syndic** — Makes queues vanish; power in the pause. *He never raises his voice. The harbour master listens anyway.* ‘[SOCIAL]‘
7. **Lantern Advocate** — “Jurisdiction moves like tide”; law in flux. *She carries a waterclock in her sleeve to measure the shifting of legal moods.* ‘[JUSTICE]‘
8. **Privateer Captain** — “Crooked” letter of convoy; profit in the margins. *Her ship flies three flags; the one she lowers last is the one that matters.* ‘[COMBAT]‘
9. **Thalassoi Sergeant** — Shore leave but still on duty; marine precision. *A tattoo of a lighthouse on his forearm; the light is his wife’s name.* ‘[COMBAT]‘
10. **Admiralty Magistrate** — Rules fast, travels faster; justice in a hurry. *She once sentenced a man to the galleys and boarded the ship before he did.* ‘[JUSTICE]‘
- J **Dredging Foreman** — Channel follows their purse; water reshaped. *His crew are excriminals; he pays them in salt pork and absolution.* ‘[LABOR]‘
- Q **Mirror-Keeper (Elite)** — Commodore’s confidante; places beacons that bind. *Their faces are never seen only reflected. Some say they have none.* ‘[AUTHORITY]‘
- K **Kahfagian Commodore** — Off the books but on the water; shadow admiral. *His flagship is a fishing smack. Its nets drag up letters of marque.* ‘[AUTHORITY]‘
- A **Admiral of Red Shoal** — Offers wine, figs once. Price in stories. *She pours the first cup herself. If she pours a second, you’ve already agreed.* ‘[LEGEND]‘

Clubs — Complications/Threats

(Entries unchanged except for the addition of a new threat: **Web Unravelled** a Lethaiar agent is exposed, and the oligarchs turn on each other.)

2. **Early Tide** — Turns two bells early; grounding risk rises like the sea. ‘[WEATHER]‘ *Someone bribed the tideclerk or the moon is angry.*
3. **Smothering Fog** — Sound travels, sight does not; navigation by ear alone. ‘[WEATHER]‘ *You hear oars. Then you don’t. Then they’re behind you.*
4. **Boom Slam** — Harbour chain slams shut; wrong side means delay or danger. ‘[AUTHORITY]‘ *The chain’s links are inscribed with names of debtors. Each one rattles differently.*
5. **Light Shift** — Beacons change midapproach; your lane just moved. ‘[TRAVEL]‘ *Someone paid the Lantern Clerk. Find out who or drift into the reefs.*
6. **Pilot Strike** — No escorts available; average unpaid, risk assumed. ‘[LABOR]‘ *The pilots sit in their guildhall, drinking tea, watching ships founder.*
7. **Customs Inspection** — Ladder audits cargo and crew; delays bite deep. ‘[AUTHORITY]‘ *The inspector has a silver tooth. He smiles when he sees a manifest.*

8. **Reef-Runners** — Corsair skiffs circle with boarding hooks; steel in the spray. ‘[COMBAT]’ *Their leader wears a MirrorKeeper’s badge stolen or earned, you cannot tell.*
9. **Jurisdiction Flip** — Lanternlaw shifts; your writ no longer bites. ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The tide turned. So did the magistrate. Your safeconduct is now kindling.*
10. **Fire Risk** — Alchemical cargo aboard; quarantine if anything spills. ‘[DISASTER]’ *A single spark and the whole quay becomes a crater. The factor wants you to know this.*
- J **Quartermaster Betrayal** — Tidetables sold to rival; route compromised. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The betrayal is written in lemon juice; heat reveals the name.*
- Q **Yellow Flag** — Port quarantine; deadlines rot on the hook. ‘[DEATH]’ *The flag is dyed with turmeric and something else something that smells sweet.*
- K **Fleet Redeploy** — “Safe” corridor becomes parade ground; chaos in formation. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *Admirals play chess with real ships, and you are a pawn.*
- A **Black Squall (at the Pointe)** — Scatters ships and stories alike. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *This is no natural storm. The water hisses. Something below is waking.*
- + **Web Unravelled** — A Lethaiar agent is exposed. The oligarchs turn on each other, accusing every rival of being a spider. ‘[POLITICS]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *Silk threads appear on every doorknob. No one trusts their shadow.*

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

(Unchanged; the existing rewards work well for a thalassocracy.)

2. **Mooring Chit** — Skip the Mooring Roll once; harbour favours you. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The chit is a dried seahorse shell. Keep it away from salt.*
3. **Pilotage Token** — One certified escort through a bad channel. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The pilot who accepts it must touch your shoulder before speaking.*
4. **Fee Waiver** — Cargo cleared today; ledger smiles included. ‘[TRADE]’ *The clerk stamps it twice once for the crown, once for the Hollow.*
5. **Safe-Conduct** — Along specific beacons lane; law walks with you. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The commodore’s seal is warm. It cools as the exit nears.*
6. **Salvage Rights** — On named quay or reach; flotsam becomes fortune. ‘[TRADE]’ *You must name each piece before touching it. The wrong word forfeits the claim.*
7. **Warehouse Access** — Bonded storage; seal prize before rivals sniff. ‘[TRADE]’ *The key is a bronze finger. It fits only one lock and breaks after use.*
8. **Lantern Code** — Tonight’s signals revealed; navigation advantage. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *Three quick flashes: safe passage. One long, two short: the Admiralty is watching.*
9. **Dredging Grant** — You decide where next channel runs; reshape the sea. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The dredgers are convicts. They work faster if you promise a name in their favour.*
10. **Letter of Marque** — Convoy protection for one season; legal blades. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The ink is mixed with gunpowder. It smokes slightly when read.*
- J **Admiralty Judgment** — Precedent travels with you; law bends. ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The case number is burned into a leather tag. Tag it to a belt loop.*
- Q **Mirror Warrant** — Legal right to post a beacon; redraw the map. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The MirrorKeeper’s seal, still warm. The channel you mark becomes law until challenged.*
- K **Spice Share** — Stake in Kassamira auction floor; profit in pepper. ‘[TRADE]’ *The share is*

a peppercorn sealed in wax. Bite it to test authenticity.

A **Lantern License** — Temporary authority to redefine the lane. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The harbour master spits when he hands it over. Use it wisely or not at all.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (25 → 4, 610 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (papers/rights/priority) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **sea & signal** motifs beacons that migrate, tides that remember, law that flows like water. If a King or Ace of Spades appears, also echo **web motifs** silk threads on a bollard, a reflection that holds too long, the faint smell of spiced tea (the Lethaiar are near).

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Pilot’s Mirror:** Kahfagia’s strength is not its fleet but its monopoly on light and lane. To post a beacon is to redraw the map. Any character with a Mirror Warrant may permanently move a beacon or buoy (GM sets a 4segment clock). For the duration of that clock, all navigation rolls on that lane are at +1 Position for the party and 1 Position for rivals.
- **Lantern-Law Privilege:** While flying an Admiralty flag or carrying a valid Lantern License, your ship may pass through chainbooms and customs points at +1 Position. The first time in a session you invoke this privilege, the GM gains 1 SB (the Admiralty is watching).
- **Oligarchic Favour (Leverage Track):** Instead of tracking coin debts, track *Favour* with the great families (alKassam, Carrasco, Mirat, etc.). Favour 13 gives you access to private docks, early auction warnings, and offthebooks pilots. Favour 4+ lets you call in a family to block a rival’s safeconduct or raise a false alarm on their ship.
- **The Web’s Patience (Secret Clock [6]):** Tracks the Lethaiar infiltration of the Shadow Council. The clock ticks when the party helps a Lethaiar agent, exposes a rival house’s secrets, or ignores a silken thread. At 3, the Harpist’s name appears on a dockmaster’s manifest. At 6, the Empty Chair is filled and the new house head bows to a greyrobed stranger. The party may reduce the clock by exposing an agent or by warning an oligarch (costs Favour 2).
- **Western Reach Rumours:** Once per port visit, a character may roll Wits + Lore (DV 3) to hear a rumour from a captain returned from beyond the mirror. On success, the GM reveals one of the six rumours (see below) as a foreshadowing hook or a clue for an ongoing arc.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Lantern Bearer** The Traveler. *A light that never goes out; a promise that never sinks.*
 - **The Mirror-King** The Witness. *Reflections that remember every lie, every promise, every cargo.*
 - **The Tide Father** Khemesh. *The pressure beneath the keel; the debt that the sea collects at ebb.*
 - **The Spider’s Daughter** Inaea (secret). *The web that binds the oligarchs, strand by patient strand.*
 - **The Unlit** Ikasha. *The ninth lamp that is never lit; the safe harbour that exists only

in rumour.*

Lore Echoes (CrossExpansion Hooks)

- **Saint Alvaro of the Lantern (The Traveler):** The Admiralty’s mirrortowers double as wayshrines for the Saint of Lost Channels. Sailors who light a candle before a voyage and whisper a destination to the mirror claim the tide will not turn against them before they reach it. The MirrorKeepers charge a fee for this service payable in salt, not silver.
- **The Silken Coup (Inaea):** The Lethaiar call their infiltration the *Genteel Harvest*. They do not conquer; they adopt. An oligarch who accepts a greyrobed advisor finds that their children are betrothed to shadowkin, their ledgers are copied in disappearing ink, and their mirrortower shows only the face they wish to see not the one that watches them sleep.
- **The TideSworn Compact (The Admiral of Sealed Tides):** A small but influential order of notaries based in Kassamira Port. They adjudicate disputes over beacon rights, cargo claims, and pilotage fees. Their judgments are always delivered in triplicate, and they accept no bribes only binding oaths. Those who lie before a Covenant judge find that their next three voyages are plagued by contrary winds.
- **The Hospitallers of the Salted Veil (The Bitter Root):** A hospice on Deadman’s Quay is run by greyrobed healers of the Order. They ask no payment, but they never forget a face. It is said that if you accept their care, you owe a favour to the sea itself and the sea always collects. Smugglers leave small offerings of fresh water on the pier to stay in the Order’s good graces.
- **The Ninth:** In any lanternlit scene, the ninth lamp lit in a room reveals a threshold. The wise stop at eight. Those who light the ninth are said to see a figure standing on the water outside the window waiting.

Kahfagia Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Wake:** Toss a crust over your shoulder before entering a new channel. Ignore the first *Smothering Fog* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Turn the Lantern:** Spin the binnacle lamp once counterclockwise. Cancel *Boom Slam* or take 1 die on your next pilot check (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Deep:** Whisper a true name into a lead line. Gain +1 Effect against corsairs for the scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Tide Court. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Cut the Thread:** If you find a silk thread on your bollard, cut it with a silver knife. Negate the next *Web’s Patience* tick. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

(Unchanged; see earlier table.)

Western Reach Rumours (d6, fast hooks)

1. A harbour where bells toll under water; cargo *must* be named aloud.
2. A spice that stops bleeding until moonrise.
3. A mirrorreef that reflects storms from a week ahead.
4. A pilotage guild that uses birds, not beacons.

5. A fleet that sails by *shadow* cast on fog.
6. A court that weighs debts in *breath*, not coin.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Sail + Wits):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Wake Surge*.
- **Cut the Lane (Pilot + Tactics):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a beacon is under your colour, +1 die.
- **Weather the Squall (Resolve + Sail):** On a hit in *Black Squall*, you pick who drifts; on a miss, the Keeper does.

Boss Seeds (Sea & Signal / Web & Silk)

- **The Mirror-Keeper of Kassamira (signal tyrant)** *Phases:* Audit → Blacklist → Light Embargo. *Cracks:* rival beacon logs, Tide Court precedent, stolen codebook.
- **Corsair-Chaplain of the Pointe (relic raider)** *Phases:* Charm → Board → Bell-Wake. *Cracks:* sanctified boom, cofradía oath, drowned saint tithe.
- **The Veiled Harpist (Spider’s Daughter)** *Phases:* Whisper → Weave → Harvest. *Cracks:* speak a true name of a Lethaiar agent, cut a strand of the Web with silver, or remind an oligarch of a debt older than the Spider’s memory.

Patronage & Power

In Kahfagia, power flows through control of the sea lanes themselves and through the silken threads that bind the oligarchs to the Spider’s will. The maritime oligarchs have built their empire not through conquest of territory but through mastery of navigation and the quiet manipulation of debt. Every beacon, every channel marker, every mirrorlight is both a navigational aid and a legal instrument. But behind every mirror, a greyrobed woman watches. And she is very, very patient.

For the GM: Kahfagian patronage revolves around access to channels, to cargo, to legal protection. Rewards often take the form of pilotage tokens, safeconducts, or salvage rights. But the secret war of the Lethaiar adds a new layer: players may be hired to expose an agent, to protect an oligarch from being “woven,” or even to ally with the Spider’s children for a share of the Harvest. Use the **Web’s Patience** clock to track the infiltration; let players decide whether to slow it, accelerate it, or ride it to power.

Amaria The Iron Shore

A small peninsula squeezed between Kahfagia’s Akilan holdings and the Oshiiran border, Amaria is a land of iron mines, coastal fog, and hybrid law. Ecktoria once claimed it; now it pays tribute to both Kahfagia and Oshiira to stay independent. Its people speak a creole of Kahfagian maritime slang and Oshiiran bureaucratic precision, and its courts rule by a blend of Admiralty tariff law and Vermilion Corps ledgerjustice.

What you notice first: The smell of rust and brine. The way every official carries two seals one for Kahfagia, one for Oshiira. The constant ticking of waterclocks that never agree on the hour.

The rule that kills newcomers: Never carry only one flag. Amarian vessels fly both the lantern and the grain sheaf. A single flag is a declaration of allegiance and an invitation to be sunk by the other side.

Quick Generators for Amaria (d6 each)

Spades Places (d6)

1. **Iron Quay** A pier built from salvaged warship timbers. The nails are iron from the inland mines; they rust red, staining the water like blood. '[INDUSTRY]'
2. **CoinHouse of Two Ledgers** A countinghouse where every transaction is recorded twice once for the Kahfagian tariff, once for the Oshiiran grain tithe. The third ledger is the smuggler's. '[TRADE]'
3. **Fog Lighthouse (Disputed)** A stone tower with two lamps: one green for Kahfagia, one white for Oshiira. Only one is lit at a time. The keeper changes them with the tide. '[AUTHORITY]'
4. **Smuggler's Rope-Walk** A hidden cove where boats land at low tide. The ropewalk is a series of knotted lines that lead to a cave full of untaxed cargo. '[STEALTH]'
5. **Mine Shaft of the Ninth Vein** An iron mine that goes deeper than the surveyors mapped. The miners whisper of a sealed door at the bottom Aeler work, they say. '[MYSTERY]'
6. **Dual Customs Post** A wooden shack with two windows: one for Kahfagian stamps, one for Oshiiran seals. The line snakes between them. Smugglers pay both clerks and skip the line. '[AUTHORITY]'

Hearts People (d6)

1. **TwoLedger Clerk** Sits at a split desk, writing with two hands. Her left hand files Kahfagian tariffs; her right, Oshiiran grain receipts. Her third hand the one no one sees writes the real numbers. '[TRADE]'
2. **Iron Miner (Free)** A former indentured labourer who bought his freedom with a year's ore. His hands are stained red with rust. He knows the sealed door's location but will not speak of it. '[LABOR]'
3. **Smuggler Captain** Flies no flag. His ship's name changes with each port. He speaks four languages badly and navigates by the taste of salt on the wind. '[STEALTH]'
4. **Kahfagian Customs Agent** A oneeyed woman with a brass hook for a hand. She stamps cargo with a bellshaped seal. The seal rings when the declared value is a lie. '[AUTHORITY]'
5. **Oshiiran Grain Auditor** Thin, spectacled, carries a grain balance. He measures every sack against the Widow's standard. He has found nine thieves this year. The tenth was his own clerk. '[JUSTICE]'
6. **Fog Keeper (Lighthouse)** An old sailor who lost his sight to a Kahfagian mirror flash. He tends the lamps by touch. He knows which flag flies by the heat of the glass green is cool, white is warm. '[WEATHER]'

Clubs Complications (d6)

1. **Tariff DoubleCross** Both Kahfagia and Oshiira claim the same customs fee. Pay one, and the other impounds your cargo. Pay both, and you are bankrupt. Smuggle, and you are a patriot. '[DEBT]'

2. **Mine Collapse (Sealed Door)** A cavein opens a passage to the sealed Aeler door. The miners are afraid. Something is breathing on the other side. The party is asked to investigate or to seal it again. ‘[DISASTER]’
3. **Lighthouse Outage** Both lamps go dark. Ships founder on the reef. The keeper is found dead, one hand on each lamp. The cause of death: old age or old debt. ‘[DEATH]’
4. **Census Dispute** Oshiira claims Amaria’s population for grain tithes; Kahfagia claims it for port taxes. The same people are counted twice or not at all. The party is asked to audit the ledgers. The ledgers are on fire. ‘[POLITICS]’
5. **Iron Embargo** A rival faction sinks an ore barge. Both powers blame each other. The price of iron spikes. The party’s cargo is now worth a fortune and a target. ‘[COMBAT]’
6. **The Ninth Vein Opens** The sealed door cracks. A cold wind blows from the deep. The miners flee. A voice whispers a name the name of the party member who owes the deepest debt. ‘[MYSTERY]’

Diamonds Rewards (d6)

1. **Dual Customs Stamp** One stamp, two seals. Passes both Kahfagian and Oshiiran checkpoints without inspection. Use once per journey. ‘[TRAVEL]’
2. **Iron Ingot (Ninth Vein)** A bar of ore from the sealed door’s chamber. It is warm to the touch. Aeler runes glow on its surface. Trade it to the True Masons for a favour. ‘[TRADE]’
3. **Fog Keeper’s Log** A journal of tide and lamp schedules. Decode it to predict when the disputed lighthouse will be unguarded. Gain +1 Position on smuggling attempts. ‘[WEATHER]’
4. **TwoLedger Receipt** A document that proves you paid both tariffs. It is written in disappearing ink. The ink vanishes after one use but the paper remembers. ‘[JUSTICE]’
5. **Miner’s Compass** A brass needle that points to the sealed door. It also points to the nearest iron vein and to the nearest heart that beats with greed. ‘[TRAVEL]’
6. **Smuggler’s Flag (Neutral)** A plain grey banner. Fly it to pass between Kahfagian and Oshiiran patrols unmolested. The patrols will not salute. They will not shoot. They will pretend they did not see you. ‘[STEALTH]’

Chapter 2

Ecktoria

Marble & Fire.

My grandfather was a senator. He voted to burn the Ykrul tribute-pact, and then he voted to burn the inquiry into why the grain ships sank. He signed his name in wax and watched the city burn three times. He never raised his voice.

I am a Coin-House Factor. I seal deals with three ribbonswhite for "ask," red for "now," black for "never." I have never used the black ribbon. Not because I am kind, but because "never" is a debt I cannot collect.

Ecktoria is an Empire that never quite diedmore like a corpse propped up by gilded scaffolding and the stubborn refusal of its undertakers to admit the job's done. The Everflame burns in every basilica not as a symbol of divine truth, but as a literal lie detector: swear a false oath near it, and your tongue turns black. I have seen a merchant's tongue turn black mid-sentence. He finished his lie anyway. The buyers pretended not to notice. *That is Ecktoria.*

The statues watch. The fire judges. The marble remembers every name carved into its stepsand every name left out.

Do not refuse a toast in a coin-house. The ledgers are the true judges, and a declined cup is a declined credit. You will not borrow again.

Marcus of the Red Ledger, Coin-House Factor, third generation

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Spiced flatbread dipped in olive oil and honeybut only if you can afford the honey. The poor eat millet porridge with a single dried fig. The fig is counted as part of the household's grain allowance.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count coins by touch. Every

Ecktorian child has a box of worn sesterces; by age five, they can tell a debased copper from pure silver by the weight alone.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their signature. Ecktorians judge by handwriting before face. A clerk with a steady hand is trustworthy. A noble with a flourish is hiding something. A merchant who signs with an X is not worth doing business with.

What is the most common crime? Tax evasion but it is not a crime, it is a sport. Every household keeps two ledgers: the white one for the Censor, the red one for the family. The art is in keeping the red ledger from looking like a confession.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Censor's clerks are paid to find discrepancies. They are also paid to lose them. The price of a lost discrepancy is exactly 5% of the tax owed. This is not corruption. It is "administrative flexibility."

Where do people go when they die? The family crypt, beneath the basilica floor. The wealthy are burned, their ashes mixed with marble dust and pressed into the floor tiles. The poor are buried in unmarked graves outside the walls. The Everflame's light does not reach that far.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You petition the Censor to have the wrong stricken from the public record. The petition costs a tenth of your annual income. If accepted, the wrong is erased legally, it never happened. If rejected, the wrong is published, and you lose your civic standing.

What is the most important festival? The Triumph of the Flame (autumn equinox). The basilica's central flame is carried in procession through every district. To touch the flame is to be absolved of petty debts. To be burned by it is a sign that your debts are not petty.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Grand Magistrate's seal is a forgery. The original cracked in 783 AR. The current seal was carved by a prison engraver who was executed to keep the secret. The engraver's apprentice is still alive. They live in Silkstrand. They have the original sketches.

2.1 Ecktoria — “Marble & Fire”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The flame remembers. The marble judges. The ledger never sleeps.*

Grand Magistrate (Elite): “The law here is written not in books but in marble and flame. Every edict carries the weight of centuries, and every judgment echoes in the very stones of the Forum. But the Forum has grown quiet of late. The patricians no longer listen.”

Ferrymaster (Commoner): “I’ve seen the city burn three times and rise again like a phoenix made of stone. The marble remembers, the bells tell the truth, and the fire judges all — especially those who think coin can buy clean hands. But this time the fire isn’t burning. It’s *smiling*. The rich have stopped looking at the flames. They only look at each other.”

Genre / Mood: Imperial decay, mercantile noir, flamelit judgment, Renaissance decadence — a city walled off from its own rot, where the wealthy dance while the poor cough ash.

Starting Location: The CoinHouse floor, marble cracked with soot lines, where votive candles burn beside melted icons. A factor with smokesinged ledgers offers a purse. “The Lame King moves,” she says. “And the Basilica burns with him. Your credit is good — for now. Find out who lit the fire, or the Flame will audit your soul at dawn. And stay away from the Amber Palace. The Vigil has been *smiling*.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Once the heart of the Utaran Empire, Ecktoria has worn its laurels into chains. Three centuries of sack, fire, and slow decline have not stripped its marble forums nor its goldsealed coinhouses — but each day, more of its wealth slips into the hands of mercenaries and factions. The Black Banners march on its purse, avenging old Ykrul wounds by proxy. Processions still crown its stairways, yet ash lines every step. The city burns not only with memory, but with ambition still unquenched.

Yet the true sickness is not in the streets. It is in the **Amber Palace**, where the old patrician families have walled themselves away. They sit on laurels preserved from the empire, drinking wine that costs a village’s harvest, whispering deals with merchants who have never seen a loom. **Maelstraeus**, the demon of commerce and greed, has sunk his hooks into their ledgers; every contract they sign compounds interest in blood. **Livaea**, the demon of seduction and desire, has wrapped their hearts in silk; they marry for influence, divorce for scandal, and love only the reflection of themselves in gilded mirrors. The common folk call them the *Unburdened* — not because they carry no weight, but because they have forgotten what weight feels like.

The **Vigil** — once the empire’s secret police, now a fractured ghost of an institution — fights a silent war over the dream of restoration. One faction, the **Censer-Knights**, serves the Everflame and the Synod, hunting heresy and latent magic with brass censers and bells that ring at dawn. Another, the **Unburnt**, answers only to the old patrician houses, ensuring that no whisper of rebellion reaches the Amber Palace. A third, the **Red Vigil**, has sold itself to Maelstraeus, auditing debts and collecting interest in screams. They do not fight each other openly. They meet in the hypogeum of the Arena, under the gaze of statues that

weep marble tears.

Beyond the capital's walls, the province is a patchwork of struggling towns, abandoned fortresses, and grainlands whose harvests are disputed by rival taxcollectors. The Everflame Orthodoxy preaches unity, but each sermon is a coded signal for a political camp. The statues watch. The fire judges. And in the sewers, the Vigil's informers listen for the name of the next person to vanish.

What you notice first: The smell of old incense and fresh bread and beneath it, the faint sweetness of rot. The way crowds part for a procession and close again for a knife. The marble steps, worn smooth by centuries of petitioners. The way the wealthy never step on the cracks.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never refuse a toast in a coinhouse. The ledgers are the true judges, and a declined cup is a declined credit. You will not borrow again. But more than that: never accept a gift from a patrician without naming its price aloud. Maelstraeus and Livaea both listen, and a gift accepted in silence is a contract signed in blood.

Regional Mood: The Flame That Remembers And The Dancers Who Forgot

Here, the past does not fade it is polished into monuments. Every statue, every obelisk, every triumphal arch is a legal precedent carved in stone. Ecktoria is not one city but three: the marble forums of the old patricians (where the Unburdened hold masques that last for weeks, their faces painted with ash from the Everflame), the sootstained alleys of the mercenary camps (where Black Banner captains drink with Vigil informers), and the basilicas where the Everflame's priests balance piety against profit (and sometimes sell indulgences for the sin of being born poor). The Grand Magistrate presides over a skeleton empire, but the real power moves in coinhouses, grain ledgers, and the whispered judgments of the Censor's Hall and in the dreams of patricians who no longer remember the scent of rain.

The **Vigil** does not patrol the streets. It *permeates* them. Every tavern has an informer; every bathhouse has a spy; every marriage is witnessed by someone who reports to a faction of the Vigil. The **Censer-Knights** hunt unlicensed magic; the **Unburnt** hunt sedition; the **Red Vigil** hunts *debt*. They are not allies. They are not enemies. They are three creditors fighting over the same soul.

The **patricians** the Old Blood no longer govern. They *perform* governance. A session of the Parlement might see two senators debate the price of grain while their slaves hold silver trays of honeyed figs. A decree might be passed that doubles the salt tax, then rescinded an hour later because a duchess sneezed. They are not cruel. They are *distracted*. Livaea has taught them to crave the next pleasure before they have finished the current one. Maelstraeus has taught them that every transaction is a game, and every game is winnable if you have enough coin. They do not see the bread riots. They see a shortage of *entertainment*.

The **Everflame** still burns in the basilicas, but its light has grown dim. The High Priest speaks of unity, but his sermons are interrupted by coughing from the pews not from illness, but from the ash that falls like snow. The common folk whisper that the flame no longer judges truth; it only *records* it, filing confessions in a vault that no one ever opens. The Vigil has a key. The patricians have a copy. The poor have nothing but their names, which the Censor's Hall writes in disappearing ink.

The Everflame Faith of Ash and Incense

The state religion of Ecktoria is a syncretic faith that venerates the Eternal Flame as the divine principle, but its power flows through three great Orders, each devoted to a different Patron. The Basilica of the Unquenched Flame is the heart of the city: a cavernous space of gold mosaics, weeping saints, and the perpetual smell of beeswax and myrrh. Mass is held at dawn and dusk, the congregation coughing through the ash that falls from the censers. The priests sell indulgences in the side chapels—a silver coin for the remission of a small sin, a gold coin for a large one, a horse for a murder. The choir sings in Utaran, a language most parishioners no longer understand, but the melody is beautiful enough to make them weep.

- **Order of the Oath of Flame & Light (Orthodox)** The public face of the church. They lead processions, bless marriages, and anoint the dying. Their rites are those of vows, radiance, and protection. They are the ones who light the great candles at dawn. Many are sincere; most are tired.
- **Order of the Inquisitor Prime (Prosecutorial)** The **Censer-Knights**. They hunt untutored magic, root out demonic cults, and enforce the purity of the flame. Their rites are those of judgment, purification, and burning censure. They carry brass censers that smoke with bitter herbs, and bells that ring once for a warning, thrice for a raid. They are feared, but also respected—for they are the only ones who still take the flame seriously.
- **Order of the Oath of Mercy and Grace (Hospitalier)** The healers and confessors. They run hospices, tend to the sick, and hear the confessions of the dying. Their rites are those of healing, forgiveness, and the spiral of care. They are often at odds with the Inquisitor Prime—mercy can look like leniency. The common folk love them; the patricians ignore them.

The Everflame is both beautiful and ugly. Its gold leaf covers the same marble where debtors once scratched their names. Its hymns are sung by choirboys whose families sold them for a loaf of bread. Its relics—a nail from the True Cross, a tear of Saint Lucia—draw pilgrims from across the empire, but the priests charge admission, and the poor sleep on the steps. The flame itself is a wonder: a pillar of blue-white fire that never gutters, tended by the High Priest alone. It is said to show the truth to any who stare into it long enough—and to show the same truth to the Vigil, who watch from the shadows.

At a Glance

- **Atmosphere:** Marble grandeur, ashtipped ambition, the slow rot of imperial forms, and the cloying sweetness of a city drowning in its own nostalgia.
- **Key Conflict:** Legitimacy versus wealth; old families, new mercenaries, and the Everflame’s judgment—but beneath it all, the battle between Maelstraeus (greed) and Livaea (desire) over the souls of the powerful.
- **Notable Threats:** Bread riots, arena spills, ducal conflicts, inquisitorial visits, the Red List and the Vigil’s three factions, who may arrest you for debt, sedition, or simply being unnamed.
- **Common Rewards:** Procession permits, coinhouse credit, laurel deeds, a Golden Edict carved in precedent—and, if you are brave, a secret from the Vigil’s own ledgers.

Prominent NPCs of Ecktoria

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Valerius	Grand Magistrate	Preserve the forms of law while the empire crumbles	His gavel is a sundial; it only strikes at noon. He has not struck it in a year.
Flavia	High Priest of the Ever-flame	Balance the factions and keep the flame lit	She has never raised her voice; the flame speaks for her. Lately, it speaks in the voices of the dead.
Cassia	Duchess-Regent of the Dolmis Gate	Protect her family's trading rights	She rules from behind a silk screen; a daggerhole is cut at eye level. The screen was a gift from Li-vaea.
Marcus	Coin-House Factor	Survive the next credit panic	He seals deals with three ribbons: white (ask), red (now), black (never). His black ribbon is fraying.
Lucius	Lanista (arena master)	Own the next champion and the secrets of the hypogeum	His fighters' brands are his signature; he never repeats a mark. One brand is a spiral the mark of the Red Vigil.

The Red Clerk	Censor’s Hall scribe	Control which names are remembered	His inkwell is a skull; the skull belonged to a name he erased. He has forgotten his own name.
Censer-Knight Commander Vorenius	Prefect of the Order of the Inquisitor Prime	Hunt untutored magic before it wakes the Ninth	His lantern burns green. He says it shows the truth. His shadow has two heads.
Lady Aelia	Patrician heiress, Livaea’s favourite	Outshine every rival before the next masque	She has not left the Amber Palace in seven years. She does not know the price of bread.

Names of Ecktoria

Inspired by late Latin and early Romance: strong vowels (ae, i, o), soft endings, and the weight of imperial bureaucracy. Surnames often denote a place of origin, a trade, or a notable ancestor.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Valerius	Flavia	de Urbe	<i>the Iron</i>
Marcus	Cassia	Aquilinus	<i>the Coin-Wise</i>
Lucius	Aelia	Honoratus	<i>Flame-Touched</i>
Tiberius	Cornelia	Lateranus	<i>the Unburned</i>
Gaius	Livia	Silvanus	<i>Bread-Counter</i>
Decimus	Valeria	Portinari	<i>Ash-Finger</i>

The Three Ecktorias: Faction Spectrum

Ecktoria is not a single polity but a battlefield of three competing visions. Most citizens and factions fall somewhere between these poles, shifting allegiance as the grain price changes. Superimposed on them are the whispers of Maelstraeus and Livaea, who have no faction — only debtors.

- **Old Blood (Patrician Traditionalists)** – The ancient senatorial families who remember when Ecktoria ruled the world. They worship precedent, hoard marble, and see mercenaries as necessary filth. Their power is in law, lineage, and the silent networks of the Censor’s Hall. *Clocks: PATRICIAN PATIENCE [4], BLOOD DEBT [6]. Patron whispers:* Livaea — they marry for influence, betray for pleasure, and mistake cruelty for wit.

- **Black Purse (Mercenary & Trade Leagues)** – The new power: condotta brokers, coinhouse factors, and mercenary captains who have bought what birth could not give. They care about supply lines, not bloodlines. Their loyalty is to the next contract, and their god is the ledger. *Clocks: CONTRACT SPIRAL [4], PAYDAY FEVER [6]. Patron whispers: Maelstraeus* they measure profit in interest, interest in suffering, and suffering in silver.
- **The Everflame (Church & Inquisition)** – The priests, inquisitors, and relickeepers who claim that the Eternal Flame is the only true sovereign. They offer legitimacy to whoever pays the tithe and withdraw it from whoever forgets. Their power is in pulpits, processions, and the fear of excommunication. *Clocks: HERESY INDEX [4], SANCTUARY VIOLATION [6]. Patron whispers: Neither the Everflame remembers, but the Vigil has learned to filter its truths.*

Superimposed on these are the **Ykrul creditors** (who hold Ecktoria’s debt like a leash), the **Black Banners** (who hold its streets like a lease), and the **Vigil** (who hold its secrets like a knife). A wise politician learns to balance all three and keeps a boat ready on the Dolmis.

The Vigil Three Faces of the Secret Police

The Vigil is not one order but three, each claiming the mantle of the old imperial secret police. They do not cooperate. They do not war. They *audit* each other.

- **The Censer-Knights (Orthodox, Everflame)** Hunters of untutored magic. They carry brass censers that smoke with bitter herbs and bells that ring once for a warning, thrice for a raid. They answer to the Synod and the High Priest, but their true loyalty is to the *precedent* the law that magic must be licensed, indexed, and taxed. A Censer-Knight raid is heralded by a single, low bell. They are the most feared and the most public. *Clocks: CANDLE-SMOKE SWEEP [4], HERETIC INDEX [6].*
- **The Unburnt (Patrician)** Bodyguards and spies of the Amber Palace. They wear red sashes and carry no visible weapons. Their job is to ensure that no whisper of rebellion, no bread riot, no debt revolt ever reaches a patrician’s ear. They are experts at *redaction* not killing witnesses, but making them forget. *Clocks: PALACE SECRETS [4], REDACTED MEMORY [6].*
- **The Red Vigil (Maelstraeus’s Own)** Debtcollectors and interestenforcers. They serve no noble, no church, no magistrate only the ledger. They audit the wealthy for the wealthy, finding hidden obligations, unpaid tithes, and compound interest that has grown teeth. A Red Vigil agent never demands coin. They demand *names*. *Clocks: INTEREST DUE [4], LEDGER OF NAMES [6].*

The Vigil’s three commanders meet once a month in the hypogeum of the Arena, under the gaze of statues that weep marble tears. No record is kept of these meetings. No one admits they happen. The common folk say that if you see a Vigil agent, it is already too late but they cannot agree on *which* Vigil.

Spades — Places

2. **Petition Steps** — Milkstone steps where dawn petitions are pinned. *The petitions are written in ink and hope. The steps answer in marble and silence.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
3. **Tally-Ford Ferryhouse** — Ropedrums thrum all day; the ferrymaster watches coin and banners. *The ropedrums have a pattern. It spells the names of those who paid late.* ‘[TRAVEL]’

4. **Arena Hypogeum** — Practice sand and whispered secrets beneath the games. *The sand is from the Tiber. It still remembers the blood of the last revolt. The Vigil meets here.* ‘[DEATH]’
5. **Everflame Cloister** — Candle markets and sidechapels where flame speaks truth. *The flame has a voice. It is the voice of the last liar who tested it. Lately, it speaks in a whisper.* ‘[TRUTH]’
6. **Shatterline Bazaar** — Between quaketoppled columns, merchants hawk broken dreams. *The columns were toppled by an earthquake that killed a senator. He still haunts the rubble, counting his debts.* ‘[TRADE]’
7. **Coin-House Floor** — Counting ledgers under glass; factors seal credit with three ribbons. *The ribbons are colored: white for "ask," red for "now," black for "never." The black ribbons are all frayed.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
8. **Mile-Zero Obelisk** — Surveyors’ starting point; all roads measured from here. *The obelisk has a crack. The crack is a mile long in the other direction. The Vigil uses it to measure disappearances.* ‘[LAW]’
9. **Triumph Stairs** — Processional Way switchback; marble worn smooth by ambition. *The stairs have a name: "The Rise of the Forgotten." No one remembers why. The patricians still climb them.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
10. **Aqueduct Walk** — Narrow guardpath above the city’s arteries; perfect for ambush or escape. *The water below tastes of iron. It is the city’s memory of its own blood. The Vigil drinks it to stay awake.* ‘[STEALTH]’
- J **Ducal Loggia** — High above a packed square; a duchess watches and waits. *The duchess has not blinked in three hours. She is counting. She has forgotten what she is counting.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- Q **Censor’s Hall** — Redlacquered tablets record every name, every shame. *The tablets are redacted in invisible ink. The truth is underneath. The Vigil has the reagent.* ‘[LAW]’
- K **Grand Forum** — Statues tarped, echoes loud; where crowds become mobs. *The tarps were a gift from a dead emperor. The statues do not thank him. They whisper to the Vigil.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
- A **The Amber Palace** — Walled off from the city, where the patricians hold masques that last for weeks. *The walls are not stone. They are debt. No one has entered without an invitation in a decade. No one has left.* ‘[LEGEND]’

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Torchbearer Child** — Ashsmudged hands; knows every shortcut through the ruins. *She has never been lost. The ruins speak to her in dust. The Vigil pays her for echoes.* ‘[STEALTH]’
3. **Ferrymaster** — Knows which banners pay late; collects more than coin. *His ledger is a net. The names are the catch. He sold a name to the Red Vigil once. He does not sleep well.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
4. **Coin-House Factor** — Seals credit with three ribbons; eyes twitch at defaults. *His eyes are the color of old silver. They see through your purse. They also see the Red Vigil in the corner.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
5. **Lanista** — Owns fighters and their secrets; sells victory in the sand. *His grin is a brand. The brand is on his fighters’ necks. One fighter has a brand that glows a Vigil spy.* ‘[COMBAT]’

6. **Decumanus-Master** — Surveyor who "moves" stones; rewrites the city's shape. *His rod is a finger bone. The bone belonged to the last surveyor who argued. The Vigil uses his maps.* '[LAW]'
7. **Procession Marshal** — Permits and whistle; keeps order in ceremonial chaos. *His whistle is for the living. His bell is for the dead. He has not used the whistle in a year.* '[SOCIAL]'
8. **Grain-Prefect** — Allots loaves; knives in the margins of every ledger. *His ledger has a stain. The stain is wine or blood. The Vigil has a copy.* '[DEBT]'
9. **Censor's Clerk** — "Misfiles" careers; knows which names to forget. *His inkwell is a skull. The skull belonged to a name he forgot. The Vigil pays him for the ones he remembers.* '[LAW]'
10. **Veteran Standard-Bearer** — Sells honor as a retainer; medals heavier than sword. *His medals are from a war that never happened. The corpses are from one that did. The Vigil recruited him.* '[COMBAT]'
- J **Gladiatrix** — Darling of the crowds; owes no one but the sand. *Her sword has no name. The sand has many. The Vigil has a file on her. It is thicker than her arm.* '[COMBAT]'
- Q **Duchess-Regent** — Behind a silk screen; speaks through cousins, rules through silence. *The screen has a hole. The hole is for a dagger hers. The screen was a gift from Livaea.* '[POLITICS]'
- K **High Priest of Everflame** — Smiles like law; flame judges truth and debt. *His smile is a candle. It can warm or burn. The Vigil has asked him to smile less.* '[TRUTH]'
- A **Censer-Knight Commander Vorenius** — Leads the Order of the Inquisitor Prime. Fears the Unburnt. Hates the Red Vigil. *His lantern burns green. He says it shows the truth. His shadow has two heads one for each faction he has betrayed.* '[AUTHORITY]'

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Blocked Bridge** — A procession blocks the only crossing till sundown. '[TRAVEL]'
3. **Proscribed Sigil** — A sudden edict: your mark is now forbidden. '[LAW]'
4. **Bread Riots** — Grain barges are late; hunger hisses at the city's edges. '[SOCIAL]'
5. **Arena Spill** — A riot spills into streets; shutters slam, guards draw steel. '[COMBAT]'
6. **Ducal Conflict** — Rival dukes levy the same ward; your recruits vanish. '[POLITICS]'
7. **Border Dispute** — A replat redraws boundaries; your deed becomes "disputed." '[LAW]'
8. **Frozen Purse** — A coinhouse calls in notes; your purse freezes at the worst moment. '[DEBT]'
9. **Inquisitorial Visit** — A relic's authenticity is questioned; penalties are swift and public. '[TRUTH]'
10. **Aftershock** — Masonry and timetables fall; scaffolds groan with new cracks. '[DISASTER]'

- J **Counterfeit Laurel** — Your win is void unless you find the forger. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The forger is a child. The child is a slave. The slave is a senator’s son. The Vigil knows.*
- Q **Church Purge** — "Spectacles" are banned; your venue is canceled by zealots. ‘[DEATH]’ *The zealots are paid by a rival. The rival is in the front row. The Vigil is in the back.*
- K **Rerouted Triumph** — The crowd follows the favored path; your moment is stolen. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The favored path is lined with archers. The archers are not there for the ceremony. They are Vigil.*
- A **Red List** — A secret ledger; your patron’s name appears overnight. ‘[DEATH]’ *The list is written in a dead hand. The dead are still collecting. The Vigil holds the pen.*

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Bread Chit** — Ward sustenance for a week; street patience guaranteed. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The chit is a clay token. Break it to eat or to bribe. The Vigil accepts both.*
 3. **Procession Permit** — Move sacred flame through a crowded quarter; law walks with you. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The permit is a torch. Carry it, and the city will part or burn. The Vigil will follow.*
 4. **Arena Purse** — Settles debts and hires mouths; bloodmoney in coin. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The purse is a helmet. The helmet belonged to a champion who lost. The Vigil has his name.*
 5. **Survey Writ** — Reset one boundary stone; redraw the city’s shape. ‘[LAW]’ *The writ is a stone. Move it, and the map changes on paper. The Vigil watches the paper.*
 6. **Ducal Safe-Conduct** — Four guards and a trumpet; noble favor walks ahead. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The guards are paid by the duke. The trumpet is paid by you. The Vigil has a key to the trumpet.*
 7. **Coin-House Credit** — Silent and immediate; debt becomes opportunity. ‘[DEBT]’ *The credit is a ribbon. Cut it to spend or to owe. The Vigil will collect the interest.*
 8. **Magistrate’s Postponement** — Buy a tenday against any suit; law delayed, not denied. ‘[LAW]’ *The postponement is a letter. The letter is sealed with a tear. The Vigil has the other copy.*
 9. **Laurel-Deed** — Crowd favor follows you into court; glory as a shield. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The deed is a leaf. It was plucked from a victor’s crown. The victor is dead. The Vigil knows why.*
 10. **Grain Ledger** — Name who eats this month; hunger bends to your will. ‘[DEBT]’ *The ledger is a stomach. Feed it, or it will feed on you. The Vigil has the first page.*
- J **Minor Title** — A style that opens doors that bolts resist; rank as a key. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The title is a word. The word is "Patrician." The doors do not ask questions. The Vigil does.*
- Q **Basilica Audience** — One private hour with the High Priest; the flame speaks truth. ‘[TRUTH]’ *The hour is a candle. When it burns out, so does your favor. The Vigil lit the candle.*
- K **Censor’s Indulgence** — One banned thing becomes permitted (for you). ‘[LAW]’ *The indulgence is a silence. The silence is a scream. The Vigil has earplugs.*
- A **Golden Edict** — An exception carved in marble; precedent travels like law. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The edict is a crack. The crack in the law is now an opening. The Vigil is already inside.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (papers/favor/precedence) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **marble and fire** motifs statues that watch, flames that judge, and law that remembers every name. Also echo the **Vigil's presence** a cough in the crowd, a seal on a document you did not stamp, a mirror that shows a different face.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Imperial Ruins:** Every district bears halfcollapsed arcades, serving as markets, courts, or shelters for mercenary companies. The Vigil knows every hidden passage.
- **Competing Factions:** Dukes, guilds, and priests stage processions that collide at bridges and squares, each claiming legitimacy. The Vigil collects bets on the outcome.
- **Monuments as Weapons:** Statues, obelisks, and colonnades are not only symbols they are barricades, rallying points, and high ground when the city riots. The Vigil has a map of which statues can be toppled.
- **Everflame Orthodoxy:** The basilicas preach unity, but each sermon is a coded signal for a political camp. The High Priest plays balance while cultivating his own following. The Vigil decodes every sermon.
- **Black Banner Contracts:** Foreign mercenaries fill the gaps left by a shrinking citizen levy, their loyalty secured only by steady coin. The Vigil audits their pay.
- **The Amber Palace Quarantine:** The patricians have not left the palace in a decade. No one is certain if they are prisoners or patrons. The Vigil maintains the perimeter and delivers the wine.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Saints & Cults):**
 - **St. Marcellus of the Gilded Scale (Mykkiel)** *The Justiciar*. His order enforces unwritten laws; reading a sealed precedent binds the reader to enforce it. His shrine is the Censor's Hall. The Vigil keeps a copy of every precedent.
 - **St. Valeria of the Serpent (Isoka)** *The Shedding Saint*. Pilgrims who confess at her chapel forget one sin and one kindness. Her mosaic shows a snake eating its tail. The Vigil uses her chapel to erase memories.
 - **St. Lucia of the Undying Flame (Oath of Flame & Light)** *The Witness of Embers*. Any oath sworn over her shrine's flame cannot be broken; the breaker sees their own face in every wave until they drown. The Vigil swears oaths there and never breaks them.
 - **The Reckoner (Maelstraeus)** *The Ledger Keeper*. A mystery cult of coinhouse factors. They offer credit at the cost of a hidden interest that compounds in blood. The Red Vigil are their debtcollectors.
 - **The Ember Prefect (Heretic Cult)** A schism that believes the flame should not be contained. They meet in the arena hypogeum, chanting the *Unspoken Ninth Citation*. The Grand Magistrate has outlawed them three times. The Vigil has infiltrated them twice.
 - **The Velvet Mask (Livaea)** A secret society of patricians who worship pleasure as the

only truth. Their rites are said to last nine days. No one has ever left a rite unchanged. The Vigil watches their parties and reports to the Unburnt.

Lore Echoes (CrossExpansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord run a hospice in the Shatterline Bazaar. They ask no payment but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the arena slaves, trying to untie her cord from a coinhouse debt. The Vigil has her file.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the grainprefects. Take it, and your store never runs dry but the coin will reappear in the mouth of a starving child. The Red Vigil uses it to mark debtors.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Ecktorian psions are called FlameReaders. They see the future in the Everflame’s flicker. The High Priest employs three and has never trusted a forecast that didn’t smell of smoke. The Vigil employs their apprentices.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Imperial Arena is a Class IV Poltergeist site the collective rage of every gladiator who died for the crowd. Saikou Ira would ring a bell eight times and leave a wreath of laurel. The Vigil rings the bell nine times. The Arena answers.
- **The Ninth:** In any Ecktorian court, the ninth citation of precedent voids all previous. The wise stop at eight and settle. Those who cite the ninth hear a faint laughter from the marble walls and their cases are never heard again. The Vigil cites the ninth often. The laughter does not bother them.

Ecktoria Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Flame:** Crumble a crust into the Everflame. Ignore the first *Bread Riots* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Ribbon:** Tie a single knot in a coinhouse credit ribbon. Cancel *Frozen Purse* or take −1 die on your next debt roll (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Marble:** Whisper a dead debtor’s name into a statue’s ear. Gain +1 Effect when collecting from their heirs this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Grand Magistrate. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Spit on the Seal:** Before signing any contract, spit on the wax seal. If it sizzles, the Vigil has a copy. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **city guards or rival factions**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **crowds or ceremonial processions**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **patrols or inquisitors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or ceremonial opportunity**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **City authorities or noble house** becomes aware and begins responding.

- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **crowd movement or procession**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival faction member or city official** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **guards, mercenaries, or zealots** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes **procession turns violent/boundary dispute erupts/patron turns**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **High Priest, Grand Magistrate, or Duchess-Regent** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically **procession erupts/arena gate opens/monument collapses**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice **flame speaks/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Ecktoria (Marble & Fire):** Statues turn their heads, flames burn blue, ceremonial masks appear in windows.
- **Ecktoria (Procession):** Crowds chant your name, banners block your path, trumpets announce your arrival.
- **Ecktoria (Patronage):** Seals break in your hand, favors are revoked, noble houses compete for your allegiance.
- **Ecktoria (The Vigil):** A seal appears on your documents that you did not stamp. A cough from the crowd sounds like your name. Your reflection in a polished shield has a red sash.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Cross-Region Hooks (optional draws):**
 - *Aeler True Masons* bid to shore a failing aqueduct; accepting stabilizes *Aftershock* but grants them soft leverage in the ward. The Vigil audits the contract.
 - *Aelinnel Green-Market broker* offers “truthcredit” on court gossip; pay later in favors or names. The Vigil pays in silence.
 - *Black Banner retainer* parade demands back pay on the Triumph Stairs; crowd sympathy tilts your next parley. The Vigil arrests the ringleader.
- **Faction Entanglements During Travel (use en route or on city entry):**

- If the party holds any *Condotta* Diamonds, begin with *Bread Riots* at +1 segment (mercenary grain trains rerouted).
- Entering with an *Underway Pass* (Aeler) grants +1 Position on *Aqueduct Walk* scenes but ticks *Ducal Conflict* once (guild jealousy). The Vigil notes your pass.
- Carrying *Green Market* tags downgrades one *Censor’s Hall* action but flags *Inquisitorial Visit* at the next temple. The Vigil compares tags.
- **Trade Good Consequences (pick 1 when a haul sells):**
 - *Arena Steel* → street duels spike → start *Arena Spill* at 1. The Vigil collects the weapons.
 - *Relic Fragments* → basilica prestige swings → tick *Church Purge* or grant *Basilica Audience*. The Vigil inspects the relic.
 - *Survey Rights* → boundary replat → downgrade one *Border Dispute* or upgrade a rival’s. The Vigil updates the map.
- **Diplomatic Favor (minor currency):**
 - Earn by resolving a public scene without bloodshed (Forum, Procession, CoinHouse).
 - Spend 1 to reduce DV of a permit/audience by 1, or to ignore *Blocked Bridge* for one crossing.
 - Holding 2+ makes you “interesting”: start a *Red List* [4] that advances on snubbed patrons. The Vigil adds your name.
- **Reputation Echoes (soft power):**
 - *Crowd-Loved (Laurel-Deed)*: first time per session you face a mob, set Position one step safer. The Vigil watches how the mob loves you.
 - *Coin-House Trusted (Credit)*: ignore the first *Frozen Purse*; next time, it returns at +1 severity. The Vigil audits your credit.
 - *Clerically Vouched (Everflame)*: downgrade one *Inquisitorial Visit*; if abused, promote *Church Purge*. The Vigil has a copy of your voucher.

Monuments as Mechanics (opulence with teeth)

- **Processional Geometry:** When acting on the *Triumph Stairs*, choose: +1 Effect or –1 Heat; on a miss, *Rerouted Triumph* advances. The Vigil stands at the top of the stairs, watching.
- **Aqueduct Leverage:** Securing an aqueduct span grants a onescene *high ground* tag in any linked ward; if collateral hits, tick *Aftershock*. The Vigil knows where the aqueduct leaks.
- **Forum Acoustics:** Rally speeches at the *Grand Forum* grant an extra assist die if at least 20 witnesses; failure spawns *Bread Riots* at +1. The Vigil counts the witnesses.

Plug-in SB Conversions (Ecktoria flavor)

- Any 1 SB may become *Crowd Drift*: shift the scene’s terrain in favor of or against you (bridges clog, stairs clear).
- Any 2 SB may become *Seal Revoked*: void one paper (Permit/Chit/Indulgence); to avert, sacrifice *Diplomatic Favor*.
- On 3+ SB offer *Patron Bargain*: accept a visible mark (ribbon, laurel brand) to halve consequences; start a *Patron Debt* [6].

Hidden Orders & Ancient Conspiracies (d12 hooks)

1. **The Ash Senate** – a ledger of “extinguished” patrician lines still voting by proxy through funerary guilds. The Vigil has the key.
2. **Surveyors of the Ninth Mile** – decumanusmasters who can *move* boundaries with ritual math; a lost rod sets precedent across the city. The Vigil owns the rod.
3. **Lantern Tetrarchy** – four basilica beadles who decide which miracles are counted; the fifth lamp was broken in a purge. The Vigil lit the purge.
4. **The Red Marble Compact** – coinhouse founders who tithe 1 in 100 coins to a secret indemnity fund used to flip coups. The Red Vigil administers the fund.
5. **Archivum Umbrae** – censor clerks maintaining a *shadow index* of names that must not stand trial (yet). The Vigil reads the index nightly.
6. **Peregrine Brotherhood** – ferrymasters trading in sealed confessions; blackmail that floats. The Vigil buys the confessions.
7. **The Laurel of Dust** – a gladiators’ mutual that chooses which champions live long enough to hold office. The Vigil chooses the champions.
8. **Aqueduct Collegium Obscura** – engineers who keep a second set of sluice keys; droughts become elections. The Vigil has the third set.
9. **Order of the Broken Obelisk** – surveycult that believes MileZero is *wrong* and can refound the city with one stone. The Vigil has the stone.
10. **The Funeral Republic** – undertakers running a parallel courier state through catacombs and wakes. The Vigil uses their couriers.
11. **The Ember Vault** – a sealed reliquary under the Arena; victors’ sweat was bottled for augury. The Vigil broke the seal.
12. **Triumphal Maskers** – procession costumers who encode heretical theses into robe pleats and torch patterns. The Vigil decodes the theses and sometimes agrees.

Cults & Mystery Rites (d10)

1. **Children of the Phoenix** (*rebirth by fire*): ashmarks grant +1 die vs. fear in crowds; mark Fatigue if you hesitate near open flame.
2. **Verdant Laurel** (*blood to marble, sap to coin*): once/session turn 1 Harm into 1 CoinHouse Credit; start a *Green Debt* [4].
3. **Mask of the Thirteenth** (*forbidden procession step*): walk through a riot unmolested; next parley with clergy begins one step worse.
4. **Brotherhood of the River Tongue** (*truth ferried at night*): ask the Dolmis one yes/no; a ferryman shows up later to collect a name.
5. **Candlemakers of Ever** (*flame remembers lies*): blue flame points to falsehood; the liar dreams of you for three nights (Exposure +1).
6. **Sable Standard** (*war saint cult*): your banner ignores morale checks once; start a *Blood-Tithe* [4] owed to the saint’s chapel.
7. **The Ninth Bell** (*hour that is not kept*): skip a queue or sentence; next edict you need arrives late (Delay SB free once).
8. **Guild of Red Accountants** (*sin as ledger*): convert 2 SB into a *Magistrate’s Postponement*; add *Karmic Debt* [6].
9. **The Marble Eaters** (*mortification sect*): bite stone, gain +1 Effect resisting crowd crush;

take Harm 1 (Stress) if you boast.

10. **Torch of Saint Vessa** (*saint of necessary arson*): sanctify a fire to purge a tag (Plague/Corruption); City Heat +2.

Religious Schisms & Trials

The Everflame Divide (choose a live schism)

1. **Orthodox Basilica vs. Ember Reformers:** Is miracle *counted* by law or *kindled* by need?
2. **Laurel Theologians vs. Street Saints:** Does glory flow *down* from triumphs or *up* from breadlines?
3. **Iconoclast Ward vs. Reliquary Keepers:** Is the flame purer without images?

Schism Mechanics (table-facing)

- **Heresy Index** [0–6]: ticks when players publicize a stance, defy clergy, or wield cult rites in view. At 3: inquisitorial audits become common; at 6: *Church Purge* (Q) autotriggers once/session until lowered.
- **Sanctuary / Anathema Tags:** locations acquire tags during arc scenes. *Sanctuary*: first harm in scene becomes Fatigue; *Anathema*: first social miss spawns “Proscribed Sigil.”
- **Trial by Fire (miniprocedure, 3 beats):**
 1. *Assembly*: set the forum/stair as arena; state thesis in one sentence (players or NPCs).
 2. *Witness*: three proofs (relic, miracle, precedent). Each proof: test Social/Arcana/Resolve vs. crowd DV; on success, reduce Index by 1 or gain *Basilica Audience*.
 3. *Judgment*: roll Crowd Mood (1d6): 1–2 mobs, 3–4 silent acceptance, 5–6 laurel toss (gain *Laurel-Deed*). If Index ≥ 4 , –1 to the roll.

Ecktoria – Marble and Fire

Starting Location: The CoinHouse floor, marble cracked with soot lines, where votive candles burn beside melted icons.

“In Ecktoria, even faith must balance its ledgers, and the gods audit in ash.”

In... the CoinHouse floor, a factor with smokesinged ledgers offers a purse. “The Lame King moves,” she says. “And the Basilica burns with him. The Amber Palace has not answered a summons in a month. The Vigil is asking questions. I suggest you find the answers before they find you.”

Regional Motifs Coinoaths, basilica relics, marble acoustics, augury smoke, Vigil seals.

Whispers to Offer “Bid against the city,” “Pocket the relic shard,” “Name an innocent debtor,” “The Vigil’s informer sits in the corner.”

External Clocks Threat: *Procession of Ash* [6]; Community: *Credit Panic* [4]; Anchor: *Basilica Choir* [4]; Vigil: *Red List* [6].

Complications Smoke speaks truths; coins stick to skin; a reliquary runs hot; a seal appears on your documents that you did not stamp.

Anchors at Risk A choir novice; a patron account; a Vigil informer who owes you a favour.

Escalation Beat The Basilica tolls a note only one PC hears. The Vigil hears it too.

Relief Return the shard; pay a citydebt in blood or ; route the procession elsewhere; give the Vigil a name.

Boss Seeds (Cults & Conspiracies)

- **The Ember Prefect** (schismatic inquisitor): *Phase* [8] Citation → Censure → Autodafé → Purge. Lair: Everflame Cloister. Counters: relic provenance, crowdfavor, rival sermon. *Vigil twist*: The Prefect was once a Vigil informer. The Vigil knows where he hides.
- **The Surveyor-Primus** (geomantic usurper): *Phase* [6] Replat → Dispossess → Erase. Lair: MileZero. Counters: Aeler measurerods, witness line, broken rod. *Vigil twist*: The Primus has a Red Vigil agent as a protégé.
- **Phoenix of the Arena** (miracle or hoax?): *Phase* [10] Hype → Immolation → “Rebirth” → Riot. Lair: Imperial Arena. Counters: doused ash, Mask of the Thirteenth, Everflame test. *Vigil twist*: The Phoenix is a Vigil experiment. The Unburnt want to contain it. The Red Vigil wants to sell tickets.
- **The Velvet Mask** (Livaea’s cult): *Phase* [8] Invitation → Masque → Debt of Pleasure. Lair: The Amber Palace. Counters: an unbroken oath, a mirror with no reflection, a name spoken without desire. *Vigil twist*: The Vigil’s Unburnt faction attends every masque. They are not there to stop it.

Diamonds: Forbidden Leverage (add to §2.1)

14. **Shadow Index Leaf** – remove one name from the Red List for a week; add *Countercoup* +1.
15. **Ember Writ** – sanction one cult rite as “orthodox” for a scene.
16. **Surveyor’s Ninth Rod** – redraw one ward line unnoticed (until dawn).
17. **Vigil Seal (Red)** – For one scene, the Red Vigil treats you as a contractor. Interest will be collected later.

Cross-Contamination (fast ties)

- **Aeler True Masons**: backing an iconoclast audit grants shoring crews; bellcodes now gate temple entries. The Vigil has the bellcodes.
- **Aelinnel Thorn Courts**: hawthorn chaplains host “mirror sermons”; a basilica gains *Sanctuary* while a rival becomes *Anathema*. The Vigil watches both.
- **Black Banners**: warchaplains monetize indulgences; clearing *Payday* risks +1 *Heresy Index*. The Vigil takes a cut.

Patronage & Power

Ecktoria’s decline is not collapse, but transformation. Wealth bleeds into patronage webs: a senator’s indulgence, a censor’s indulgence, a noble’s purse. The city’s great houses keep mercenary captains on retainer, while priests sell ritual processions as public theater and private favor. And everywhere, the Vigil watches not to stop the rot, but to take notes.

Yet beneath the decay, two demons whisper. **Maelstraeus** teaches that every contract is a weapon, every debt a leash. **Livaea** teaches that every desire is a chain, every pleasure a payment. The patricians who once ruled the world now rule only the Amber Palace, and the Amber Palace is a gilded cage. They do not see the bread riots. They do not hear the Vigil’s footsteps. They dance. They drink. They forget that the flame remembers everything.

For the GM: Patronage should function as both opportunity and trap. Any gift (a purse, permit, or charter) binds the receiver to service, but patrons can die, fall from favor, or suddenly proscribe what they once allowed. The Vigil offers a different kind of patronage: *protection* in exchange for *information*. A party that pays the Vigil in secrets may find doors opening and other doors closing behind them. To emphasize the decadence and dread:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, ribbons, laurel crowns, Vigil marks) that can be stolen, forged, or voided.
- Let rival patrons issue conflicting "safeconducts," forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use processions, funerals, or trials as arenas for social contests, where patronage debts surface and shift allegiances.
- Introduce the **Vigil’s Faction Clock [6]** to track which Vigil faction (Censer-Knights, Unburnt, Red Vigil) has the most leverage over the party. When it fills, that faction makes a demand.

Patronage in Ecktoria is not mere background—it is the engine of politics, coin, and survival. And beneath it all, Maelstraeus and Livaea are writing a contract. The city is the collateral. The poor are the interest. The patricians are the signature—and they signed in blood long ago.

Chapter 3

Acasia

The Broken Marches.

We do not speak of the Curse. We speak around it, under it, through the gaps where words used to fit. The Curse is not a thing. It is the space where a thing used to be.

I am a charcoal-burner. My family has worked these woods for three generations. My grandfather could name every tree between the Pale Causeway and the Wolfstairs Pass. My father could read a deer's track in packed clay. I can tell you where the villages used to be. The map in my head has more empty spaces than marks.

Acasia was not always like this. Once, the granaries held grain through winter. Once, the roads carried more than ghosts and tax collectors. Then the trees started dying. Not all at once slowly, branch by branch, forest by forest. The Blackwood turned grey, then brittle, then silent. The farmers said it was a curse. The duke said it was blight. The merchants said it was the tariffs. The priests said it was the will of gods who had stopped listening.

Nobody said it was guilt. Nobody had to. Guilt is the smell of mildew on old parchment. Guilt is the way a village watches you pass without opening its gates. Guilt is the empty chair at the feast, the unmarked grave behind the chapel, the child who will not meet your eyes because their parents told them not to speak to strangers.

The truth the one we do not speak is that we could have saved the Blackwood. We saw the first trees wither. We saw the sap run black. We did nothing. We told ourselves it would pass. We told ourselves the duke would fix it. We told ourselves the forest was not our responsibility. And then the forest died, and the silence that followed was our answer.

The Curse of Acasia is not a spell. It is a memory. The land remembers what we did and what we failed to do. Every broken milestone on the old Imperial Road is a forgotten promise. Every abandoned vineyard is a harvest we chose not to plant. Every bridge that leads back to the same shore is the road we refused to take.

Never sign a contract on a bridge. The river is a witness, and it never forgets a signature. But more than that: the bridge knows when you are lying. Not to the other party. To yourself.

We are the Curse now. We carry it in our silence, in our empty fields, in the way we turn away when someone asks where the children went. Acasia is not a broken province. It is a province that broke itself, one small refusal at a time, until there was nothing left to break but the people who stayed.

And still we stay. Because leaving would mean admitting we were wrong. And that is the one thing guilt cannot bear.

Corvin, charcoal-burner of the Blackwood, who no longer names the trees because there are too few left to name

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Hardtack soaked in broth if you have broth. If not, hardtack and hope. The granaries have been empty for three winters. The merchants sell grain at famine prices. The duke says the roads are too dangerous for caravans. The farmers say the duke owns the caravans.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To name the dead. Every Acasian child has a list of ancestors they repeat at bedtime. The list gets shorter each generation. Not because children forget. Because the dead are forgetting themselves.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Whether they have a shadow. The Curse takes shadows first. A man without a shadow is not cursed—he is already gone. His body just hasn't stopped moving yet.

What is the most common crime? Bridge-toll evasion. The roads are unsafe, the ferries are unreliable, but the barons still demand payment for crossings no one can make. The crime is not in refusing to pay. The crime is in being caught trying.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Curse began with a promise broken on the Blackwood Bridge. A baron promised his daughter to a lord of the old forest. He married her to a lowland knight instead. The forest remembered. The forest is still waiting for the wedding.

Where do people go when they die? Into the Blackwood. Burial is forbidden—the ground rejects the dead. Bodies are carried to the tree-line and left. The wood takes them. Sometimes, at dusk, you can see them walking between the trunks. They do not look back.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You walk the Broken Milea stretch of road that collapsed into the river a decade ago. If you reach the far side, you are forgiven. If you fall, you were not sorry enough. No one has reached the far side in seven years.

What is the most important festival? The Counting of the Names (midwinter). Every village lists its dead aloud, from oldest to newest. If a name is forgotten, the ghost walks until someone remembers. The list grows longer each year. The memory grows shorter.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The duke's son is a ghoul. He was lost in the Blackwood as a child. They found him three days later, pale and smiling. He does not age. He does not eat. He only watches. The servants know. The servants do not speak.

3.1 Acasia — “Broken Marches”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The Empire conquered it first. The Empire left it last. Now neither remembers why.*

Margravine of the Broken March (Elite): “The tithe must be paid, not merely offered. A promise written in ash and sealed with iron will is worth more than a thousand gold coins scattered on the wind. The Empire is dead. Its debts are not.”

Hedge-Witch (Commoner): “Don’t cross the Pale Causeway at dusk, especially not if you’ve got a silver tooth. The bridge’ll remember it, and next time you pass, it’ll want more than just your footfall. In Acasia, every road has a memory. The question is who pays the toll. The Empire forgot. That’s why it fell.”

Genre / Mood: Lowfantasy wasteland, mercenary realism, cursed borderlands.

Starting Location: The Pale Causeway’s last inn, walls sootblackened by coal and a century of gossip. A bounty poster flutters beside a halfempty hearth. The innkeeper is a oneeyed woman who pours small beer without asking. A stranger at the bar offers a sealed contract: retrieve a dowry chest from a Blackwood matriarch before the Margravine’s feast day. “The chest contains a claim, not coin,” the stranger whispers. “But a claim in Acasia is worth more than gold—it is a key to a bridge that does not loop. The Empire’s surveyors marked it. Then they died.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Acasia was the first province the Uтарan Empire swallowed when it turned its eyes east. The legions marched through the Pale Causeway, crushed the hillkings, and planted their eagles in the Blackwood. For centuries, Acasia was the empire’s eastern breadbasket and its first line of defence. Grain flowed west; coin flowed east. The roads were straight, the bridges paid, and the Curse was just a farmer’s whisper.

Then the empire rotted from within. When the last Uтарan emperor died and the provinces broke away, Acasia lingered for another hundred years a ghost province whose governors still stamped Uтарan seals, whose courts still cited Uтарan law, whose coins still bore the emperor’s face. No one came from the west to collect the taxes. No one sent legions to enforce the peace. The Acasians kept the forms, because they had never learned to keep anything else. They had no native king, no unifying faith, no common tongue beyond the legionary’s Latin. They were the empire’s children, and when the empire died, they became orphans.

For a century they clung to the ruins. Then the plagues came. Then the famines. Then the Curse a slow rot of roads that led nowhere, bridges that looped back on themselves, villages that woke to find their neighbours’ houses standing empty. The old imperial surveys became maps of places that no longer existed. The grain blights turned the storehouses to dust. The free companies, once hired to keep the peace, became the only law.

That was two hundred years ago.

Now Acasia is a wound that will not close. It sits between Ecktoria to the west and Vhasia to the east, claimed by both, ruled by neither. Petty kings raise their banners in burned keeps. Free Companies trade loyalty like grain, swapping colours midmarch. The Margravine of the Broken March keeps a tally of feuds, binding bloodlines to her feast days. The Lame King travels on a throne carried by debtors, making law by pointing. And the Curse the nameless thing that makes crossroads turn back on themselves is not a myth. It is the weight

of broken promises, and Acasia is drowning in them.

South, on the marshy islands of the Amaranthine coast, the city of Silkstrand squats on reclaimed silt, trading in silk, silver, and secrets. The Acasians call it “the Sink” a place where the Curse thins, but where law is measured in coin, not custom. Few Acasians go there. Fewer return unchanged.

What you notice first: The smell of mildew on old parchment and wet ash. The way every milestone has been recarved first in Utaran, then in a halfdozen failed scripts. The silence of a village that heard you coming and chose not to open its gates.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never sign a contract on a bridge. The river is a witness, and it never forgets a signature. The Empire’s last governor signed a treaty on the PontduTithe. No one knows what it said. The bridge remembers.

Regional Mood: Famine, Ambition, and the Ghost of Empire

Here, the past is not a memory it is a predator. The Utaran Empire left behind roads that lead to nowhere, laws that contradict each other, and a hunger that no harvest can fill. Acasia’s petty kings hold court in burned keeps, their crowns forged from iron nails pulled from famine coffins. The Margravine keeps a tally of feuds, binding bloodlines to her feast days. Free Companies trade loyalty like grain, swapping colors midmarch. And beneath it all, the Curse waits. It is not a monster. It is a geometry: the wrong turn, the bridge that leads back to the same shore, the bell that tolls for no funeral. In Acasia, the land itself has become a contract, and the fine print is written in mildew.

The Curse is not ancient. It is a legacy. Some say it began with the last Imperial Survey, when the surveyors tried to map every bridge, every ford, every tolland in the measuring, broke something. Others say it was the plagues, when the dead were buried in unmarked pits and the priests forgot the proper rites. The hedgewitches say it was the empire’s own fault: they ruled Acasia for centuries but never taught the Acasians to rule themselves. When the empire left, the land had no king, no law, no memory. The Curse filled the gap.

Now the Margravine and the Lame King fight over the scraps, while free companies sell their swords to whichever claimant pays first. The hedgewitches tie red thread around bridges and leave offerings of salt at crossroads, hoping to keep the Curse from spreading. The villagers pray to saints the Empire forgot. And the roads the old imperial roads still march west toward a capital that no longer exists.

Prominent NPCs of Acasia

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Zara “the Ledger”	Margravine of the Broken March	Keep the province from fracturing completely	She has never lost a feud; her sword is also a counting rod. She claims descent from the last Utaran governor.

Oren “ <i>Tin Crown</i> ”	The Lame King	Be recognised as a true sovereign	His traveling throne is carried by debtors; he pays them in promises. His grandfather was a free company captain who declared himself king.
Ysabeau	Hedge-Witch of the Blackwood Charcoalers	Survive the Curse and keep her kin from the rope	She knows which bridges eat travellers, and her price is a story that ends badly. Her grandmother witnessed the last imperial survey.
The Bride	Dowry chest claimant (Blackwood matriarch’s heir)	Recover the chest before the Margravine’s feast day	She carries a dagger in her wedding veil. The claim is to a bridge that drowned. The bridge was built by the Utaran legions.
Vladan	Free Company Captain (“The Rusted Banner”)	Find a permanent contract before winter	He has served three kings this year. He cannot remember their names. His company’s banner is an Utaran eagle, torn and stitched.

Sister Ash	Ex-Imperial surveyor	Finish the old map of Acasia	She visits villages that no longer exist. The map shows them anyway. She carries a sealed chest of the last governor’s papers.
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Names of Acasia

Inspired by the martial duchies of a fallen southern empire: clipped Latin, warnames, and the hard consonants of mountain keeps. Many families still bear Utaranized surnames, though they have not spoken the language in generations.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Alboin	Theodelinda	da Ponte	<i>the Stiff</i>
Authari	Rosamund	del Ferro	<i>the Toll-Fist</i>
Liutprand	Gundiberga	di Rocca	<i>Bridge-Born</i>
Desiderius	Anspranda	Longobardus	<i>Blackwood</i>
Ratchis	Veleda	Saxo	<i>the Unremembered</i>
Aistulf	Gisela	Capoferro	<i>Ash-Finger</i>

(Pass/Ruin/TollTown) Broken milestone on the old Imperial Road; borders “moved” overnight. Vineterrace hillside with an abandoned press; strangler ivy owns it now.

Spades — Places

2. Broken Milestone

[RUIN] [OMEN]

On the old Imperial Road; borders “moved” overnight.

The stone has been chiseled seven times. The last mark is still wet. The first was cut by Utaran legionaries.

3. Vine-Terrace Hillside

[RUIN] [HARVEST]

Abandoned press; strangler ivy owns it now.

The ivy has grown around a skeleton. The skeleton still holds a wine cup. The vintage was the year the last governor left.

4. Toll-Bridge Town

[TOLL] [BOUNDARY]

Over a cold river; two tolls, no receipts.

The second toll is collected by a child. The child does not speak. The bridge was built by the legions. It remembers their footsteps.

5. Wolfstairs Pass

[MOUNTAIN] [AMBUSH]

Switchbacks beneath a stonefall cliff.

The stones were placed by a landslide that knew your name. The pass was the empire's eastern gate. No army has crossed it in a century.

6. **Sootfall Abbey Ruins** [RUIN] [DEATH]

Bell tower intact; crypts breathing.

The breathing is a prayer. The monks are still down there. They have been praying for the empire's soul for two hundred years.

7. **Hill-Motte** [FORTIFICATION] [WAR]

Fresh palisade; ditch scattered with caltrops.

The caltrops are from a siege that ended last week. The bodies are still rotting. The siege was over a bridge toll. The bridge has not collected in fifty years.

8. **Border-Stone Ring** [BOUNDARY] [OMEN]

Carved with seven crowns; each points wrong.

The crowns belong to kings who never existed. The stones remember them anyway. The eighth crown was the empire's. It is not carved. It is implied.

9. **Blackwood Charcoalers' Hollow** [FOREST] [WITCHCRAFT]

Witchposts at every path.

The witchposts were made from the gibbets of tax collectors. The tax collectors still swing. They were collecting for the empire. They have not stopped.

10. **Salt-Road Ford** [RIVER] [DEATH]

Rains expose old bones in the chalk banks.

The bones are from three wars. They are not all human. The ford was the empire's salt route. The salt is still in the water.

J **Iron Mine Adits** [UNDERGROUND] [WHISPERS]

Held by a miners' commune; the air is full of whispers.

The whispers are the mine's memory. It remembers every collapse. The last collapse was the year the empire fell. The miners are still digging.

Q **Margravine's Hunting Lodge** [NOBLE] [SECRETS]

Tapestries of victories that never were.

The tapestries were woven by a blind weaver. The threads are from her own hair. The victories are Utaran. The weaver was Acasian.

K **War-Camp City** [WAR] [REFUGE]

Tents around a burned keep; every banner claims the throne.

The keep was burned by its own lord. He did not want to share the heat. The lord was the last imperial governor. He died in the fire.

A **The Pale Causeway** [ROAD] [CURSE]

The last high road that survives the spring thaws.

The causeway is made of bones. The bones are from the workers who built it. The workers were Acasian. The empire paid them in promises.

(Petty Crowns/Priests/Companies) Tithecollector's runner with a tallyrod and an empty stomach; roadside prior with three lay brothers guarding a relic.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Tithe-Collector's Runner** [AUTHORITY] [HUNGER]

Tallyrod, empty stomach, and a list of names.

His tallyrod has notches from a dozen villages. The villages are now empty. He collects for the Margravine. She does not ask where the grain goes.

3. **Roadside Prior** [FAITH] [RELIC]
 Three lay brothers guarding a relic.
The relic is a finger bone. The prior claims it belonged to a saint who starved to death. The saint was an Uтарan missionary. The Acasians ate his offerings.
4. **Hedge-Witch** [WITCHCRAFT] [KNOWLEDGE]
 Knows which bridges eat travelers.
Her price is a story. The story must have a bad ending. She has heard all the good ones. The bridges listen when she speaks.
5. **Free Company Captain** [MERCENARY] [FATIGUE]
 Pike and shot between contracts.
He has served three kings this year. He does not remember their names. His first contract was with a man who called himself emperor. The man is dead. The contract is not.
6. **River Reeve** [LAW] [CORRUPTION]
 Rents every boat twice.
His paper is a single page folded into a boat. The other half is elsewhere. The other half is in the Margravine’s counting house. She does not know.
7. **Salt-Baron** [TRADE] [VIOLENCE]
 Hired blades; owns the ford and your timetable.
His salt is grey. It was cut with ashes from a burned village. The village refused to pay the imperial salt tax. The empire is dead. The salt is not.
8. **Blackwood Matriarch** [NOBLE] [VENGEANCE]
 Tends the feud like a garden.
Her garden grows tombstones. She waters them with tears—her enemies’. Her grandmother was the last Acasian to hold an imperial title. The empire took it back. She has not forgotten.
9. **Ex-Imperial Surveyor** [KNOWLEDGE] [LONELINESS]
 Has the last accurate map.
The map shows villages that no longer exist. The surveyor visits them anyway. She leaves offerings of bread and ink. The ghosts do not eat. They watch.
10. **“King” of Three Villages** [CLAIMANT] [IRON]
 Ironnail crown, ironwill taxes.
His crown was a plowshare. He reversed the curse. The curse reversed back. He does not know.
- J **Bride with No Dowry but a Claim** [CLAIM] [DESPERATION]
 Daggers in the wedding chest.
The claim is to a bridge that drowned. The bride intends to collect. The bridge was built by the legions. The legions are gone. The bridge is not.
- Q **Margravine of the Broken March** [AUTHORITY] [FEUD]
 Half saint, half tax roll.
She has never lost a feud. Her tally stick is her sword. Her greatgreatgrandfather was the last imperial governor’s clerk. He stole the seal. She still has it.
- K **The Lame King** [CLAIMANT] [FATIGUE]
 Traveling throne; makes law by pointing.
His throne is a sedan chair carried by debtors. They owe him everything. He owes the Margravine a bridge toll. He has not paid. The bridge remembers.

A The Cursed Child of Silkstrand

[MYTH] [OMEN]

A rumor more than a person; her laughter ends sieges.

She is said to be twelve years old. She has been twelve for a century. She was born on the day the last imperial governor died. She does not age. She does not forget.

(Feud/Levy/Weather/Curse) Peatfog; all horns sound like someone calling your name. Sudden levy—every traveler pressed for a day’s service. Bridge feud; rival banners drop the chain on your cart.

Clubs — Complications/Threats**2. Peat-Fog**

[WEATHER] [FEAR]

All horns sound like someone calling your name.

The name is not yours. Answer it, and the fog will take you. The fog is the empire’s last breath.

3. Sudden Levy

[AUTHORITY] [TIME]

Every traveler is pressed for a day’s service.

The levy master has a list. Your name is on it—in fresh ink. The list was copied from an imperial tax roll. The roll is two hundred years old.

4. Bridge Feud

[BOUNDARY] [VIOLENCE]

Rival banners drop the chain on your cart.

The chain was forged from a broken oath. It rattles when liars approach. The oath was sworn to the emperor. The emperor is dead. The chain does not care.

5. Grain Blight

[HARVEST] [FEAR]

Doubles the tithe; refusal means torches at night.

The blight has a face. It is the face of a tax collector who died hungry. The collector worked for the empire. The empire did not pay him.

6. Scree Slide

[MOUNTAIN] [BLOCKED]

Seals the pass; the “safe” detour is owned by your enemy.

The enemy raised the toll yesterday. He was expecting you. The pass was the empire’s eastern gate. It still remembers the legions.

7. Wedding Turns Ambush

[SOCIAL] [TRAP]

You are caught between two bloodlines.

The bride’s veil is a shroud. The groom’s ring is a knife. The feud began when the empire divided the valley. The valley has not healed.

8. Witch’s Tithe Night

[WITCHCRAFT] [DEBT]

Lights move in the woods; owe nothing or else.

The lights have voices. They are arguing over who should collect. They are the ghosts of imperial tax collectors. They have not stopped working.

9. Pox Sign

[DISEASE] [ISOLATION]

On a village gate; your escorts desert you.

The pox is a rumor. The desertion is real. The pox came with the last imperial supply train. The supply train never arrived.

10. Condotta Breaks

[MERCENARY] [BETRAYAL]

The Free Company flips colors midmarch.

The new colors are the same as the old colors. The captain just wanted to raise morale. He was

hired by the Margravine. He was also hired by the Lame King. He is collecting both salaries.

J Heretic Preacher [FAITH] [RIOT]

Sparks a march; tollgates come down in splinters.

The preacher’s text is a tax receipt. He reads it like scripture. The receipt was issued by the empire. It is still valid. No one knows to whom.

Q Imperial Pretender [CLAIMANT] [POLITICS]

Arrives; every petty lord changes tabards.

The pretender’s seal is a sunburst. The sunburst is slightly crooked. The seal was stolen from the last governor’s tomb. The governor’s ghost is following him.

K River Overruns the Levee [WEATHER] [DESTRUCTION]

The pontoon goes; your rivals don’t.

The river’s name is “Debt.” It remembers every unpaid crossing. The empire’s engineers built the levees. They calculated the flood levels. They did not calculate the Curse.

A The Curse Stirrs [CURSE] [TRAP]

No matter the road, you return to the same crossroads.

The crossroads has a signpost. The arms are labeled “Regret,” “Hunger,” “The Same.” The post was planted by the last imperial surveyor. She is still walking.

(Papers/Claims/SafeConduct) Tollexemption plaque for one bridge (once); monastery letter for bed and bread on a named road.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. Toll-Exemption Plaque [TRAVEL] [ONCE]

For one bridge (once).

The plaque is a bronze leaf. Hold it up, and the tollkeeper will spit—but step aside. The leaf was minted by the empire. The empire’s mines are closed. The metal is still good.

3. Monastery Letter [HOSPITALITY] [ONCE]

For bed and bread on a named road.

The letter is sealed with a wax tear. The monks will honor it—or they will not. The abbot was an imperial clerk. He still follows the old forms.

4. Wine-Right [TRADE] [ONGOING]

On an abandoned terrace; locals will work for shares.

The wine is from a vine that grows over a mass grave. It tastes of iron. The grave holds the last imperial garrison. They were paid in promises.

5. Condotta Contract [MERCENARY] [ONCE]

A signed pike contract (one battle on your terms).

The contract is written in blood. The blood is from the captain’s own finger. The contract was copied from an imperial legionary oath. The words have changed. The weight has not.

6. Tithe-Remission Writ [AUTHORITY] [ONCE]

For a village; they owe you a season’s labor.

The writ is stamped with a bell. The bell’s clapper is a finger bone. The bell was cast from melted imperial coinage. The coinage was debased. The bell rings true.

7. Border-Stone Adjustment [BOUNDARY] [ONCE]

Move a line two fields over.

The adjustment is a lie. The truth is that the line was always there. The line was surveyed by

the empire's best geometers. They are all dead. Their measurements are not.

8. **Pass-Key Charm** [TRAVEL] [ONGOING]

Recognized by Pale Causeway watchmen.

The charm is a knotted cord. Untie it to pass—or to stay. The cord was tied by an imperial courier. The courier's route was swallowed by the Curse. The cord remembers the way.

9. **Sealed Dowry Chest** [CLAIM] [MYSTERY]

Of claims, not coin; certain doors open.

The chest is locked with a riddle. The answer is a name you do not know. The name is the last imperial governor's. He wrote it on the inside. He is the only one who has seen it.

10. **Mine-Share** [RESOURCE] [ALLIANCE]

In the commune; they fight like they mean it.

The share is a pickaxe. The commune will lend you a miner—or a grave. The mine was opened by the empire's first surveyors. They found iron. They also found something else. They did not name it.

J **Blood-Peace Charter** [SOCIAL] [TRUCE]

Suspend a feud long enough to move your wagons.

The charter is a white ribbon. Blood will not be spilled while it flies—but blood will remember. The ribbon was woven by a hedgewitch. She used thread from a tax collector's uniform. The collector is dead. The thread is not.

Q **Marriage Proxy** [SOCIAL] [ALLIANCE]

From the Margravine; bind a hillking to your cause.

The proxy is a wedding veil. The veil was worn by a ghost. The ghost was the Margravine's grandmother. She married an imperial legate. The legate never came home.

K **The Lame King's Traveling Writ** [AUTHORITY] [ONCE]

Troops must make way (for now).

The writ is a broken scepter. The Lame King's seal is a footprint. The footprint was pressed into wax by his grandfather. The grandfather was a free company captain. He could not write. He used his boot.

A **Curse-Redemption Rite (Temporary)** [RITUAL] [ONCE]

For one night, no crossroads can hold you.

The rite is a whisper. The whisper is a name you have never spoken. The name is the Curse's. It does not want to be spoken. It does not want to be silent. It wants to be paid.

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (papers/claims/safeconducts) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo plague and curse motifs—crossroads that turn back on themselves, bells tolling for no funeral, banners blackened by mildew, the ghost of the empire in every milestone.

Additional Features

- **Feud as Currency:** Any insult, accident, or rumor can birth a feud; the GM may replace an SB result with a feudtoken tied to a petty lord or house. Feudtokens act as reusable complications: once per scene, the GM can spend a feudtoken to have a rival appear, a bridge close, or a village refuse aid.
- **Rot & Tithe:** Each market or harvest scene carries a risk of rot—add a pressure if food or coin are exchanged without a blessing or a seal. A failed roll may double the tithe or spoil stored supplies.
- **The Curse Remembers:** When roads or negotiations stall, the GM may quietly repeat imagery—crossroads, whispers, mildew—to remind players that Acasia itself resists resolution. If the party ignores three such omens, the *Curse Stirrs* complication triggers automatically.
- **Empire’s Ghost:** Any ancient imperial structure (milestone, bridge, fortress) may still be haunted by the echo of its original purpose. A character who makes an offering (a coin, a salute, a whispered oath) may gain +1 die on a single roll within sight of that structure. The offering must be sincere. The empire does not accept bribes. It accepts memory.

Lore Echoes (CrossExpansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord run a hospice in a burned abbey. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the charcoalers, trying to untie her cord from a Rothari death warrant. She says the empire’s last debt is still unpaid.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Pale Causeway is a Class II Anchor site—the ghosts of workers who died building it still carry stones. Saikou Ira would leave a silver coin in every crack. The workers do not spend the coins. They stack them. They are building something.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the tollcollectors. Take it, and your passage is always free—but the coin will taste of blood every time the Causeway floods. The coin was minted in the empire’s last year. The emperor’s face is worn smooth.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Acasian psions are called “FeudReaders.” They taste the weight of old grudges in the water. The Margravine employs two—and has never trusted a settlement they didn’t whisper. They say the Curse is not a thing. It is a conversation. The empire is still talking.
- **The Ninth:** In any Acasian scene, the ninth toll paid at a bridge is never the last. The wise pay eight and barter for the ninth. The ninth toll is collected by a child with no name. The child is the Curse’s accountant.

Acasian Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Milestone:** Crumble a crust at a broken milestone. Ignore the first *Peat-Fog* penalty.
- **Knot the Contract:** Tie a single knot in a writ’s ribbon. Cancel *Bridge Feud* or take –1 die on your next negotiation (your choice).
- **Name to the Blight:** Whisper a dead tax collector’s name into a grain sack. Gain +1 Effect when avoiding tithes this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Margravine.

Decline & Patronage

Patronage here is as brittle as candle wax. The Rothari Clan holds their marches by fear and iron law—patronage from them is real, but cruel, demanding service in blood or levy. Elsewhere, noble names are little more than titles printed on parchment and sold like promises. The Margravine keeps a tally of feuds, binding bloodlines to her feast days, while mercenary captains trade loyalty for coin, switching colors with each bell.

To seek a patron in Acasia is to choose which hunger you will feed: the Rothari's iron teeth, a Free Company's purse, or the hollow blessing of a saint who may never have lived. Yet even false crowns cast shadows long enough to shelter those desperate enough to kneel. The empire is dead. Its debts are not. And the Curse is patient.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **tithe-collectors or petty lords**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **Free Company patrols or village watchmen**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **feud-trackers or hedge-witches**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable road conditions**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **River reeve or Free Company captain** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **fog or bridge closure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival bloodline or toll-lord's enforcer** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **feudkin, Free Company deserters, or Margravine's guards** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **contract voided/levy doubled/curse triggered**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Margravine, Lame King, or Cursed Child** intervenes.

- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **fog thickens/bridge falls/curse loops**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Acasia (Feud & Tithe):** Toll collectors demand double, bloodlines take offense, wagons are seized as “payment.”
- **Acasia (Rot & Famine):** Grain blights spread, wells run dry, abandoned villages hold only ghosts.
- **Acasia (Curse & Crossroads):** Roads loop back, milestones point the wrong way, the same bridge appears twice.
- **Acasia (Empire’s Ghost):** A phantom legionary marches past, an imperial seal glows on a broken stone, a tax collector’s ghost demands arrears.

Boss Archetypes in Acasia

- **The False King (Feud/Authority)** — A petty lord or pretender who crowns themselves on the ruins of empire. *Phases:* Levy Demanded → Feud Declared → Hasty Coronation. *Cracks:* a **Blood-Peace Charter** suspends his authority; a **Marriage Proxy** binds him to a rival.
- **The Witch of the Blackwoods (Witchcraft/Curse)** — A hedgewitch, matriarch, or revenant who manipulates feuds and curses. *Phases:* Tithe of Fear → Curse of the Crossroads → Hollow Wedding. *Cracks:* a **Curse-Redemption Rite** breaks her hold; a **Mine-Share** gives the commune courage to defy her.
- **The Tithe Collector (Greed/Extortion)** — A bureaucratpriest with writs, escorts, and the ability to summon feuds or famine with a single decree. *Phases:* Audit of Souls → Seizure of Grain → The Reckoning. *Cracks:* a **Toll-Exemption Plaque** voids his claim; a **Wine-Right** buys off his debtors.
- **The Rotting Child (Mystery/Curse)** — A folkloric horror tied to Acasia’s plague of false crossroads. *Phases:* Laughter in the Fog → The Bridge That Loops → The Feast of Ends. *Cracks:* a **Tithe-Remission Writ** fed to the fog; a **Monastery Letter** read aloud at the crossroads.
- **The Imperial Ghost (Undead/Precedent)** — The shade of the last imperial governor, still trying to collect the taxes. *Phases:* Audit of the Damned → Summon the Debtors → The Emperor’s Peace. *Cracks:* produce the original imperial charter (in the Sealed Dowry Chest), pay a wergild in the empire’s own debased coinage, or convince the ghost that the empire is truly dead.

Encounter Seeds (Quick Hooks)

- **The Dowry That Walked:** A Blackwood matriarch’s dowry chest has been stolen. The chest contains a claim to a bridge that never floods—and a curse that the Margravine wants broken. The chest was last seen in the hands of a free company captain who claims he is the heir to the empire.

- **The Lame King's Feast:** The Lame King invites the party to a feast. The feast is a trial. The food is memory. The wine is lies. The king wants to know who killed the last imperial surveyor. The surveyor is sitting at the table.
- **The Curse of the Pale Causeway:** The Causeway is repeating. Every crossing brings the party back to the same inn. The innkeeper is missing a finger. She says she gave it to the bridge. The bridge wants more. The bridge remembers the empire's last toll.

Chapter 4

Vhasia

The Fractured Sun.

Two crowns. One kingdom. A river so wide it might as well be a border and oh, how the crowns love pretending it's not.

I am a Road Warden. I have served under three different banners on this same stretch of road, and the only constant is that someone always wants to collect tolls. The Northern Seigneurie and the Southern Parlement both claim the throne, both flood the river with paperwork to "prove" their right, and both are too busy arguing over seal wax colours to notice that the Fenwoods already burned Lence, and the Sun-court is a memory.

The Last Dauphin? A rumour. But rumours pay well when you're the one who started them and I started three: that he was swapped at birth with a goatherd's child, that he's secretly a Veiled Sister in disguise, and that he's been dead for ten years, his "reappearance" a puppet show run by the Seigneurie's spymaster.

Never carry a coin that bears only one sunburst. The realm has three mints, and the wrong metal on the wrong road is treason.

Road Warden Cerran, who has not slept in two days and is not sure which crown he serves

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Dark bread and watered wine the wine cuts the dust from the road. The nobility eat spiced eggs and fresh cheese, but they eat behind closed doors. To eat well in public is to invite envy. Envy is a dagger.

What does a child learn before they can walk? Which colours not to wear. Black and gold are the Northern Crown's colours. Red and silver are the Southern Parlement's. A child

who wears the wrong colour to the wrong village may not return home.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Which side of the road they walk on. The north side is the Crown's. The south side is the Parlement's. The middle is no man's land literally. Bandits, spies, and messengers use the middle. So do ghosts.

What is the most common crime? Raiding across the Belworth. The river is the border, the border is a suggestion, and the suggestion is enforced by armed men on both sides. The crime is not in raiding. The crime is in being caught on the wrong bank at dawn.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Sun-court was not burned. It was bankrupted. The Fenwoods did not sack Lencethey bought it. Every judge, every clerk, every guard captain had a price. The Fenwoods paid it. The Vhasians are still paying interest.

Where do people go when they die? To the crypts beneath the Sun-court if they can afford a plaque. The poor are buried in unmarked graves along the Belworth floodplain. The river floods every spring. The dead wash downstream, into the land of the other crown. Neither side claims them.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a chevauchée a raiding party that burns a village in your name. The apology is not in the burning. The apology is in the promise that the village will be rebuilt with your own hands. If you burn a village and do not rebuild, you have not apologized. You have started a feud.

What is the most important festival? The Sun-return (spring equinox). Both crowns claim the sun as their symbol. On this day, both hold processions. The processions are identical. The participants do not acknowledge each other. The sun does not care.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Queen-Mother has no claim to the regency. Her son is not the Dauphin. The real Dauphin died in childbirth. The Queen-Mother's daughter was stillborn. The child on the throne is a foundling, bought from a Tulkani caravan. The Tulkani know. The Tulkani are still waiting to be paid.

4.1 Vhasia “The Fractured Sun”

Cardinal-Regent of the Broken Sun (Elite): “The sun may be fractured, but our authority is absolute within our domains. Every coin minted here carries our blessing, and every law written bears our seal the rest is just politics.”

Road Warden (Commoner): “I’ve served under three different banners on this same stretch of road, and the only constant is that someone always wants to collect tolls. My horn calls honest warning best heed it. The Fenwoods burned Lence, and now every duke with a coin purse thinks he’s king.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Vhasia is a realm of broken coronations and split loyalties. Once a proud province of the Utaran empire, the unified Suncourt shattered like its heraldic sunburst when the Fenwoods of Viterra and their allies sacked the capital of Lence and cast down the old Blood line. Now rival dukes, duchesses, abbesses, and parlements claim the fractured light. Everywhere, signs of fracture: chipped sundiscs on milestones, worn tabards bearing half a crown, coins minted in rival cities with different suns. In Vhasia, legitimacy is as fragile as a mirror, and every oath risks breaking along the fault lines of politics, faith, and fortune.

What you notice first: The smell of old smoke and fresh ink. The way every noble’s seal has a hairline crack. The constant, nervous laughter of courtiers who remember whose head rolled last season.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never carry a coin that bears only one sunburst. The realm has three mints, and the wrong metal on the wrong road is treason.

Regional Mood: Crowns, Courts, and Companies

Here, the past is a weapon and the future is a debt. The Fenwoods came from Viterra with fire and iron, broke the Sunking’s army at the Ford of Ashes, and burned Lence until the mirrors melted. They left the throne empty not destroyed, but open. Now every duke with a long purse and a short conscience backs a claimant. The QueenMother weaves alliances from her riverside keep. The Two Crowns rival dukes crowned in rival cathedrals march their levies through fields that can feed neither. Routiers sell their swords by the season, and parlement clerks drown justice in procedure. Vhasia is not a nation at war. It is a nation that forgot how to be at peace.

Starting Location: The PontduTithe, its golden arches catching fire in the sunset as pilgrims chant from both banks. A Duchy Constable in splendid armor guards the toll gate. “The Chevauchee burns,” he says, gesturing to distant smoke. “Two Crowns march to meet it. Whose seal do you carry? Speak quickly the levy waits for no one.”

Prominent NPCs of Vhasia

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
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Elianor Everblood	QueenMother (née Longblood) of Ethor	Restore her son Valdaïs to the throne	She has outlived three husbands and two sons; she is not mourning.
Valdaïs Longblood	Duke of Adria, claimant to the Suncourt	Unite Vhasia under a strong northern crown	He has never lost a joust. His opponents have a habit of falling ill before the tilt.
The Red Marshal	Exiled commander of the Suncourt's army	Win back Lence or die trying	He lost the Battle of Ashes; he still sees it in his dreams and his nightmares.
Seint Michel's Justiciar	Magistrate of the Order of the Gilded Scale	Enforce the chivalric code without mercy	He carries a scale with one pan empty; the empty pan is for lies.
Sister Oria	Custodian of the Lantern Rites House on the Belworth	Keep the rites of hospitality and witness	She has never drawn a blade. She has never needed to.
The Cantor Alain	Iron Bard, bearer of the Cracked Ring	Sing the truth of Corin's mercy before the armor closes again	Feathers grow from his temples; his shadow moves a halfstep behind him.

Names of Vhasia

Inspired by the fractured duchies: Francien, Norman, and Brittonic influences. Soft vowels, silent consonants, and surnames that recall a bridge, a ford, or a stained banner.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Valdaïs	Elianor	de la Marche	<i>the Iron</i>
Renaud	Isabeau	de Lence	<i>the Unbuckled</i>
Corin	Oria	d'Aethor	<i>BellSworn</i>
Touénot	Mael	du Pont	<i>the Silver</i>
Alain	Giselle	de la Croix	<i>AshBanner</i>

Ghiro	Celandine	l’Argent	<i>the Unpaid</i>
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Spades Places

(Château/Cathedral/Forest) Wayside shrine with pilgrims tacking petitions to a scorched sundisc; vineterraced clos above a millstream with napping watchmen.

2. **Wayside Shrine** — Pilgrims tack petitions to a scorched sundisc; each parchment curls in different winds. *The petitions are never answered. The shrine is a mailbox for the dead.*
3. **Vine-Terrace** — Clos above a millstream; watchmen nap, halberds traded for bottles. *The best vintage is called “Crownbreaker.” It tastes like smoke and regret.*
4. **Bastide Square** — Neat as a checkerboard; merchants pay homage to different “hours” of the Sun. *The square has a gallows. It rotates to face whichever claimant lost the last duel.*
5. **Royal Forest** — Antler posts mark laws no king remembers; poachers still hang. *The forest’s deer have grown bold. They wear crowns of shed antlers.*
6. **Pont-du-Tithe** — Tollbridge flanked by chapels and crossbows; chains blessed by rival bishops. *The chains were forged from melted sunbursts. They ring in different keys.*
7. **Great Fair** — Outside a chartered town; counting sheds ring like bells, rumors louder still. *The fair has a Court of Miracles where counterfeiters sell to informers.*
8. **Salt Pans** — Windpumps on an estuary; gulls own the law, smugglers own the night. *The salt is grey. It tastes of old tears and older debts.*
9. **Siege-Château** — Hoardings patched, cistern low, banners cut into ragged suns. *The banner’s ragged edges are from a Fenwood sword. The owner still limps.*
10. **Cathedral Yard** — Cranes creak, stones fly, scaffolds bristle with rival masons’ marks. *The mason’s marks are clan signs. A scratchedout mark means a dead foreman.*
- J **Parlement Hall** — Hung with faded tapestries; sunbursts spliced and restitched by claimants. *The tapestries show battles that never happenedand some that shouldn’t have.*
- Q **Queen’s Causeway** — Milelong oath paved in quarried stone; halfsunken each spring. *The sunken half is a graveyard for vows. The stones are slippery with old lies.*
- K **Sun Palace (Lence)** — Shattered mirrors, brambled gardens; courtiers playing at kingship. *The mirrors were covered after the sack. No one wants to see what they show now.*
- A **King’s High Road** — Milestones chipped of crowns; yet every army still marches it. *The road is paved with the bones of tax collectors. They are not missed.*

Hearts People & Factions

(Lord/Court/Company) Road warden with dented badge and honest horn; vintnerguild syndic counting saints’ days as credit terms.

2. **Road Warden** — Dented badge, honest horn; ignored by both crowns but knows the roads. *His horn is cracked. It still soundsbut the note is always half a step flat.*
3. **Vintner Syndic** — Counts saints’ days as credit terms, vintages as treaties; wine as diplomacy. *He keeps a bottle of Crownbreaker in every cellar. He knows which vintage each duke prefers.*
4. **Abbess-Chatelaine** — Rules a fortressconvent with iron accounts and sharper scripture. *She has never drawn a blade. The scaffold has, on her orders.*

5. **Routier Captain** — Scarred and mercenary; prefers ransoms to loyalty; coin as conscience. *He switches banners as often as his shirt. His loyalty is to the paychest and his mother.*
6. **Duchy Constable** — Splendid armor, empty coffers, pride swollen as a banner; glory over gold. *His armor was his grandfather's. It still has the dent from a Fenwood axe.*
7. **Parlement Clerk** — Drowns foes in procedure, fishes them out for fealty; law as a weapon. *His quill is a dagger. He sharpens it every morning.*
8. **Salt-Farmer** — Gabelle lessee with cudgels, writs, and a riverchart no crown has; tax as tyranny. *His ledger is written in salt. One drop of water and the debts vanish along with the evidence.*
9. **Trouvère** — A scandalous lay about the last Sunking brings knives to tavern doors. *He sings the truth. That is why he sleeps in a different inn every night.*
10. **Marshal-Exile** — The Suncourt's hammer; now wielded by whoever pays in silver. *He lost the Battle of Ashes. He still sees it in his dreams and his nightmares.*
- J **Heretic Perfect** — Preaches peace while tucking hidden daggers into parchment margins. *His sermon is a code. The psalms tell you which bridge to cross and which to burn.*
- Q **Queen-Mother** — Riverside keep; weaves alliances as if they were dowers. *She has outlived three husbands and two sons. She is not mourning.*
- K **Two Crowns** — Rival dukes, each "crowned" in rival cathedrals, neither whole. *One wears a crown of iron. The other wears a crown of words. Both rust.*
- A **Last Dauphin** — A rumor with a birthmark; armies march for whispers alone. *He may be a baker's son. The armies don't care. They need a sun to follow.*

Clubs Complications/Threats

(Chevauchée/Law/Church) Chevauchée burning loyalty oaths as well as barns; smoke curls like scripture. Interdict falls on a county; bells silenced, trade stalls.

2. **Chevauchée** [WAR] [RAID] — Raiders burn loyalty oaths as well as barns; smoke curls like scripture. *The raiders wear no colors. Their horses answer to whistles and grudges.*
3. **Interdict** [RELIGIOUS] [LEGAL] — Falls on a county; bells silenced, trade stalls, heretics prosper. *The bells were melted for shot three wars ago. The silence is old.*
4. **Forest Law** [LEGAL] [HUNT] — Venison becomes treason; poachers hang from antler posts. *The antler posts are carved with the names of the hanged. They whisper at dusk.*
5. **River Spate** [WEATHER] [DELAY] — Ferries chained, bridges drowned, pilgrims stranded midprayer. *The water is the color of old gold. It washed away a mint last spring.*
6. **Coin Debasement** [ECONOMY] [LEGAL] — Three mints, three suns, no trust; soldiers demand silver alone. *The silver is from the same mine but the stamp is a prayer, not a promise.*
7. **Parlement Divided** [LEGAL] [POLITICS] — A siege laid on parchment before walls; war by paperwork. *The clerks duel with citations. The loser pays the winner's ink bill.*
8. **Company Mutiny** [WAR] [MERCENARY] — Unless arrears are paid in blood or coin; mercenaries as a time bomb. *The mutineers have a list. Your name is on it or will be by nightfall.*
9. **Relic Dispute** [RELIGIOUS] [LEGAL] — Two abbeys claim the same saint's bones; mobs answer with stones. *The bones are actually from a cow. The saints don't mind. They like the attention.*

10. **Harvest Blight** [ECONOMY] [WEATHER] — Bread locked behind pikes; bakers guarded as lords. *The blight has a name. It is the name of a duke who raised the levy too late.*
- J **Tournament “Accident”** [CHIVALRY] [ASSASSINATION] — Hides an assassination; your favor is now evidence. *The lance was filed with a prayer. The prayer was answered but not for the target.*
- Q **Royalist Restoration** [POLITICS] [FEAR] — Sunburst badges painted overnight on doors and graves. *The paint is the color of dried blood. The badges face the wrong direction.*
- K **Feudal Levy** [WAR] [LEGAL] — Lords demand levies in days, not months, with three days’ bread. *The bread is hardtack from the last Fenwood siege. It still smells of smoke.*
- A **Winter Campaign** [WEATHER] [WAR] — Roads turn to mud, hooves to ice, armies to ruin. *The snow is grey with ash. The Pass of Ashes has a sister pass now.*

Diamonds Rewards/Leverage

(**Charter/Patent/Right**) Safeconduct sealed by a duke or abbey; honored only once, on one road; burgess charter for a market ward.

2. **Safe-Conduct** *The seal is cracked. The road is watched. Use it before the seal breaks.*
3. **Burgess Charter** *The charter is a bell. Ring it, and the town answers or it doesn’t.*
4. **Bridge Farm** — Tolls at PontduTithe for a season, if you can hold it. *The tollkeepers are loyal to the last coin. Yours or theirs.*
5. **Paréage Charter** — Shared rule with a monastery half justice, half rent, no peace. *The monks pray for you. They also pray for your enemies. Balance.*
6. **Wardship** — Over a minor heir; lands obey you “for now.” *The heir has a knife. He knows how to use it. He learned from watching you.*
7. **Gabelle Lease** — Saltax rights; lucrative, hated, and dangerous. *The lease is a death warrant written in profit. Cash it wisely.*
8. **Letters Patent** — Raise a free company under your banner; an army as a business. *The letters are signed in bloody yours or the notary’s. Both are valid.*
9. **Remission** — Of feudal dues for a village; they’ll march when called. *The village has a long memory. They remember the last lord who promised mercy.*
10. **Low-Justice** — Grant (stocks, fines, gallows) in a troublesome hamlet. *The gallows rope is new. The notches are from the last hamlet.*
- J **Confiscation Writ** — Against a royalist estate if you can seize it first. *The writ is a race. The other claimant rides a faster horse.*
- Q **Queen’s Audience** — Private with the Queen Mother; a whisper becomes policy. *The audience is a chess game. She always wins but she lets you take a pawn.*
- K **Sunburst Warrant** — Of the fallen court most still bow if shown boldly. *The warrant is a ghost. It has no power only the power of belief.*
- A **General Pardon** — Temporary: rebels absolved if they bend the knee. *The pardon is a spring. It will close when the season turns.*

Quick Use Notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (charters/patents/rights) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **fractured sun** motifs: light that splinters, oaths that crack like glass.

Additional Features

Fractured Seals: When brandishing a writ, badge, or charter tied to a Suncourt claimant, step Position up one step for the scene’s next interaction at a gate, court, or checkpoint. Each use advances a **Legitimacy** [4] clock linked to the claimant; when it fills, rivals challenge the authority on sight.

Parlement Games: If a scene touches petitions, guild disputes, or feudal appeals, the first Diamond played becomes a policy lever: treat it as two Diamonds toward swaying a decision or rewriting a custom. Afterward, start or advance a **Whispered Precedent** clock; when it fills, backlash spreads as other courts cite the case against you.

Gabelle Knife-Edge: At bridges, fairs, or salt depots, convert Diamonds tied to tolls, leases, or safeconducts into immediate passage or tariff relief for the company (no roll). Each conversion ticks a **Resentment** [4] clock for the locale; when it completes, expect boycotts, ambush rumors, or an audit by rival officials.

Vhasian Chivalry & the Round of Five Virtues: The knights of the western cantons (Ethor, Adria) follow the Round of Five Virtues: **Courage, Courtesy, Mercy, Prowess, Truth**. In a formal joust or a legal duel, the GM may award *Victory by Virtue* rather than by blood: the combatant with the higher Virtue score wins the dispute, even if they lost the physical exchange. This is the law of the tilt and the law of the court.

The Armor Closes / The Song Escapes (Chivalric Clocks): The Cantor Alain, bearer of the Cracked Ring, sings a warning at every tourney:

- **Armor Closes** [6] advances when knights choose protection over mercy, when gorgets are buckled tight, when chivalry becomes siege mentality. When full, the cantons close their borders and the raids become wars.
- **Song Escapes** [8] advances when a Cantor sings the truth, when mercy is shown, when armour is unbuckled. When full, a moment of genuine connection occurs though it may be fatal.

In Rouen, Alain still sings the *Planctus Armatus* each spring, and the congregation weeps for Sir Corin, who unbuckled his gorget to hear a thief’s voice and was undone by the mercy he offered.

Lore Echoes (CrossExpansion Hooks)

- **Seint Michel, the Judge of the Scar (Mykkiel):** The Order of the Gilded Scale maintains the *Chivalric Ledger* record of every oath sworn and broken in the cantons. A page torn from this ledger can serve as a single-use Claim String (gain +1 Position in any court). The Orders

justiciars are feared and respected; they never unbuckle their gorgets, and they have never lost a case. The QueenMother keeps a copy in her riverside keep, wrapped in a grey shroud.

- **Seint Isabeau, Who Slumbers Amongst the Lilies (Ikasha):** In the Ethorian marches, knights whisper prayers to Seint Isabeau when they long to set aside their steel. Her shrine is a hawthorn grove where armour must be left at the gate. Pilgrims who enter bareskinned and speak a true regret find that their next wound heals in a single night but they dream of a woman in white who asks, Will you remember how to be touched? Those who return to the grove a second time are never seen again.
- **Seint Evroul of the Cairn (Mor’iraath):** In the high passes of the Ethorian marches, a rusted knight in an unopened helm haunts the old barrows. He is the patron of those who carry a blooddebt and cannot rest. To call upon him, one must pour a cup of salt water at a cairn and name the wrong done to your house. He will witness one blow; if it lands, the foe is *Marked by the Cairn* any spirit may locate them for a year. If it misses, the blow turns inward. The MarshalExile carries a scar from such a bargain; he does not speak of it.
- **The Order of the Sunken Cup (The Hospice of the Broken Blade):** A greyrobed hospice in the ruins of Lence treats the wounded of both crowns. They ask no payment, but they record every name in a ledger that never dries. The Restorationists suspect they are spies for the QueenMother; the Two Crowns accuse them of erasing debts. Sister Oria, the hospices custodian, is also the keeper of the LanternRites House on the Belworthneutral ground where even claimants must leave their blades at the door.
- **The Ninth:** In any Vhasian court, the ninth citation of precedent voids all previous. The wise stop at eight and settle. Those who cite the ninth are said to hear a faint laughter from the marble walls and their cases are never heard again.

Vhasian Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Sun:** Crumble a crust onto a cracked sundisc. Ignore the first *Chevauchée* penalty.
- **Knot the Seal:** Tie a single knot in a charter’s ribbon. Cancel *Parlement Divided* or take –1 die on your next legal argument (your choice).
- **Name to the Salt:** Whisper a dead claimant’s name into a salt pan. Gain +1 Effect when collecting debts from their faction this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the QueenMother.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Rival officials or court guards take notice.
- **Noise:** Parlement clerks or routier patrols are alerted.
- **Trace:** Trackers or tax collectors mark your route.
- **Delay:** A setback costs time or a favourable legal window.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant resource clock.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** A duchy constable or abbesschatelaine begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** Legal challenge or road closure costs you advantage.

- **Foe Appears:** A rival claimant or freecompany arrives.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes Compromised/Neglected.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional routiers, parlement guards, or ducal forces arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool or weapon becomes unusable.
- **Major Twist:** A writ is voided, an interdict declared, or a levy called.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark Fatigue 1/Harm 1 or an appropriate Condition.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates fully.
- **Authority Arrival:** The Two Crowns, QueenMother, or MarshalExile intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** A chevauchée hits, the river floods, or the parlement erupts.
- **Patron Omen:** An omen appears, a blessing is lost, or a curse manifests.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Fractured Authority:** Seals break midsigning, legal papers rewrite themselves, badges refuse honour.
- **Legal Warfare:** Court decisions reverse, precedents are cited against you, writs expire prematurely.
- **Sun Symbolism:** Sundiscs crack underfoot, light splits into contradictory shadows, oaths shatter like glass.

Patronage & Power

In Vhasia, power flows through the remnants of imperial authority, fractured legitimacy, and the careful manipulation of legal and religious institutions. Former Utaran provincial structures still provide a framework for governance, but competing claimants to the Suncourt have created a complex web of overlapping jurisdictions and conflicting loyalties. The true power lies with those who can navigate this legal maze and maintain the appearance of legitimate authority.

For the GM: Patronage in Vhasia revolves around legitimacy, legal documents, and the ability to command respect from institutions that no longer have a clear central authority. Rewards often take the form of charters, writs, and official positions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, badges, writs) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival claimants issue conflicting authorities, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the parlements, cathedrals, and châteaux as arenas for social contests, where

knowledge of law and custom determines success.

In Vhasia, your papers are your power, and your power determines whether you rule or are ruled.

The Vacant Throne & Campaign Clocks

For longform political campaigns:

- **Vacant Throne Clock [10]:** Advances when a claimant gains a major advantage (battle, noble defection, foreign alliance). Retreats when the party brokers a truce or exposes a weakness. When full, a claimant takes Lence and declares themselves king.
- **Armor Closes [6]:** Advances when knights choose protection over mercy, when gorgets are buckled tight, when chivalry becomes siege mentality. When full, the cantons close their borders and the raids become wars.
- **Song Escapes [8]:** Advances when a Cantor sings the truth, when mercy is shown, when armour is unbuckled. When full, a moment of genuine connection occurs though it may be fatal.
- **Claimant’s Coup (per claimant):** A 6clock that advances when that claimant wins a Parlement vote, a joust, or a skirmish. When full, they march on Lence.

Boss Seeds (threephase foes)

- **The Red Marshal (Exiled Suncourt hammer)** *Phases:* Chevauchee Call → Banner Turn → Lists to War. *Cracks:* Letters Patent buys one round of obedience; General Pardon lets a unit stand down.
- **Cardinal-Regent of the Broken Sun (scarlet gloves)** *Phases:* Interdict Blade → Seal Both Ways → Confessional Leak. *Cracks:* Queen’s Audience cancels Interdict Blade once; a Synod Indulgence treats a church check as controlled for one scene.
- **The Parlement Spider (chief clerk; quills like daggers)** *Phases:* Motion to Delay → CounterCitation → Filed at Dawn. *Cracks:* Sunburst Warrant opens a “royal window”; a Burgess Charter lets a town court overrule once locally.
- **The Two Crowns (rival dukes)** *Phases:* Contradictory Edicts → Levy in Hours → Coin Trial. *Cracks:* Sunburst Warrant + public mass unites them for one scene; General Pardon calms levy unrest once.

Legendary Sites & Trials

- **Tournament Ordeal (Bastide Square)** Declare Purse, Patent, or Pardon as stakes. Win to cash a matching ♦; lose and spawn *Tournament “Accident”*.
- **Cathedral Scaffold Assize** Argue law atop creaking beams; each good point moves Position up; each slip marks Exposure. A *Paréage Charter* lets you call a recess once.
- **Pont-du-Tithe Vigil** Keep the bridge peaceful through dusk: clear 3 segments on *Bridge Peace* by feeding pilgrims, quieting relic zeal, and paying one tithe from your purse.

Extensions (Plugin)

- **Legitimacy Dial (Claimant ↔ Neutrality):** Track the party’s public stance.

- *Claimant High*: +1 Position when invoking seals, warrants, or feudal rights; first parley with a rival claimant starts one step worse.
- *Neutrality High*: +1 Effect when brokering truces or smuggling between factions; first petition to a court or cathedral starts one step worse.
- Center the dial by paying weight to both sides or hosting a neutral moot.
- **Parlement MiniGame (legal duel):**
 - Lay three counters: *Precedent*, *Equity*, *Force*.
 - Argue a point (roll Lore + Sway vs. DV 3). On a hit, move one counter to your side. On a miss, the clerk gains *Citation Edge*.
 - Win two counters to secure a temporary *Parlement Ruling* (treat as a Diamond for one scene).
 - *Spider's Interjection* (2 SB): flip *Precedent*, but start *Whispered Precedent* [2].
- **Chevauchée Pressure (raid clock):**
 - Two opposed clocks: *Outrun the Fire* vs *Scorched Earth* (size by highest rank in seed).
 - Each leg, choose *High Road* (fast, exposed), *Bypass* (slow, hidden), or *Ford* (risky, shortcut).
 - Advantage: Bypass → High Road (cover), Ford → Bypass (speed), High Road → Ford (navigation).
 - Spend a *Watch-Code* (from ThreeFires Ridge) to shift one segment from Scorched Earth to Outrun.
- **Favor of the Sun (prestige track):**
 - Earn by resolving disputes between claimants without bloodshed, or by returning stolen relics.
 - At 3 Favor, treat one *Safe-Conduct* or *Sunburst Warrant* as unquestioned for a scene.
 - Each use after the first advances *Legitimacy Challenge* [4] against that claimant.
- **StartofScene Omens (1d6):**
 1. *Cracked Bell*: first legal action gains +1d; first boast draws *Parlement Divided*.
 2. *Smoke on the Ridge*: Chevauchée advances once; shortcuts open.
 3. *Three Suns*: three claimants claim the same road; pick a side or start *Coin Debasement*.
 4. *Queen's Dove*: a message arrives; +1d on the next *Queen's Audience* attempt.
 5. *Salt Wind*: *Gabelle Lease* counts double value today; smugglers' ears open.
 6. *Routier Campfire*: mercenaries are hireable for one scene at half price but they'll ask questions later.
- **Plugin SB Conversions (Vhasia Flavor):**
 - 1 SB → *Seal Crack*: a writ loses half its value until rewitnessed.
 - 2 SB → *Citation War*: increase DV by 1 unless you produce a precedent (spend a ◇ or recall a past ruling).
 - 3+ SB → *Crown Fracture*: the claimant's legitimacy splits; halve a consequence by accepting a rival's seal on your paper (start *Legitimacy Challenge*).
- **Reputation Echoes:**
 - *Court-Favored*: once/session, downgrade *Parlement Divided* to a minor delay; the next

document you present is scrutinized (+1 DV).

- *Chevauchée-Tested*: +1 Position when evading raids; supply lines run 1 segment longer.
- *Neutral Broker*: +1d with both claimants in a truce scene; any betrayal earns *Resentment* [2] from both sides.

- **Cross-Region Hooks (quick integration):**

- *Thepyrgos Synod Leak*: a *Synod Indulgence* can suspend a Vhasian interdict but starts *Whispered Precedent* in Thepyrgos.
- *Ubral Feud Echo*: paying wergild to a Vhasian claimant instead of a clan starts *Feud Rekindled* along the border roads.
- *Kahfagia Salt War*: cashing a *Gabelle Lease* to outbid corsair lanes adds *Market Knives* [4] in Silkstrand or on the coastal quays.
- *Valewood Relic Interest*: a relic from a Vhasian cathedral may be claimed by fae courts; a Diamond spent on relic control may instead draw *Court Tithe*.

Chapter 5

Viterra

The Hedge-Law Realm.

Every hedge here marks not just a boundary but a principle the careful balance between order and freedom, justice and mercy. Our law grows like the hedges themselves, tended with precision and patience.

I am a Queen's Justiciar. I have never lost a legal duel. My opponents have a habit of falling down stairs. I do not push them. The stairs *remember their debts*.

Viterra breathes with the careful rhythm of precedent and petition. Once a proud kingdom before becoming a Utaran province, it is now reborn under a Warrior Queen who rules by legal precision as much as military might. The realm's true sinews lie not in steel but in writs, charters, and the ancient rights that bind lord to tenant, crown to county, and church to common.

But do not mistake us for gentle. The Queen's Peace is not a promise it is a contract, renewed each morning by every magistrate, every justicar, every clerk who opens a ledger. And across the Belworth, the Vhasians still claim our hedges are theirs. Let them try.

Never cross the Belworth without a charter recognized on both banks. Viterran law and Vhasian claim fight every crossing, and the river takes the losers.

Justiciar Elodie Venn, who invoked the Right of Acknowledgment and watched a father speak truth to his son for the first time

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Barley porridge with a drizzle of honey if you own bees. If not, porridge with salt. Salt is the currency of the poor. Honey is the currency of the hopeful.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To recite their lineage back three generations. Every Viterran child knows their grandparents' names, their grandparents' trades, and their grandparents' debts. A child who cannot recite their lineage is a child without standing. Standing is everything.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Whether they carry a seal ring. A seal ring means they have the right to make contracts in their own name. A stranger without a seal ring is either a servant or a criminal. In Viterra, the difference is a matter of paperwork.

What is the most common crime? Boundary disputes. A hedge moved three feet east. A milestone replaced under cover of darkness. A ford declared "private" when it has been public for two centuries. The courts are clogged with such cases. The lawyers are rich. The hedges are patient.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Queen is not a warrior. She has never drawn a sword. Her reputation was forged by a propaganda campaign run by her spymaster. The spymaster is dead. His successor is more discreet.

Where do people go when they die? To the family plot if they have a family. The landless poor are buried in parish cemeteries, their headstones marked with a single word: "Anonymous." The ghosts of the anonymous wander the hedgerows at dusk. They do not remember their names. They remember their debts.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You petition the hedge-court for a "writ of contrition." The writ requires you to state your wrong aloud, in public, while holding a handful of earth from the wronged party's land. If the earth crumbles, you are forgiven. If it holds, your apology is not accepted. You may try again next season.

What is the most important festival? The Opening of the Rolls (autumn). Every county sends its tax records to the capital. The procession is a week long. The documents are carried by children, so that the next generation may learn the weight of obligation.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Codex of Precedents has a missing page. It was torn out fifty years ago, during a trial for treason. The page contained the precedent for executing a monarch. The Queen knows. The Justiciars know. The page is hidden in a lead-lined box beneath the hedge-court at Thornwood. The hedge-court is haunted. The ghost knows where the key is.

5.1 Viterra — “The Hedge-Law Realm”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Every hedge is a boundary. Every boundary is a claim. Every claim is a blade.*

Warrior Queen (Elite): “The hedge that is not defended is only a suggestion. And the law that is not enforced is only a memory. I will have both remembered in stone, in blood, and in the ledgers of every parish from the Belworth to the Dolmis.”

Fen Reeve (Commoner): “The dikes hold back more than water they hold back chaos. Every rod measured, every stone placed, keeps the flood from washing away not just our fields but our very way of life. Across the Belworth, the Vhasians still claim our hedges are theirs. Let them try. We have lawyers. We have swords. Sometimes they are the same people. The Queen’s peace is a contract; she signs it each morning with a sword. I just hope the ink holds.”

Genre / Mood: Postimperial consolidation, legal warfare, border adventurism, the fragile crown.

Starting Location: The Hall of Dawning tiltyard at first light. Dawnknights drill in armor polished like mirrors. Beside them, advocates rehearse arguments with the same intensity. A Queen’s Justiciar slides a parchment across an oaken rail. “Three charters, one road across the Belworth. The Vhasian claimant says the bridge is theirs. The local reeve says it’s crown land. The abbey says it’s a pilgrimage, not a toll. Carry the Queen’s writ, break the Quiet Tolls, and make them agree by clause or by cut. The Earls are watching, and the Queen has only just secured the throne. Fail, and you’ll give her enemies the excuse they need.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Viterra breathes with the careful rhythm of precedent and petition but also with the raw, unhealed scar of a kingdom that threw off the Uтарan yoke and is still learning to stand alone. Once a proud, independent kingdom before the legions came, Viterra never forgave the empire. It was the first to break away when the Uтарan Imperium faltered, its hedgelaws and parish courts preserving a stubborn, deeprooted identity that parchment and wax could never erase. Now, under a young and untested Warrior Queen, Viterra is trying to remember what it means to rule itself.

But the crown is not secure. Queen Veralyn Everblood took the throne only after the sudden death of her brother, King Baldwyn Brightside, who reigned for barely two years before succumbing to a swift, mysterious illness. His death was a wound the kingdom has not healed. The succession was contested: the earls of the northern marches, who remember when their ancestors ruled as petty kings, demanded concessions; the barons of the western borderlands, many with Vhasian blood and Vhasian gold in their pockets, whispered that a woman could not hold the crown. The Queen has spent her first year in the saddle, riding from keep to keep, sealing charters with her own seal, settling feuds with her own justiciars, and when necessary proving her right to rule with a blade in her hand. The throne is secured, for now. But the kingdom is a patchwork of loyalties, and every hedge hides a knife.

The realm’s true sinews lie not in steel but in writs, charters, and the ancient rights that bind lord to tenant, crown to county, and church to common. Every hedgerow, every parish stone, every ferry crossing carries the weight of custom older than memory. Yet there is no single,

unified law. The Queen's law competes with the earls' law, with the barons' law, with the ancient custom of the fens, with the Ubral clan law that still holds in the high passes, and with the Vhasian claims that bleed across the Belworth. A deed that is valid in Valora may be worthless in the Marches. A judgment that holds in a crown court may be overturned by a hedgemoot at dusk. The very question *which law is law* is the central argument of the kingdom.

Viterra is not a nation at peace. It is a realm that wages law as war, and war as law. The Queen's Peace is not a promise it is a contract, renewed each morning by every magistrate, every justicar, every clerk who opens a ledger. And the ink is still wet on many pages.

What you notice first: The smell of damp parchment and fresh ink. The clatter of writrunners' boots on cobblestones. The way every noble's hand rests on a seal ring and every commoner's hand rests on a hatchet.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never cross the Belworth without a charter recognized on both banks. Viterran law and Vhasian claim fight every crossing, and the river takes the losers.

Regional Mood: Hedge, Crown, and Claim

Here, law is a blade. The Warrior Queen rules from Valora, her throne a bench of precedents. She is young, untested, and surrounded by counselors who mistake caution for loyalty and by courtiers who still whisper the name of her dead brother. The old Fenwood dukes whose ancestors sacked Lence and left the Vhasian Suncourt fractured still hold vast estates in the northern marches, and their claims across the Belworth keep the border smoking like a low fire. The earls of the north, descendants of the old hill kings, watch her every move, waiting for a misstep. The barons of the west, many of whom swore oaths to Vhasian claimants before they swore to her, smile with teeth that glitter with coin from across the river. Every spring, the Queen's justiciars ride west with warrants and escorts, demanding homage from villages that have paid Vhasian tithes for a generation. Every autumn, Vhasian routiers raid the grain convoys, and the legal duels that follow are fought with steel and citation alike. The border is not a line on a map. It is an argument. And the Queen intends to win it.

North, the Ubral clans watch from their cairns, ready to rekindle feuds if a Viterran levy crosses the passes. South, Thepyrgos sends clerks and spies, testing the edges of Viterran jurisdiction with every disputed toll. And in Theona, the Three Greens mumble old curses while Viterran bailiffs try to count their cattle and always miscount by one. The Queen's rule is not yet secure. Every charter she signs is a challenge. Every justiciar she sends is a declaration. Every duel fought in her name is a step toward a throne that is still being carved.

Prominent NPCs of Viterra

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk

Queen Veralyn Everblood	Warrior Queen of Viterra	Consolidate her rule and reclaim the crown’s authority	Her crown has no jewels only seals; each seal is a conquered claim. She still sleeps with a dagger under her pillow.
Justiciar Elodie Venn	Queen’s Justiciar	Enforce the law without fear or favour	She has never lost a legal duel; her opponents tend to fall down stairs. She was a commoner until the Queen raised her.
Baron Aldric	Disgraced turncloak	Restore his lost honour through loyal service	He was stripped of his lands for oathbreaking during the succession crisis; now he haunts the northern marches, trying to earn back the Queen’s trust.
Ser Roran	Knight of the Queen’s household	Remind himself that a stranger’s coin bought his life	He wears a silver gauntlet over his left hand; he never takes ransom. He was a prisoner of the Vhasians; the Queen paid his price.

Fen Reeve Cuthbert	Keeper of the dike guilds	Protect the fens from flood and the Queen's tax men	His tallyrod has notches from three floods; the next notch will be from a Vhasian raid. He trusts the Queen but not her lawyers.
Master Advocate Halric	Legal duelist and scholar	Win the Great Law Day and retire undefeated	He has argued cases in three kingdoms and won all using their own precedents. He refuses to take sides in the succession dispute which means everyone suspects him.
Sister Oria	Custodian of the LanternRites House (Belworth)	Keep the rites of hospitality and witness on the border	She has never drawn a blade. She has never needed to. The Queen's enemies who have crossed her threshold have a habit of forgetting why they came.
Earl Morcar of the North	Leader of the northern earls, old blood	Preserve the privileges of the ancient nobility against crown encroachment	He carries a sword that belonged to a king before the Utaran conquest. He has not yet sworn formal fealty to the Queen.

Names of Viterra

Inspired by AngloSaxon and early Norman England: strong consonants, soft vowels, and surnames that recall a hedge, a dike, or a parish. Many nobles still bear Utaranized names from the occupation, but the common folk use the old tongue.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Baldwyn	Veralyn	Everblood	<i>the LawGiver</i>
Cuthbert	Aldric	Fenwood	<i>the Unbuckled</i>
Roran	Halric	of the Scar	<i>BellSworn</i>
Morcar	Oria	de la Marche	<i>the HedgeWise</i>
Leofric	Aelfwyn	l’Argent	<i>the Silent</i>
Ghiro	Celandine	Riven	<i>AshBanner</i>

(Reeve/Guild/Knight/Legal Advocate) Fen reeve with tallyrod speaking for dike guilds; rivercarter syndic moving grain faster than rumor; justices of the peace settling disputes with careful pen; master advocates who duel with words and swords.

Spades — Places

2. **Fen Causeway** — Stile with tollrod and eel carts queueing; each reeve claims right to collect under a different charter. Dueling advocates argue cases on makeshift platforms. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[TRADE]’ *The causeway sinks an inch each year. The lawyers argue over whose fault that is.*
3. **Hedgerow Green** — In the Dales; bows strung under apple trees where justices of the peace hold court beneath makeshift arbors. Court duels permitted for matters of honor. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The apple tree is called “the Hanging Judge.” Its fruit tastes of iron.*
4. **Beacon Hill** — Above the Highlands; firegrate still warm from last winter’s levy call, signal tower with semaphore arms for legal dispatches and military alerts. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The hill has three beacons. One for Ubral raids, one for Vhasian incursions, one for paperwork.*
5. **Belworth Stairs** — Ferry ledgers gone damp with rivermist; three manors claim toll rights, writs in three different hands. Legal challenges fought in boats while waiting. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The stairs were repaired last year. The Vhasian side uses a different measurement.*
6. **Bloom Quarry** — Old ironbloom turned drill yard; hammer echoes carry, forgereeve holds tally of crown contracts. Military contracts awarded through legal bidding wars. ‘[CRAFT]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The forgereeve has never lost a contract. His opponents have a habit of finding better jobs elsewhere.*
7. **Parish Maze** — Stone maze where three maps disagree; hedgepriest’s vote decides who pays tithe and who holds freehold. Legal disputes settled by navigating the maze correctly. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[RIDDLE]’ *The maze changes at night. The hedgepriest says that’s God’s will.*
8. **Fairport Works** — Tideworks at the Dolmis mouth; customs writs in three languages flutter, inspectors with magnifying glasses examine every manifest. Maritime law enforcement includes boarding actions. ‘[TRADE]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *One language is Utaran, one is Linn, one is for the smugglers.*

9. **Law Quarter** — Valora archives, oathrooms, Hall of Dawning where precedent is birthed in ink and sealed with wax. Adjacent training grounds for legal advocates. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[KNOWLEDGE]’ *The archives have a locked wing. The key is a legal argument no one has won.*
10. **Counting Fields** — Tarlington beside muster ground; wagons load, ledgers missum, auditors with quillpens and suspicious eyes. Military mustering follows strict legal procedures with armed oversight. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[LABOR]’ *The auditors carry swords. They say it’s for counting cattle. No one asks further.*
- J **Dike Crown** — Ring of turf and timber; brotherhood bells warn of flood and spies who move like water through the fen. Legal sanctuary for those fleeing court judgments. ‘[COMMUNITY]’ ‘[LAW]’ *The sanctuary lasts for one tide. After that, the reeves can come if they can find you.*
- Q **Progress Camp** — Queen’s canvas palisade, banners stiff, whispering old courtiers plot advancement through legal maneuver and sanctioned duels. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The camp moves every week. The lawsuits follow at a measured pace.*
- K **Tilt-Yard** — Hall of Dawning at first light; Dawnknights drill clean, loyalties in contracts signed with careful pen. Legal challenges often end in trial by combat. ‘[COMBAT]’ ‘[LAW]’ *The sand is raked between duels. Sometimes the rake turns up old blood or old oaths.*
- A **Highway Stone** — Queen’s milestone above the Dolmis road; three sheriffs post seals over hers, each claiming different jurisdiction. Territory disputes resolved through armed arbitration. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The stone has been broken and reglued seven times. Each crack is a forgotten compromise.*

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Fen Reeve** — Tallyrod; speaks for dike guilds, remembers every floodyear’s debts and the charters that govern them. Authorized to call local levies for legal disputes. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[COMMUNITY]’ *His tallyrod has notches from three floods. The next notch will be from a Vhasian raid.*
3. **River Syndic** — Moves grain faster than rumor; knows which writs matter and which customs officials can be... persuaded. Maintains armed merchant guards. ‘[TRADE]’ ‘[STEALTH]’ *His ledger has a watermark a crown on one side, a sunburst on the other. He shows the right side to the right audience.*
4. **Parish Surveyor** — Three maps, one opinion; hedgewalks settle more disputes than courts, measures boundaries with careful chain. Expert witness in property disputes. ‘[KNOWLEDGE]’ ‘[LAW]’ *His chain is exactly one rod long. The rod changes length depending on who is paying.*
5. **Dawn Quartermaster** — Ledgers sharper than tongue; logistics before lances, counts every farthing spent in the Queen’s name. Legal authority over military supplies. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[LABOR]’ *He once tracked a missing farthing to a Vhasian counting house. The farthing was returned with interest.*
6. **Levy Serjeant** — Dales bow calm, cider breath, memory keen for every loophole in the mustering laws. Commands armed civilians in legal enforcement actions. ‘[COMBAT]’ ‘[LAW]’ *His bowstring is made from a cancelled writ. He says it shoots truer now.*
7. **Cleric-Pair** — Light preacher vs. Everflame canon lawyer; debates decide tithe law, one for the spirit, one for the letter. Religious law carries weight in secular courts. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[LAW]’ *They share a room at the inn. They have not spoken outside court in seven years.*
8. **Fairport Shipwright** — Dolmis cousins; skiff carries more secrets than cargo, knows which manifests to forge and which to honor. Expert in maritime law and naval combat. ‘[CRAFT]’

- ‘[STEALTH]’ *Her skiff has no name. The customs clerks have given it three.*
9. **Fenwood Comptroller** — Conjures wagons with a signature, silence with a seal, counts the Queen’s coin and tracks every debt owed to the crown. Legal authority over taxation. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[TRADE]’ *His quill is a dagger. He has used it as both.*
10. **Queen’s Justiciar** — Law on the road, polite as a noose; bearing three kings’ judgments and a purse full of pardons for the right price. Authorized to conduct trial by combat. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *She has never lost a legal duel. Her opponents have a tendency to fall down stairs.*
- J **Border Routier** — Reads ledgers as ambushes; serves two crowns, collects from both, knows which border posts take bribes in what coin. Expert in frontier law enforcement. ‘[STEALTH]’ ‘[TRADE]’ *His loyalty is to the highest bidder. The Queen and the Vhasian claimant are currently in a bidding war.*
- Q **Warrior Queen** — Crown on helm, sword at side, patient sums behind her gaze; rules by law’s sharp edge and knows every precedent that supports her claim. Final arbiter in legal duels. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[LAW]’ *Her crown has no jewels only seals. Each seal is a conquered claim.*
- K **Crown Council** — Fenwood dukes, guild envoys, abbots; weighing grain against glory, charters against coin, precedent against practicality. Legal battles fought through proxy advocates. ‘[POLITICS]’ ‘[LAW]’ *The council has a standing rule: no weapons within the chamber. The advocates have found seventeen loopholes.*
- A **Master Advocate Halric** — Silvertongued legal warrior who settles disputes through verbal duels that can end in physical combat. Keeper of legal combat traditions. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *He has argued cases in Vhasian, Thepyrgosian, and Ubral courts and won all three using their own precedents.*

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Dike Breach** — Blackrain; the wrong reeve claims credit while wagons drown, insurance claims and liability writs fly like autumn leaves. Legal liability may require armed enforcement. ‘[DISASTER]’ ‘[LAW]’ *The water is brown with peat and lies. It carries old deeds downstream.*
3. **Feast Clash** — Light vs. Everflame processions collide; shutters slam, writs fly, justices of the peace called to settle which holy day takes precedence. Honor disputes may require legal duels. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[LAW]’ *The processions take different routes now. The clash was not an accident.*
4. **Quiet Tolls** — Sprout on the Queen’s Highway; escorts sniff traps, sheriffs argue rights, customs officials demand duties no one knew existed. Territorial disputes resolved through armed arbitration. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The toll posts have fresh paint. The paint is from the keep of a Vhasian claimant.*
5. **Audit Freeze** — Countinghouse freezes cargo; Queen’s seal vs. old writs, auditors with suspicious eyes and quillpens sharp as daggers. Legal challenges may escalate to physical confrontation. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[DEBT]’ *The auditors work by candlelight. The shadows on the walls look like gallows.*
6. **Border Snarl** — Three courts arrest the same haycart; whose hay is it? Which lord’s charter takes precedence? Bribes flow like wine. Frontier justice often involves armed standoffs. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The hay is from a field that was Vhasian last spring. Now it’s Viterran. The field hasn’t moved.*

7. **Isle Refusal** — Theona withholds levy; the quays choke on rumor, ships idle while lawyers debate maritime law and ancient treaties. Naval blockades become legal enforcement actions. ‘[POLITICS]’ ‘[LAW]’ *Theona’s envoy carries a hawthorn branch. The Queen’s justiciars will not touch it.*
8. **Delta Spat** — Fairport vs. Marcott customs; barges stack three deep, merchants pick sides, inspectors with magnifying glasses examine every manifest. Trade disputes fought with merchant guards. ‘[TRADE]’ ‘[LAW]’ *The magnifying glasses reveal truth and also start fires. Both are useful.*
9. **Routier Arrears** — A freecompany flips unless someone pays; your name on a ledger, a debt owed to men who know the price of blood. Legal debts enforced through hired swords. ‘[DEBT]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The routiers have a list. Your name is on it or will be by sunset.*
10. **Salt Pinch** — Import spikes, bakers barricade; the Queen’s promise tastes like thin gruel, merchants hoard salt like gold, riots brew in back alleys. Economic warfare becomes physical conflict. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The salt is grey. It was cut with ashes from a burned Vhasian customs post.*
- J **Dawn Recall** — Escort pulled to a floodstruck parish; the writ argues with the river, justices demand inquiry into who neglected the dikes. Military enforcement of legal judgments. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The escorts are back in a week. They bring new writs and fewer men.*
- Q **Aberielist Intrigue** — Royalist seals in wrong hands; the Queen’s patience thins, conspirators plot in counting houses, whispers of rebellion. Treason charges carry death penalty in legal duels. ‘[POLITICS]’ ‘[LAW]’ *The seals are from a dead duke. The duke’s ghost is said to approve.*
- K **Levy Call-Up** — Dalesmen mustered; your wagons seized “for the realm,” conscription writs signed with careful pen, families left to tend fields alone. Legal authority backed by armed force. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The conscription writs have a clause: “void if Belworth freezes.” The river is still warm.*
- A **Legal Duel Challenge** — Master Advocate Halric issues a formal challenge; refuse and lose legal standing, accept and risk life and fortune in courtyard combat. The ultimate legal weapon. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The challenge is written on both sides of the parchment. There is no blank space to refuse.*

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Ferry Priority** — Belworth crossing (once); a horn answers, though perhaps the wrong ferry; customs officials look the other way for the right coin. Legal right of way backed by armed escort. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The priority token is a writ signed by both banks. The ink on one side is newer.*
3. **Dike Allotment** — Brotherhood labor granted if three clerks are convinced and proper bribes distributed among the right hands. Work performed under legal contract with military oversight. ‘[LABOR]’ *The allotment includes a clause: “as tides permit.” The reeve decides what the tides permit.*
4. **Market License** — Valora’s square; a guild nod still needed, but the right seal on the right parchment opens many doors. Legal protection from merchant guild enforcement. ‘[TRADE]’ *The license is written on vellum from a Vhasian abbey. The irony is noted.*
5. **Dawn Escort** — Four lances at dawn; loyalty waxes and wanes with pay, but their presence

- keeps lesser men from troubling you. Legal authority to enforce your writs. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The lances are from the Fenwood armory. The Fenwood dukes have their own plans.*
6. **River Charter** — Guaranteed haul on a grain artery weather permitting and proper duties paid to the right officials. Legal right protected by river patrol. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The charter is stamped with a seal that looks like a crown or a sunburst. No one can agree.*
7. **Map Correction** — A hedge moves, borders shift, lawsuits bloom; a new survey can make or break a man’s fortune overnight. Legal survey backed by armed surveyors. ‘[LAW]’ *The surveyors carry chains and swords. The swords are for when the chains disagree.*
8. **Customs Seal** — Fairport for Dolmis cargo; honored today, disputed tomorrow, but tonight it clears the way for what needs moving. Legal immunity from customs enforcement. ‘[TRADE]’ *The seal is a wax crab. It pinches when pressed.*
9. **Thing Ruling** — Sharp local bite, but appeals run swifter than oaths; justice swift but not always just, depending on which purse feeds the judge. Court decisions enforceable by local levy. ‘[LAW]’ *The ruling is carved on an oar. Break the oar, and the ruling breaks with it.*
10. **Salt Allotment** — Winter depot; the Queen’s writ opens doors, old hands still count sacks, but the right connections ensure the best salt reaches the right tables. Legal monopoly backed by military force. ‘[TRADE]’ *The salt is from a pan worked by Ubral exiles. They still count in clan measure.*
- J **Wardship** — A minor fenkeep; menatarms “for now,” a tutor has plans, but the right guardian can be found for the right price. Legal guardianship with military authority. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The ward is a child. The child has a seal ring. The ring is older than the kingdom.*
- Q **Queen’s Audience** — Private; her questions strike like thrusts, but her favors can elevate a man from nothing to something overnight. Royal decree carries immediate enforcement power. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The audience lasts one hour. The paperwork lasts a generation.*
- K **Ducal Warrant** — Fenwood to enforce customs; old power bows, new power watches, but the parchment carries weight in any court. Legal authority backed by noble house military. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The warrant is signed in blood or ink that looks like blood. The difference matters at trial.*
- A **Duel Sanction** — Right to challenge in legal combat; the Queen’s seal makes it official, Dawnknights serve as seconds, the winner takes all legally. Ultimate legal enforcement mechanism. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The sanction is a coin. Heads you duel, tails your opponent chooses the weapon.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (writs/charters/priority) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **hedgelaw** motif boundaries blur, charters contradict, precedent splinters, and the careful web of legal authority shows its cracks. Legal warfare escalates to physical conflict.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Hedge-Law Momentum:** When a valid *writ*, *charter*, or *warrant* is presented in the proper parish, step **Position** up one category on social or logistical actions in that locale for the scene. The first contradiction starts a **Border-Lace** [4] clock; advance each time competing papers are invoked.
- **Beacon & Bell Chain:** If two adjacent *beacons* or *brotherhood bells* are under your influence, convert one **Club** draw into a travel delay for *others* while the party proceeds with improved **Effect** for movement and logistics. The signal draws scrutiny; the GM may bank 1 SB tied to local authority.
- **River-Right Window:** At a ferry, tidework, or customs stair, play any **Diamond** tied to crossings or seals to open a short *window of lawful passage*: one convoy passes uninspected, or one cargo clears at priority. The window closes immediately if a storm, audit, or levy card is revealed.
- **Legal Duel Protocol:** When legal disputes cannot be resolved through argument, parties may challenge each other to a duel. The winner's position becomes legally binding. Requires proper sanction and seconds (see **Duel Sanction Diamond**).
- **Vhasian Claims:** Any Viterran noble with land across the Belworth may invoke a *Ducal Warrant* to attempt to collect rents or enforce judgments in Vhasia. Doing so starts a **Border Snarl** clock, as the Vhasian claimants are unlikely to cooperate.
- **Theona Contest:** The Warrior Queen's authority over the Three Greens is nominal at best. Any attempt to enforce Viterran law in Theona triggers an **Isle Refusal** complication, and the local taboos may twist the law into knots.
- **The Succession's Shadow:** The sudden death of King Baldwyn Brightstide and the contested succession left deep scars. Any legal dispute that touches on inheritance, legitimacy, or royal authority is automatically one step more volatile. The GM may spend 1 SB to introduce a witness, a document, or a rumor related to the succession crisis.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - * **Saint Elodie of the Unburdened Knot (Inaea / Oath of Mercy and Grace):**
A legendary figure from the early days of Viterran independence, Saint Elodie was a hedgepriestess who wandered the disputed borderlands, binding feuds with red thread and forgiveness. Her most famous miracle was the *Unknotting of the Fenwood Vengeance* a blood feud that had run for nine generations. She took a strand of hair from each family's eldest, tied them into a single cord, and then *cut the cord in half*, declaring: "The past is severed. What you owe now is not to the dead, but to the next stranger who asks for bread." The families feasted together for the first time in centuries. Her shrines are wayside posts where travellers leave a knotted cord; the first person to untie a knot and offer it to a stranger in need is said to receive her blessing (+1 die to their next act of mercy or reconciliation). The Temple of Light has never canonised her she was too folk, too female, too hedgerow but the common folk remember. The Queen's justiciars respect her precedent: *A severed debt is not a gift. It is a thread that now binds you to the living.*" (Some scholars whisper that Saint Elodie was not a priestess but a mortal avatar of **Inaea**, the Spider's Daughter, or a wandering Runekeeper of the **Oath of Mercy and Grace**. The Church of the Everflame calls her a heretic; the fen folk call her grandmother.)
 - **Saint Michel of the Gilded Scale** Mykkiel. *The law that does not bend; the judge

who cannot be bought.*

- **Saint Isabeau of the Lilies** Ikasha. *The dream of setting aside the crown; the mercy of forgetting duty.*
- **Saint Evroul of the Cairn** Mor’iraath. *The oath that outlasts the oathtaker; the debt paid in blood and stone.*
- **The Hedge King** The Traveler. *The road that belongs to no lord; the path that finds its own way.*
- **The Brightside Martyr** (folk cult) A local veneration of King Baldwyn Brightside, who died before he could rule. His followers believe his ghost still rides the borders, and that the Queen rules in his name not her own.

Lore Echoes (CrossExpansion Hooks)

- **The HedgeSeal (The Dike Covenant):** Covenant judges in the eastern parishes adjudicate disputes over river tolls and inheritance. They carry no weapons, only a set of iron scales and a copy of the *HedgeLaw Tables*. A ruling from the Order is binding in both Viterra and the Vhasian marches, but any party who lies before them forfeits their right to appeal. The Warrior Queen has granted them a charter; the Fenwood dukes consider them spies.
- **Saint Cuthbert of the Fen (The Traveler):** A legendary reeve who walked the flooded dikes during the Great Storm and lit every beacon by hand. His shrines are stiles and bridge posts; travellers who touch the iron ring on his shrine and speak a destination find the road holds firm. The Temple of Light has absorbed his cult, but the fen folk still leave offerings of eels at his cairns.
- **The CogCults of the Northern Hills (The Clockwork Monad):** In the high parishes near the Ubral border, secret fraternities of millers and surveyors believe that law is a machine that can be perfected. They meet in abandoned watermills, measuring boundaries with brass chains and reciting the *Canons of Proportion*. The Everflame calls them heretics; the Queen’s justiciars ignore them because their charts are always accurate.
- **The Salt Sworn of the Eastern Coast (The Pale Shepherd):** Along the Dolmis shore, a syncretic cult tends to the drowned. They build cairns of salt stone and leave no offerings only the names of the lost, carved into driftwood. The Temple of Light has tried to suppress them three times; each time, the mission ships have been found adrift with no crew and a single name carved into the mast: *Oblivion*.
- **The Ninth:** In any Viterran court, the ninth citation of precedent voids all previous citations. The wise stop at eight and settle out of court. Those who cite the ninth are said to hear a faint laughter from the marble walls and their cases are never heard again.

Viterran Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Hedge:** Crumble a crust at a parish boundary stone. Ignore the first *Border Snarl* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Writ:** Tie a single knot in a charter’s ribbon. Cancel *Audit Freeze* or take –1 die on your next legal argument (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the River:** Whisper a dead claimant’s name into the Belworth. Gain +1 Effect when arguing against their heir’s claim this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Queen’s Justiciar. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

- **The Brightstide Candle:** Light a candle in memory of King Baldwyn before a difficult legal proceeding. On a roll that includes a 1, you may reroll that die once but if you still fail, the ghost of the dead king is said to watch from the shadows. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **crown officials or rival advocates**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **writrunners or levy guards**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or customs inspectors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable court date**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Queen’s Justiciar or fen reeve** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **legal challenge or river closure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival claimant or border routier** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **Dawnknights, levy forces, or Vhasian routiers** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes **writ voided/duel declared/levy called**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Warrior Queen, Crown Council, or Master Advocate Halric** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically **dike breaks/river floods/court erupts**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Viterra (Hedge Law):** Boundary stones shift, charters contradict themselves, legal precedents split midcitation.
- **Viterra (CrossBorder Claims):** Vhasian landlords appear with older deeds, Theonan taboos void writs, Ubral cairns declare neutrality with axes.

- **Viterra (Legal Warfare):** Court decisions reverse without warning, witnesses recant, duel seconds change sides.
- **Viterra (Succession Politics):** A document surfaces bearing King Baldwyn’s seal; a northern earl declares the Queen’s writ invalid in his lands; a baron offers to switch sides for a price.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Survival):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Thorn Hedge*.
- **Cut the Charter (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a **Ducal Warrant** is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Assize (Resolve + Lore):** On a hit in *Audit Freeze*, you pick whose ledgers are examined; on a miss, the GM does.

Legal Combat System (Summary)

When legal disputes cannot be resolved through negotiation, parties may engage in formal legal duels. These combine verbal sparring with physical combat:

Phase 1: Pleadings

- Each advocate presents their case (Wits + Sway vs. DV 3)
- Success grants +1 die to the next phase
- Failure creates 1 SB that the opponent can spend

Phase 2: Cross-Examination

- Attack opponent’s arguments (Wits + Insight vs. DV 3)
- Success inflicts Fatigue 1 on the opponent
- Critical success forces opponent to answer truthfully

Phase 3: Trial by Combat (if unresolved)

- Physical combat with legal stakes (Body + Melee or relevant combat skill)
- Winner’s position becomes legally binding
- Loser suffers legal consequences (fine, loss of claim, imprisonment) plus physical harm

Boss Seeds (threephase foes)

- **The Violet Clerk (Master of CounterSeals)** *Phases:* Produce Earlier Patent → Split the Writ → Seal Fast. *Cracks:* a **Queen’s Audience** overrules his seal; a **Duel Sanction** forces personal combat; a **Map Correction** voids his boundary claim.
- **The Thorn Captain (Queen’s Quiet Hand)** *Phases:* Queenspeace Zone → Duel Warrant → Swap the Field. *Cracks:* a **Map Correction** reveals a loophole; a **Dike Allotment** lets you claim the field as “flood zone”; a **Border Routier** testifies to the Queen’s favor.
- **The Saffron Abbess (Keeper of BellLaw)** *Phases:* Wrong Hour → Bless or Damn → Mixed Tribunal. *Cracks:* a **Queen’s Justiciar** invokes crown supremacy; a **Border Routier** bribes her bellringer; a **Thing Ruling** from Theona forces her to recuse.
- **The Brightside Claimant (Pretender)** *Phases:* Produce the Lost Charter → Rally the Northern Earls → March on Valora. *Cracks:* find proof that the charter is a forgery; convince

Earl Morcar to stand with the Queen; survive a legal duel with the claimant's champion.

Legendary Sites & Trials

- **Belworth Stairs Ordeal** — Cross the river without a charter. On success, you prove that possession is ninetenths of the law. On failure, the river takes your name and your cargo. (Wits + Survival vs. DV 5.)
- **Hall of Dawning Vigil** — Spend a night in the tiltyard. At dawn, you recall a forgotten legal precedent. Gain a oneuse *Precedent Edge* (+1 die in any court). The ghost of a dead duelist may challenge you to a legal dreamduel. (Spirit + Lore vs. DV 4.)
- **HedgeMoot at Dusk** — Settle a boundary dispute by walking the hedge. Each successful navigation test (Wits + Survival) clears 1 segment from a **Border Snarl** clock. A miss plants the thorn of a future feud (advance **Border Snarl** by 1).

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Legal Dial (Crown ↔ Local Custom):** Track the party's stance on authority.
 - *Crown High*: +1 Position when invoking royal writs, charters, or the Queen's name; first appeal to local custom starts one step worse.
 - *Local High*: +1 Effect on hedgelaw, parish rights, or ancient precedent; first royal petition starts one step worse.
 - Center the dial by hosting a mixed moot or surrendering a contested seal to a neutral third party.
- **Courtroom MiniGame (fast trial):**
 - Lay three stones: **Precedent**, **Equity**, **Force**.
 - Argue a point (roll Lore+Diplomacy vs. DV 3). On a hit, move one stone to your side. On a miss, the opposing advocate gains *Citation Edge*.
 - Win two stones to secure a temporary **Court Ruling** (treat as a Diamond for one scene).
 - *Halric's Interjection (2 SB)*: flip **Precedent**, but start **Whispered Precedent** [2] with the losing side.
- **CrossBorder Tensions (fast pressure):**
 - Two opposed clocks: *Queen's Peace* vs *Border Fire* (size by highest rank in the seed).
 - Each leg, choose *Viterran Road* (safe, slow), *Vhasian Claim* (fast, risky), or *Ubral Pass* (hidden, costly).
 - Advantage: Vhasian Claim→Viterran Road (shortcuts), Ubral Pass→Vhasian Claim (concealment), Viterran Road→Ubral Pass (supplies).
 - Spend a **Ducal Warrant** to shift one segment from *Border Fire* to *Queen's Peace*.
- **StartofScene Rumors (1d6):**
 1. *Wrong Wax*: a rival's seals softened; +1d to forgeries this scene.
 2. *Empty Beacon*: tower unmanned; travel faster, scrutiny harsher.
 3. *DawnLane Cleared*: first convoy action gains +1 Position.
 4. *Clerk's Wedding*: filings delayed; first petition ignores *Audit Freeze*.
 5. *Fen High Water*: ferries slow; rivercharters count double value.

6. *Mask at Progress*: someone uses your name at court; +1d to social opens, +1 SB banked by GM.

- **Plugin SB Conversions (Viterra Flavor):**

- 1 SB → *Hedge Shift*: a boundary moves; increase DV by 1 for navigation or legal rolls this scene.
- 2 SB → *Citation War*: increase DV by 1 unless you produce a precedent (spend a ◇ or recall a past ruling).
- 3+ SB → *Seal Crack*: a writ loses half its value; swap one held ◇ for a lesser right until rewitnessed.

- **Reputation Echoes:**

- *CourtFavored*: once/session, downgrade **Audit Freeze** to a minor delay; the next document you present is scrutinized (+1 DV).
- *FenTested*: +1 Position when resolving dike or flood crises; legal arguments about water rights start one step worse.
- *DoubleSealed*: +1d with both royal and local courts in a truce scene; any betrayal earns **Border Snarl** from both sides.

- **CrossRegion Hooks (quick integration):**

- *Ubral (Stone & Oath)*: A **Ducal Warrant** acts as a *GuestToken* once at a clan hearth, but starts a **Feud Rekindled** tick if you collect tolls twice in a tenday.
- *Thepyrgos (Synod Law)*: A **Queen’s Audience** can suspend a synod interdict but starts *Whispered Precedent* in Thepyrgos.
- *Vhasia (Fractured Sun)*: A **Duel Sanction** is recognized on the PontduTithe but a rival abbey can turn it into *Parlement Divided* on a Club draw.
- *Theona (No Ninth)*: **Ferry Priority** overrides a local taboo once; if the Ninth custom is in play, the writ “forgets” one clause on use (GM banks 1 SB).

Conspiracy Flourishes (keep it close, keep it quiet)

- **Hedge-Moots at Dusk**: Parish elders “trim hedges” while trading sealed whispers.
- **Cipher Roses**: Folded writs stamped with thornpetals; one petal missing marks a false clause.
- **Mirror Hours**: Beacons flash lawful signals reversed for those who know the countercode.
- **Eel-Letters**: Oiled parchment smuggled in eelbaskets; ink runs in water, truth does not.
- **Quiet Steel, Quieter Quills**: Dawnknights duel at first light; advocates settle three duels before breakfast with ink alone.
- **Progress Masks**: Courtiers wear legal devices as masque motifs (seal, chain, beacon) to signal faction at a glance.
- **Bell Penance**: A single offhour peal grants amnesty to those who confess a clause before the twelfth echo.
- **The Brightside Prayer**: Whispering the dead king’s name before a legal proceeding is said to turn the judge’s heart or curse the speaker.

Patronage & Power

In Viterra, power flows through the careful application of law, the management of ancient rights, and the delicate balance between imperial legacy and reclaimed sovereignty. The Warrior Queen maintains authority through a combination of military might and legal precision, while the old duchies and local officials wield influence through their knowledge of traditional customs and hedgelaw. The true power lies with those who can navigate this complex legal landscape and maintain the appearance of legitimate authority while building genuine support.

But remember in Viterra, law is warfare. Every document is a weapon, every courtroom a battlefield, and every advocate a soldier. The pen cuts as deep as any blade, and legal victory can be as decisive as military conquest. And beneath it all runs the shadow of the dead king, Baldwyn Brightstide, whose brief reign and sudden death left a wound that has not healed. The Queen's rule is lawful but is it *right*? The earls whisper. The barons scheme. The ghost of the past walks the hedgerows at dusk.

For the GM: Patronage in Viterra revolves around legal documents, local rights, and the ability to command respect from institutions still finding their postimperial identity. Rewards often take the form of writs, charters, and official positions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize the fragile crown and the contested succession:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, writs, charters) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided especially if they bear the dead king's seal.
- Let rival duchies and Vhasian claimants issue conflicting authorities, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the courts, parishes, and muster grounds as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of law and custom determines success.
- When legal conflicts escalate beyond words, transition naturally to physical confrontation with appropriate stakes.
- Introduce the **Succession's Shadow** as a recurring complication: old loyalties, forged documents, and the ghost of the dead king can upend any legal certainty.

In Viterra, your papers are your power, and your power determines whether you rule or are ruled. But when words fail, steel speaks and the law says both are valid. The Queen's Peace is a contract. She has signed it in blood. Will you?

Chapter 6

Thepyrgos

City of a Thousand Stairs.

Every stair climbed is a word in the great conversation between earth and sky. This city is not built it is grown, stone by stone, law by law, until the very architecture speaks wisdom.

I am a Bell-Runner. I know every step that creaks a warning and every landing that whispers gossip. The bells tell the city's mood better than any lord three chimes means business, six means trouble, and nine means the hunters are coming.

The Synod rules here with the delicacy of a brick wrapped in velvet they hate unsanctioned magic like it's a personal insult, but they adore infrastructure, especially when it's shiny, expensive, and comes with a side of indulgences they can sell to the faithful. The Chain-Lanterns move at dawn, their brass censers swinging, their bells tuned to the frequency of latent magic. In the university's forbidden tiers, the Witness and the Ninth arm rival fraternities with citations and curses, and no one is sure which side the Archon secretly favours.

Never let a bell-ringer count your breaths. The Chain-Lanterns pay well for names that ring false on the test stairs.

Sofia, Bell-Runner, who ties a knot in her hair for each hunter she has outrun

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Flatbread with olive oil and a boiled egg if you are a clerk. If you are a student, bread and water. If you are a professor, bread, water, and a

single fig. The fig is a status symbol. The status is "I have not been audited."

What does a child learn before they can walk? To read a bell schedule. Thepyrgos runs on bellsdawn bells, market bells, curfew bells, trial bells. A child who cannot read the bells cannot cross the city without a guardian. A child without a guardian is a child who will be sold to the university for dissection.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their step count. Thepyrgos has a thousand stairs. A stranger who counts them aloud is either a pilgrim or a spy. A stranger who climbs them in silence is either a native or a ghost.

What is the most common crime? Unsanctioned magic. The Synod licenses every spell cast within the walls. An unlicensed cantrip is a misdemeanour. An unlicensed healing is a felony. An unlicensed summoning is a death sentence not for the caster, who will be executed, but for the summoned, who will be bound to the city's foundation as a "structural consultant."

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Silent Stair is not silent. It whispers. The whispers are the confessions of the deadscholars who died in the university's service, their secrets recorded in the stone. The Chain-Lanterns listen. They do not share.

Where do people go when they die? To the catacombs beneath the university. The catacombs are a library of bones. Each skeleton is labelled with the scholar's name, their thesis, and the date of their death. The unlabelled bones are the ones who died before they could finish. They are still writing.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You submit a "retraction" to the Synod's Committee on Ethical Correction. The retraction must be published in the public square, read aloud by a herald, and witnessed by at least three notaries. The fee is 50 silver. The shame is free.

What is the most important festival? The Convocation of the Steps (summer solstice). Every citizen climbs the thousand stairs to the upper citadel. At the top, the Archon reads the names of the dead from the past year. The names are carved into the steps as they are read. The steps are getting crowded.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Archon is a fraud. He never passed the Synod's examination. His degree was purchased from a disgraced dean whose signature is forged on every document. The forger is still alive. They live in the catacombs. They have the original quill.

6.1 Thepyrgos — “The City of Unfinished Proofs”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Every stair is a question. Every answer is a debt. The Ninth and the Witness argue over who holds the receipt.*

The Archon (Elite): “Every stair climbed is a word in the great conversation between earth and sky. This city is not built it is grown, stone by stone, law by law, until the very architecture speaks wisdom. But the stairs remember more than the living. They remember the ones who never came down.”

Bell-Runner (Commoner): “I know every step that creaks a warning and every landing that whispers gossip. The bells tell the city’s mood better than any lord three chimes means business, six means trouble, and nine means the hunters are coming. But on the ninth bell, the stairs themselves answer.”

Genre / Mood: Scholarly vertical city, Byzantine bureaucracy, Grecian folk horror in the hinterlands, metaphysical war between memory and forgetting.

Starting Location: The Synod Hall at dusk. Goldglass mosaics glitter as a Matriarch reads a scroll aloud. “The Beacon Crown sees traitors in the smoke. A child’s talent was sold to the Commissary last night. Find the informer or the next stair seized will be yours. And if you hear a stair creak where none exists, do not turn around. The Ninth is counting.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Thepyrgos is both realm and city, built on the bones of the drowned **Astroegro Empire**. The capital rises in tiers of towers, terraces, and endless stairs above the Dolmis shore but the stairs are not stone. They are *fossilised vertebrae*, the spine of a leviathan that Khemesh dragged under when the last emperor broke a covenant older than the sea. Once a Utaran province, now a nation unto itself, Thepyrgos is famed for its universities, libraries, and debating synods, where precedent and philosophy weigh as much as pikes or coin.

The Astroegro were a human civilisation of formidable magic, the ancient rivals of the **Valewood’s Empire of Leaves**. Their ruins litter the hills and swamps south of the city, and their legacy haunts every threshold. When the Empire of Leaves fell, **Lethai-thora** refugees high elves who had served as archivists and lorekeepers fled across the Black River and were granted sanctuary in Thepyrgos. Generations later, their descendants still walk the city’s tiers, their silver hair and inkstained fingers a quiet reminder of a pact older than the synod. Many now hold chairs at the university, tend the forbidden archives, or secretly serve the Witness or the Ninth.

Outside the city, the countryside is a rugged coastal landscape of limestone hills, olive groves, and whitewashed villages but the weather is warmer, wetter, and the valleys are choked with reedfilled marshes. This is the land of the **Hyro** people, the surviving descendants of the Astroegro. The Hyro carry the fracture of their ancestors in their blood. A child born in the hills might dream in geometries that do not exist. A farmer might hear the stones whispering in a language no living throat can shape. The **ChainLanterns** and other WitchHunter Commissariats ruthlessly patrol these villages, using bounty postings, candlesmoke tests, and stairseizures to identify and kidnap children with arcane talent. The Hyro have learned to offer *substitutes* a memory, a false name, a lock of hair at crossroads, hoping the Hollow

accepts the payment.

In the university's forbidden tiers, the **Witness** and the **Ninth** fight a proxy war via fraternal orders and occult mystery cults. The Witness wants the **Astroegro Vaults** *remembered* but sealed; the Ninth wants them *opened*, to trigger a Great Unlearning that would erase the concept of debt from the world. No one is sure which side the Archon secretly favors. And in the ruins of the Astroegro, something still ticks gears of black glass, locked doors that hum, and the occasional survivor with eyes like burning tar who speaks of a pressure from below.

What you notice first: The endless chime of bells from different tiers, never quite in sync. The smell of brine, olive oil, and candle wax. The way locals glance at the sky when a child coughs and then at the nearest crossroads. The quiet grace of the Lethai-thora archivists, who never seem to blink.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never let a bellringer count your breaths. The ChainLanterns pay well for names that ring false on the test stairs. But worse: never ask a question of a stair that has no end. The Ninth is listening, and it will answer.

Regional Mood: Stairs, Bells, and the Argument of Patrons

Here, every ascent is a plea and every descent a confession. Thepyrgos the city is a vertical labyrinth of stairrights, ropeguilds, and synod edicts that shift with the tide. Thepyrgos the province is a haunted countryside of hidden talent and statesanctioned abduction. The Hyro keep their arcane children in root cellars and haylofts, praying the hunters take the neighbour's instead. The ChainLanterns move at dawn, their brass censers swinging, their bells tuned to the frequency of latent magic. In the university's forbidden tiers, the Witness and the Ninth arm rival fraternities with citations and curses, and no one is sure which side the Archon secretly favors. The Lethai-thora maintain the great archives, but they are divided some serve the Witness as faithful recorders, others whisper to the Ninth in darkened scriptoria. And in the ruins of the Astroegro, something still ticks gears of black glass, locked doors that hum, and the occasional survivor with eyes like burning tar who speaks of a pressure from below.

Prominent NPCs of Thepyrgos

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Archon Konstantinos	Ruler of the city, elected by the wards	Balance the synod, the guilds, and the Commissariat	He wears a key around his neck; no one knows what it opens or that it is a key to the Ninth's Vault.

Matriarch Eleni	Synod primate, head of the Temple of Light’s synod	Keep the Everflame from reclaiming the province	She speaks once a session; when she does, the bells listen. She has never spoken the ninth word.
Commissary Kyrillos	ChainLantern commander	Purge all untutored magic from the province	His lantern shows not only latent talent but also the bearer’s greatest fear. He refuses to look into it himself.
Sofia	BellRunner (commoner exemplar)	Outrun the hunters and protect the hidden gifted	She ties a knot in her hair for each hunter she has outrun; her hair is a thicket. One knot is white a hunter she could not outrun.
Nomophylax Zoe	Lawscholar, master of citations	Reform the synod from within	She has never lost a case; her opponents have a habit of vanishing into the Unfinished Stair.
The Lighthouse-Patriarch	Reclusive seer of the Beacon Crown	Steer the city through the coming storm	He has no eyes only mirrors where his eyes should be. In the mirrors you see the faces of those who owe the Ninth.

Keeper (Lethai-thora)	Lian	High Archivist of the Library of Keys	Preserve the Astroegro records and keep the Ninth's cult from the deepest vaults	She has not spoken aloud in twenty years. She writes on water. The water never freezes.
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Names of Thepyrgos

Inspired by the southern peninsulas and the Aegean coast: clear vowels, soft endings, and surnames that recall a stair, a tower, or a village. Lethai-thora names are longer, more flowing, often ending in -iel, -ael, -ir.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Konstantinos	Eleni	Skalas	<i>the StairWise</i>
Dimitris	Zoe	Platanos	<i>the Unseen</i>
Kyrillos	Sofia	Raptis	<i>BellSworn</i>
Nikolas	Anastasia	Laskaris	<i>the Accursed</i>
Leonidas	Irini	Makris	<i>AshFinger</i>
Stephanos	Fotini	Koutroulis	<i>the Silent</i>
Aerendil	Lian	Thoraen	<i>Archivist</i>

(Tower/Stair/Seawall) Pilgrim's Stair zigzagging seacliff to wicket gate; Tower Quarter with family keeps stitched by ladders and bridges.

Spades — Places

2. **Pilgrim's Stair** — Zigzagging seacliff to wicket gate; ascent as devotion. '[TRAVEL]': '[RITUAL]' *Every hundredth step has a bell. Pilgrims ring once for mercy, twice for memory. The ninth bell has no clapper.*
3. **Tower Quarter** — Family keeps stitched by ladders and bridges; vertical neighbourhoods. '[SOCIAL]': *The lowest rung of each ladder is painted red a toll for the ropeguild. The ropeguild's ledger is written in disappearing ink.*
4. **Chain-Barbican** — Harbor gate; capstans ready to raise the boom at horn's call. '[AUTHORITY]': *The capstan pins are carved from the thighbones of executed smugglers. The bones still warm in your hand.*
5. **Blue Cistern** — Under the forum; cool echo, strict tally; water as law. '[MAGIC]': '[DEBT]': *The water tastes of copper and old prayers. Drink deep, and you may forget a debt but the water will remember your face.*
6. **Ropeyard Terrace** — Cranes walk cargo up slope by treadwheel; muscle and machinery. '[LABOR]': *The treadwheel operators sing in eights. The ninth beat is always silent that is when the Stair moves.*

7. **Storm-Wall Arcades** — Wind shrieks through arched galleries; defense as architecture. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The wind carries voices from the last siege. Some say they’re warnings. Others say they’re the Ninth rehearsing.*
8. **Beacon Crown** — Ring of watchtowers signaling along the Dolmis; eyes of the city. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The beacons burn juniper and saltpeter. Black smoke means fire; white smoke means hunters. Green smoke means the Stair is hungry.*
9. **Library of Keys** — Archive vaults; shelves locked by rung and rite; knowledge as power. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[SECRET]’ *The keys are graded by sin. The ninth key opens nothing and everything. It is kept in a box that has no lid.*
10. **Siege Court** — Test ramp and scarred stones; war never far from peace. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The ramp’s stones are stained with lamp oil and regret. Practice charges end in the cistern or the Unfinished Stair.*
- J **Ladder Monastery** — Perched on a needle of rock; monks climb toward truth. ‘[RITUAL]’ *The monks never speak. They write commandments in chalk on the rungs. The ninth rung has no chalk only a smear of ash.*
- Q **Synod Hall** — Goldglass mosaics; judgment audible at a whisper’s distance. ‘[LAW]’ *The acoustics are enchanted. A lie told here echoes twice once in the liar’s voice, once in truth’s. The Ninth’s lies echo only once.*
- K **Archon’s Citadel** — Acropolis peak; mirror tiles glare like noon’s justice. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The mirrors were a gift from Kahfagia. They show not the sea, but the faces of debtors and sometimes a stair that was not there before.*
- A **The Unfinished Stair** — A hidden flight that appears only to those who have asked a question the Synod cannot answer. ‘[THRESHOLD]’ ‘[MYSTERY]’ *The stairs have no end. Each step is a different year. At the top, the Ninth and the Witness are playing knucklebones with forgotten names.*

(Archon/Synod/Guild) Bellrunner child whose feet know every stair by heart; Master of Ropes with palms like oak, voice like a whistle.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Bell-Runner** — Child whose feet know every stair by heart; speed as currency. ‘[STEALTH]’ *She ties a knot in her hair for each hunter she has outrun; her hair is a thicket. One knot is white a hunter she could not outrun.*
3. **Master of Ropes** — Palms like oak, voice like a whistle; guild head of lifters. ‘[LABOR]’ *He lost two fingers to a frayed line. He keeps them in a jar as a warning. The jar is on the ninth shelf.*
4. **Icon-Smith** — Portable shrine, temper about pigment; faith in detail. ‘[CRAFT]’ *His pigments are ground from stolen icons. He calls it recycling the divine. The Ninth calls it preparation.*
5. **Wall Strategos** — Drills levies on the test ramp; defense as daily ritual. ‘[COMBAT]’ *She lost a son to a Linn raid. She trains orphans now and keeps a list. The list has nine names.*
6. **Chain-Keeper** — Harbor boom; hates “surprises” at dusk; order as obsession. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *His bell never rings the same note twice. He says the tide changes its mind. The Ninth changes its tone.*

7. **Oath-Examiner** — Weighs words like iron; notary of truth and consequence. '[LAW]' *She carries a scale with one pan empty. The empty pan is for lies. When the Ninth speaks, both pans tip.*
8. **Archive Sister (Lethai-thora)** — Key to the “forbidden rung”; keeper of dangerous knowledge. '[SECRET]' *Her left eye is milkwhite a price for reading a cursed shelf. The shelf was a stair in a past life.*
9. **Salt-Fish Syndic** — Warehouse queen of the quays; profit in preservation. '[TRADE]' *Her salt is cut with ground bone meal. The fish stay fresh and quiet. The bones were from a stair.*
10. **Nomophylax** — Lawscholar whose citations close mouths; precedent as weapon. '[LAW]' *He has never lost a case. His opponents have a habit of vanishing. The Unfinished Stair has a new step.*
- J **Palikar Captain** — Tower guards; ladderquick and lettershy; strength in motion. '[COMBAT]' *His shield is painted with a ladder each rung a battle he survived. The ninth rung is blank.*
- Q **Matriarch of the Ladder** — Synod primate; calm as stone, wisdom in height. '[AUTHORITY]' *She speaks once a session. When she does, the bells listen. She has never spoken the ninth word.*
- K **The Archon** — Elected, entrenched, counting bells; ruler of the ascent. '[AUTHORITY]' *He wears a key around his neck. No one knows what it opens. The key is a stair.*
- A **Lighthouse-Patriarch** — Reclusive seer; said to steer beacons in storms. '[MYSTERY]' *He has no eyes only mirrors where his eyes should be. In the mirrors you see the Unfinished Stair.*

(Edict/Quake/Chain) Tremor with hairline cracks racing down a stair; crowds freeze; iconoclast riot in the Tower Quarter.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Tremor** — Hairline cracks race down a stair; crowds freeze, dust speaks. '[DISASTER]' *The dust spells names. Yours appears if you've broken a stairright or if the Ninth is curious.*
3. **Iconoclast Riot** — In the Tower Quarter; pigments and teeth fly through the air. '[SOCIAL]' '[COMBAT]' *The riot started over a missing icon's eye. The eye was a hunter's informer. The icon was a stair.*
4. **Chain Jam** — At the barbican; capstan pins shear at the worst moment. '[TRAVEL]' *The pins were filed by a saboteur. The chain will hold or not. The Ninth is taking bets.*
5. **Black Northerly** — Pins cranes; cargo hangs between tiers, prayers below. '[WEATHER]' *The wind smells of iron and ice. Someone is using weather magic. The Witness disapproves.*
6. **Cistern Taint** — Sour water; inspectors padlock spouts, thirst rises. '[DEBT]' *The taint is sweet too sweet. Someone poisoned the cistern to flush out a talent. The talent is a stair.*
7. **Synod Summons** — A chant or badge is suddenly proscribed; law shifts like wind. '[LAW]' *The summons is written on a bellclapper. Read it, and you are a witness. The Ninth writes the margin.*
8. **Rope Guild Interdict** — No lifts until a grievance is heard; the city stops climbing. '[LABOR]' *The guild's grievance is a single name. The name is yours. The name is also a stair.*
9. **Siege Drill Panic** — Practice horns mistaken for real; chaos in the ranks. '[FEAR]' *The*

horns were blown by a child who didn't know the difference. Or did they? The child is a step.

10. **Smuggler's Ladder** — Discovered; the whole stair sealed, routes rerouted. '[STEALTH]' '[DEBT]' *The ladder was built by a Hyro family. Now they are all “guests” of the Commissariat. Their house is a stair.*
- J **Ropeyard Fire** — Sparks leap uphill faster than boots; smoke chokes the ascent. '[DISASTER]' *The fire was set to cover a kidnapping. The victim's name is on the bounty board. The board is a stair.*
- Q **Exarch's Claim** — “Thepyrgos under my protection”; arrests follow the papers. '[AUTHORITY]' *The Exarch is a puppet of the ChainLanterns. His seal is a bell without a clapper. The Ninth has the clapper.*
- K **General Watch** — All towers manned; levies seize carts “for the walls.” '[AUTHORITY]' *The levies are looking for one thing: children who flinch at candle smoke. The children are stairs.*
- A **The Unfinished Stair Awakens** — A hidden flight appears in the middle of a crowded tier. The Ninth's attention falls. '[THRESHOLD]' '[BOSS]' *The stairs have no end. The Witness is writing. The Ninth is counting. You are already on the third step.*

(Key/Rite/Paper) Stair token passes a barricaded stair without delay; harbor pass lowers the boom for your vessel on command.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Stair Token** — Pass a barricaded stair without delay (once); height as right. '[TRAVEL]' *The token is a bronze step. It fits into a missing rung. The missing rung is a secret.*
3. **Harbor Pass** — Boom lowers for your vessel on command; sea as ally. '[TRAVEL]' *The pass is a note written on a fish scale. The gatekeeper will not ask why. The fish was a witness.*
4. **Cistern Draw-Right** — A named ward during scarcity; water as favor. '[SOCIAL]' *The right is a clay cup. Break it to claim your share. The cup was a stair.*
5. **Crane Allotment** — One guaranteed lift on the Ropeyard Terrace; height as service. '[LABOR]' *The allotment is a knotted rope. Cut a knot for each use. The ninth knot is a lie.*
6. **Icon License** — Display a disputed image without penalty; faith as leverage. '[SOCIAL]' *The license is stamped with the Archon's ring. The ring is warm the Archon is watching. The ring is a stair.*
7. **Archive Hour** — Library of Keys; one shelf opened to you; knowledge as power. '[SECRET]' *The shelf is sealed with a riddle. Solve it, or the key will break. The riddle is about the ninth step.*
8. **Bellmark** — Lawful right to ring a tower bell (summons the watch); sound as law. '[AUTHORITY]' *The bellmark is a brand on your palm. Show it, and the watch bleeds for you once. The blood is a witness.*
9. **Watchlight Code** — Today's beacon and mirror signals; navigation as paper. '[TRAVEL]' *The code is written in lemon juice. Heat it to read, then hide it again. The heat is a confession.*
10. **Synod Indulgence** — One proscribed chant or rite permitted (for you). '[MAGIC]' *The indulgence is a bellnote held in a jar. Break the jar to release it. The bellnote is a name.*
- J **Pronoia Grant** — Temporary farm/tax of a terrace hamlet; land as income. '[TRADE]' *The grant is a wooden token. Present it to the village elder if she is still alive. The elder is a stair.*

- Q Synod Audience** — Private with the Matriarch and clerks; wisdom as policy. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The audience is held in a fog hollow. What is spoken there is never written. The fog is a witness.*
- K Archon’s Writ** — Palikars escort you between towers; authority as escort. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The writ is a bellrope. Tie it to your belt, and the guards will know your voice. The rope was a stair.*
- A Golden Key** — Open or seal any city gate once; access as power. ‘[MAGIC]’ *The key is a finger bone. The lock is a gauntleted fist. It will work once. The fist is the Ninth’s.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (25 → 4, 610 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (keys/rites/papers) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **height and sound** motifs bells that carry, wind that remembers, stairs that echo with purpose.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Bell-Law:** Bells are law made sound. Once per session, a Bellmark or tower bell summons the watch, a levy, or a decree. False rings stain a reputation; the Synod may inquire. The ninth ring is never false it is always the Ninth.
- **Stair-Rights:** Every stair is owned, owed, or leased. A token bypasses barricades and tolls; climbing the wrong stair without leave sparks a riot or a duel. The Unfinished Stair has no owner only a debtor.
- **The Unfinished Stair Clock [6]:** Tracks the party’s entanglement with the hidden architecture of Thepyrgos. Tick it when you use a hidden stair, ask a question the Synod cannot answer, or speak a true name of an Astroegro ruin. At 6 segments, the party discovers a *new* hidden stair one that leads to an Astroegro Vault but they are also *marked*. The Witness’s attention falls on them. Their reflections in mirrors begin to lag by a heartbeat. The ChainLanterns receive a vision of their faces. Reduce the clock by feeding a memory to the Ninth’s Coterie (lose a fact, a skill point, or a Bond) or by recording a truth in the Synod’s archives (gain Obligation to the Witness).
- **The Offering at the Crossroads (Hedge Gift):** Once per session, a Hyro character (or someone who has learned their customs) may leave a *substitute* at a crossroads a written name, a lock of hair, a childhood memory. For the next scene, they are *invisible to the ChainLanterns* (cannot be tracked or identified by candle smoke). The substitute becomes a *Debt Token* that the GM may cash in later (the Hollow accepted it; the Hollow will ask for more).
- **The CandleSmoke Test (GM Tool):** When the ChainLanterns test a village, the GM rolls 1d6. On a 1-2, they find a gifted child (the party must intervene or witness a tragedy). On a 3-4, they find a substitute (a false name, a hidden memory) and leave. On a 5-6, the village has already paid in silence no raid occurs. The party can influence the roll by offering their own substitute (use a Boon to shift the result by 1).
- **The Astroegro Singing (Player Tool):** A Hyro character can hum a fragment of an old empire song. The song has no words only pressure. When hummed at a ruin, it may open a

hidden door. When hummed at a ChainLantern, it may cause their lantern to flicker. Each use advances the *Unfinished Stair* clock by 1 (the past is waking).

- **Lethai-thora Archivists:** The high elf refugees have integrated into the city’s scholarly elite. They are the keepers of the deepest archives and the most secret keys. A character with Lethai-thora heritage (or who earns their trust) may gain access to the *Archivists’ Mark* a brass key that opens one restricted door in the Library of Keys per session. However, the Archivists are not monolithic; some serve the Witness, others the Ninth. Choosing a side may alienate the other faction.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Unwritten Citation** The Witness. *A precedent that exists only in the margin.*
 - **The Bell-Founder** Mykkiel. *The law that rings true, even when it hurts.*
 - **The Abyssal Pressure** Khemesh. *The weight beneath the city; the debt that the deep remembers.*
 - **The Silent Stair** The Ninth. *The step that is never counted, the threshold that opens only once.*

The Astroegro Vaults

Beneath the city, nine vaults. The Synod knows of three and has sealed them with Witnessbranded wax. The Ninth’s Coterie has found a fourth. The other five are still buried, waiting for the right key a true name, a specific death, a memory that has never been spoken.

Each vault contains:

- A weapon (a bell that rings the target’s true name, a lens that shows the death of anyone you name, a stone that erases a page from the world’s ledger).
- A guardian (a spirit of an Astroegro archivist, bound to defend the vault with its last calculation).
- A cost (to open the vault, you must sacrifice something the empire valued a memory of salt water, a dream of drowning, a confession of hubris).

The Ninth’s Goal: Open all nine vaults simultaneously. The resulting “unlearning” would erase the concept of *debt* from the world. No one would owe anything to anyone. The Hollow would starve. The Witness would have nothing to record. The Ninth would become the only law: *forgetting*.

The Witness’s Goal: Keep the vaults sealed, but *remember* them perfectly. Every weapon, every secret, every crime of the Astroegro must be recorded in the Synod’s archives not to use, but to witness. The Witness does not want to prevent the Ninth’s plan; it wants to be *the one who writes down what happened*.

Lore Echoes (CrossExpansion Hooks)

- **The Astroegro Remnant (Khemesh):** Deep beneath the Beacon Crown, a sealed chamber contains a working Astroegro orrery. Its gears are carved from abyssal glass, and it still ticks. Those who listen too long hear a voice whispering the true names of drowned emperors. The ChainLanterns have posted a perpetual guard; they say the orrery is a beacon for something that should not surface.
- **Saint Methodia of the Silent Stair (The Witness):** A legendary archivist who climbed the Ninth Stair of the Library of Keys and never came down. Her ghost is said to appear to

those who speak a truth the Synod has buried, offering a single citation that can overturn any edict. The price is a secret of equal weight, and the ghost never forgets.

- **The CogCults of the Clockwork Monad:** Underground fraternities of gearsmiths and logicians who believe the Astroegro Empire fell because its geometry was imperfect. They meet in the basements of the Ropeyard Terrace, trying to reconstruct the lost orrery. The ChainLanterns tolerate them because their calculations sometimes predict talent blooms. Heretics from the Everflame call them clockworshippers; the CogCults call themselves the True Iterators.
- **The Daughters of the Cord (The Bitter Root):** A hospice in the lower tiers is run by greyrobed women who ask no payment, but they take names. They are tolerated because they treat the poor for free, but the Commissariat suspects they also hide gifted children. A renegade Sister hides among the bellrunners, trying to unbind her Hollowed from the ChainLanterns' ledger.
- **The Savage Heart (Red Maw):** In the highland villages west of the city, a bear cult has arisen. They believe the only way to escape the Commissariat's hunts is to become the hunter. They wear cured skins and speak in growls, and they have begun hunting ChainLantern patrols. The Archon has declared them outlaws, but the villagers leave offerings of raw meat at their shrines.
- **Zakov's Astroegro Foundation:** The pirate city of Zakov is built on top of a sunken Astroegro port. Smugglers occasionally pull up black glass artifacts from the deep channels, which find their way to Thepyrgos' black market. The Ninth's Coterie pays handsomely for such relics; the Witness's archivists try to buy them first.
- **The Ninth:** In any Thepyrgos scene, the ninth bell rung in an hour opens a threshold. The wise stop at eight and cover their ears. Those who ring the ninth are said to see a pale figure standing on the Beacon Crown's mirror tiles waiting to collect a name.

Thepyrgos Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Stair:** Toss a crust onto a rung before climbing. Ignore the first *Tremor* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Knot the Rope:** Tie a single knot in a crane line. Cancel *Rope Guild Interdict* or take 1 die on your next lift (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the Smoke:** Whisper a hunter's name into the Beacon Crown's fire. Gain +1 Effect when evading the ChainLanterns this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Synod. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Offer the Substitute:** Leave a written false name at a crossroads. The next CandleSmoke Test against you automatically fails but the Hollow gains a Debt Token on you. '[SUPERSTITION]'

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **tower guards or guild masters**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **bell-runners or civic patrols**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or archive keepers**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable ascent**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised: Wall Strategos or guild head** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **quake damage or stair closure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival faction or civic enforcer** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **palikars, guild enforcers, or synod guards** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes **bell rings falsely/stair collapses/law changes**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Archon, Matriarch, or Lighthouse-Patriarch** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically **quake hits/bells ring/bridge collapses**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Thepyrgos (Height & Law):** Stairs shift position, bells ring with the wrong tone, legal papers rewrite themselves.
- **Thepyrgos (Synod Power):** Edicts change midspeech, citations appear in the air, wisdom comes unbidden.
- **Thepyrgos (Vertical City):** Ropes fray without warning, cranes swing cargo unexpectedly, tower windows show wrong views.
- **Thepyrgos (The Unfinished Stair):** A hidden stair appears behind the party. The Ninth is counting. The Witness is writing. The stairs have no end.

The Magic Colleges (University Extensions)

- **College of Ladders & Lines** geomancy, architecture, constraint; stairs as sigils, capstans as circles.
- **College of Bells & Beacons** acoustics, omenfire, signal calculus; law made audible, augury made measurable.
- **College of Waters & Weights** alchemy, cistern rites, dyes; solutions, precipitates, and lawful flow.
- **College of Names & Oaths** nomikon theurgy; citations that bind, clauses that compel.

- **College of Mirrors & Haze** illusion, scrutiny; seeing, being seen, unbeing seen.
- **College of Quiet** ethics of death, memory rites; permitted remembrances anything more is heresy.

The WitchHunter Province (Commissariat Extensions)

ThepyrgostheProvince funds WitchHunter Commissariats ministries with bounties posted per ward. Notices hang on stairlandings; bells announce *hunts lawful and hunts less so*. The ChainLantern order is the most feared, but others compete for quotas.

Hunter Hearts (faces of the persecution)

- **Commissary-Exarch** Writs in triplicate; quotas in private.
- **Bounty-Reader** Weighs children like coin; “verification” by bell.
- **Pardoner-Chaplain** Sells absolution to informers; keeps a careful ledger.
- **Stair-Runner Informant** Knows which doors open to the right knock.
- **Chain-Lantern Captain** Commands the most feared order; his lantern reveals truth through flesh.

Hunter Clubs (pressures and sweeps)

- **Bounty Posting** New price on “untutored talent”; crowds turn into nets.
- **Candle-Smoke Test** Lines at the Blue Cistern; smoke curls toward the Gifted.
- **Commissary Sweep** Ladders chained; a whole tier searched under horn.
- **Quieted Child** An “accident” near the Exam Stair; evidence goes missing.
- **Chain-Lantern Raid** Dawn assault on a hamlet; children taken before the rooster crows.

Hunter Diamonds (leverage and reprieve)

- **Witness Pardon** Informer absolved and paid; cancels one legal fallout *once*.
- **Archon’s Clemency** Suspends a bounty clock for one named; bellmarked and public.
- **Hidden Stair Token** Through a maintenance run unseen; good for one group escape.

Detection & Denial (Fast Procedures)

Scry & Deny (evading the tests)

1. **Mask the Trace:** dye, salt, belloil; pick *one* (each grants +1 die to one approach).
2. **Pick the Test:** *Smoke, Sound, Mirror*. State how you spoof it (alchemical veil, bell overtones, angle games).
3. **On a hit:** cancel a **Candle-Smoke Test** or **Proctors’ Gate** tag for this scene. **Consequence:** start *Bell Debt* [2] or *Rector’s Notice* [2].

Bounty Economy (quick table, GM picks or 1d6)

1. *Whisperer* (faint talent): 1 purse; informers abundant.
2. *Spark-Hand* (cantrip): 2 purses; “rehabilitation” promised.
3. *Mirror-Bent* (glamour): 3 purses; seized at once.
4. *Bell-Singer* (acoustic): 4 purses; Synod claims jurisdiction.

5. *Oath-Breaker* (binding): 5 purses; Exarch insists on custody.
6. *Quiet-Worker* (deathethic): 6 purses; College of Quiet petitions for trial.

Scenario Starters (PlugandPlay)

The Bright Child on the Exam Stair *Hook:* A BellRunner begs you to get a latent child to campus before the dawn sweep. *Complications:* **Candle-Smoke Test**, **Commissary Sweep**, a jealous **Street Thaum**. *Relief:* Trade a *Latency Seal* for testimony; or ring a lawful *Bellmark* to create a corridor accept *Censure Murmurs* [2].

The Black Ledger of Bounties *Hook:* The College of Quiet wants proof that a Commissary inflates prices to fill quotas. *Complications:* **Synod Summons**, **Smuggler’s Ladder**, **Chain Jam**. *Relief:* Publish via a *Nomikon* colloquy (gain *Synod Indulgence*); or sell it to the Archon (gain *Archon’s Clemency* but start *Faculty Feud* [4]).

The Golden Key and the Silent Stair *Hook:* A dying Archivist gives you a Golden Key. “It opens the stair the hunters fear.” *Truth:* The stair leads to the Beacon Crown’s secret basement a prison for children who passed the smoke test. *Relief:* Free the children and expose the Commissariat (gain *Archon’s Clemency* for the whole party, but start *Exarch’s Claim* at full); or seal the stair forever (gain *Golden Key* to use elsewhere, but the children are lost to memory).

The Ninth Vault *Hook:* A fragment of an Astroegro weapon has been unearthed in a hill village. The Ninth’s Coterie and the Synod both want it. The village elder offers it to the party if they can offer a substitute that satisfies the Hollow. *Truth:* The weapon is a bell that rings the true name of anyone you name. Its guardian is the ghost of the Astroegro archivist who sealed it. The ghost will not speak to anyone who has not climbed the Unfinished Stair. *Relief:* Climb the stair, speak the archivist’s true name, and take the bell but the stair adds a segment to the Unfinished Stair Clock. Or destroy the bell with a memory of the Astroegro’s fall (lose a cherished memory permanently). Or give the bell to the Synod (gain a Synod Indulgence) or to the Ninth’s Coterie (gain a Debt Token from the Ninth).

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Stealth):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Fog Bank*.
- **Cut the Stair (Presence + Lore):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a stair token is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Quake (Body + Athletics):** On a hit in *Tremor*, you pick who keeps their footing; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Bell & Inquisition)

- **The Bell-Exarch (Nine Bans)** *Phases:* Candle-Smoke Sweep → Orchestrated Silence → Synod Coup. *Cracks:* ring a forgotten bell, expose a false bounty, survive a night in the Beacon Crown.
- **The Astroegro Engine (Pressure from Below)** *Phases:* Gears Turn → Whispers Become Names → Seiche. *Cracks:* abyssal glass shard, survivor testimony, the Lighthouse-Patriarch’s mirror turning clear.

- **The Ninth's Advocate (Living Stair)** *Phases:* Count → Omit → Forget. *Cracks:* speak a true name that the Ninth does not know, offer a memory the Witness has not recorded, climb the Unfinished Stair and refuse to answer the Ninth's question.

Patronage & Power

In Thepyrgos, power flows through elevation, education, and the precise application of law but also through the hidden architecture of the Unfinished Stair. The Archon maintains authority through a complex web of guilds, synods, and civic institutions, but the real power lies with whoever can climb the stairs that should not exist. Social mobility is literally upward mobility, with stairrights, bellmarks, and archive access serving as both currency and status symbols. But the highest status belongs to those who have seen the top of the Unfinished Stair and remembered how to return.

The Lethai-thora, as the city's most respected archivists, hold a special kind of power: they know which shelves are watched, which keys are false, and which doors lead to the Ninth's vaults. Some whisper that the Archon is secretly a Lethai-thora puppet; others say the real ruler is the ghost of an Astroegro emperor, still counting stairs in the deep.

For the GM: Patronage in Thepyrgos revolves around access to towers, to knowledge, to the right to climb, and to the hidden stairs. Rewards often take the form of keys, passes, or legal exemptions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize the metaphysical war:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, keys, papers) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival guilds and the two Patrons (Witness and Ninth) issue conflicting rights, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the synods, towers, and staircases as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of law and custom determines success but where the Ninth's silence and the Witness's memory can tip the scales.
- Introduce the Unfinished Stair clock as a campaign tension; every time the party uses a hidden stair, they advance the clock and bring the Ninth's attention closer.

In Thepyrgos, your ascent is your standing, and your standing determines whether you rise or fall or whether you are simply *forgotten*.

Part II

The Northern Reaches

“The mountain counts your breaths. The frost writes your name in ice. In the north, the dead do not wait they walk, and they remember every promise you made to keep warm.” Dusana of the Raven Road

Chapter 7

Aeler

Crowns & Under-Vaults.

The mountain remembers every word carved in its stone, every seal pressed into its walls. To govern here is not to command, but to harmonize with the ancient songs that still echo in the deep places.

I am an Under-Mason. I can hear stone shift a room away. When the rock starts singing a different tune, you best listen. Three knocks in the morning means all's well, but three knocks at night means something's coming through the walls that wasn't meant to walk.

My homeland. The place where we don't trust the surface, but we do trust the weight of a well-placed keystone and oh, how the surface loves to test that trust. Our breath-bonds aren't just currency they're the hardest thing in the peaks, forged in the sighs of miners who knew too much. We sell them to Vilikari jarls who pay in furs stained with brother's blood, to Ykrul khagans who weigh the value in warhorses and broken oaths. Once, we sold one to the Veiled Sisters. They paid in secrets which is another way of saying they paid in future leverage.

Never count your breaths aloud in a mine. The mountain listens, and if it hears you reach the ninth, it will take one a breath, a memory, a shadow. My grandfather reached nine once. He lived another thirty years, but he never cast a shadow again.

Thromm Stone-Tongue, Under-Mason, who has never counted to nine

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Stone-bread and cave cheese the bread is baked on heated stone slabs, the cheese is aged in sealed galleries where the temperature never varies. The cheese has been aging for three generations. It is an heirloom. It is also barely edible.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count their breaths. Aeler children wear breath-counters small brass bells on leather cords. Eight breaths, ring the bell. Nine breaths, run. A child who cannot count is a child who will not survive the winter.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their bell. Every Aeler carries a bell tuned to their breath. A stranger's bell will ring at a different pitch the mountain's lungs are calibrated to local frequencies. A mismatched bell is a warning. A silent bell is a threat.

What is the most common crime? Air theft. In the deep vaults, ventilation is shared. A sealed door, a blocked vent, a diverted shaft these are thefts of breath, punishable by breath-debt. The guilty party must donate their own air ration to the victim. The donation is measured in days. The days are counted by bells.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The True Masons are not neutral. They are the Vault-Queen's eyes. Every "independent" repair, every "neutral" inspection, every "routine" audit the True Masons are watching. They do not report to the Queen. They are the Queen. They have always been the Queen.

Where do people go when they die? To the Deep Vault the oldest galleries, where the air is thin and the stone is cold. The dead are not buried. They are sealed in niches carved into the walls, their names chiselled above their heads. The niches are reused every century. The names are never erased. The dead share walls with strangers. The strangers are patient.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a keystone a load-bearing stone from your own holding. The stone is installed in the wronged party's wall. If it holds, you are forgiven. If it cracks, the debt stands. If it crumbles, your holding collapses. Apology is architecture. Architecture is law.

What is the most important festival? The Ringing of the Underways (deep winter). Every bell in every hold is rung at the same hour eight times, no more. The sound travels through the stone, a heartbeat that reminds the mountain that the living are still here. The dead listen. The dead do not ring back.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Vault-Queen is a construct. She was assembled in 723 AR, after the real queen died in a cave-in. Her heart is a keystone. Her breath is a bellows. Her voice is a recording. The True Masons maintain her. They have the schematics. The schematics are missing three pages. The missing pages describe how to turn her off.

7.1 Aeler (Dwarves) — “Crowns & Under-Vaults”

Elite (Vault-Queen of a crownland)

“The mountain remembers every word carved in its stone, every seal pressed into its walls. To govern here is not to command, but to harmonize with the ancient songs that still echo in the deep places. But the deep places also sing other songs — songs that forget the living.”

Commoner (Under-Mason who can hear stone shift a room away)

“When the stone starts singing a different tune, you best listen. Three knocks in the morning means all’s well, but three knocks at night means something’s coming through the walls that wasn’t meant to walk. My grandfather called it the pressure that thinks. He walked into the deep one day and never came back. The mountain answered his knock. It always does.”

Crowns & Under-Vaults

The Aeler Kingdoms hold the mountains by breath, bell, and bargain. Dozens of sovereign holds — some sealed for centuries, others trading openly with lowland markets — share only the deep roots of stone and the supremacy of the High King Beneath the Peaks. Their halls run like arteries, their cities open in thunderous caverns where bridges leap between ribs of stone and cisterns shine like night skies turned inward. *Survival* is the first law: air is counted, water is bartered, light is rationed by wick and prayer. *Tradition* is the second: seals are kept, measures remain true, and the dead keep their offices as carefully as the living. Between the two, a people learn to argue quietly and build loudly.

Collectives (clans, guild-kin, lamp-companies) own what the mountain allows; individuals are custodians by oath. Trade runs under and over the range through underways and passforts, stitching protectorates and lowland markets to vaultmouth gates. When tunnels whisper or the air tastes wrong, the Aeler move as one animal; when the Kingsmoot calls, crowns and abbesses argue in bellcode and sealed writs until the stone itself seems to lean in.

But beneath the order, beneath the breath-counters and the ledger-stones, something older stirs. The Aeler do not speak of it directly. They call it *the pressure that thinks* — a presence that lives in the deepest galleries, in the spaces between sealed holds, in the darkness where bells have not rung for centuries. It does not attack. It *invites*. Miners who wander too deep return with no memory of why they went. Others do not return at all. The pressure does not hate. It is patient. And it is always, always listening.

The Pressure That Thinks The Deep Drake

Deep beneath the oldest mountains, beyond the Ninth Seal and past the last lamplighter’s mile, there is a presence. The Aeler do not name it a dragon or a wyrm; they have no word for what it is. They call it *the pressure that thinks* — a weight in the stone that feels like curiosity, a whisper in the dark that sounds like your own name spoken with concern. It has no lair that any living Aeler has seen, but the rumour persists: a vast chamber of black glass and fossilised bone, where the heat of the earth meets the cold of the void. In that chamber lies the Deep Drake — an ancient wyrm of psychic hunger that feeds not on flesh but on *attention*. It draws the living toward it not through force, but through a gentle, irresistible lure: a halfremembered tune, a forgotten oath, a face you thought you had left behind. You walk toward it because you believe you have business there. You have no business there.

The Deep Drake does not kill. It *collects*. Its victims become part of its hoard – not corpses, but still, silent figures that sit in the dark, their eyes open, their mouths moving silently as they repeat the last promise they ever made. The Aeler have learned to live with the pressure. They seal off tunnels that grow too warm. They never answer a knock that comes in three. They count their breaths not out of habit, but out of a deep, unspoken fear that the ninth breath might be the one the pressure answers.

Hooks for the GM:

- A sealed hold has not answered the Kingsmoot in nine years. The pressure is whispering through the stone. The party is sent to investigate – or to seal the hold permanently.
- A miner returns from the deep with no memory of the past week, but their shadow now moves independently. The pressure is using them as a messenger.
- The Deep Drake does not attack. It *negotiates*. It offers forgotten secrets, lost treasures, or safe passage through its territory – in exchange for a single memory of sunlight. The party must decide what to trade.

The Fractured Crowns: Aeler Faction Spectrum

Aeler society is not monolithic. Beneath the High King’s nominal authority, each crownland follows its own star. Attitudes toward the surface range from open partnership to militant isolation, and even the most reclusive holds maintain **Edgewalker** contacts to monitor the world above.

- **Traditionalist / “The Old Ways”** – These holds idealize the ancient mountainempire: closed gates, iron tariffs, and the certain knowledge that surfacedwellers cannot be trusted. They resemble the dwarves of fireside tales: stubborn, insular, and quick to reach for an axe when a human mentions “progress.” Their kings speak of the days when no foreigner stepped past the vaultmouth. They also speak of the pressure in whispers, and they seal any tunnel that shows signs of warmth. *Clocks: FOREIGNER SUSPICION [4], HOLD SEALED [6]*.
- **Cooperative / “Open Hand”** – These holds trade freely with Aelaerem, Kahfagia, and even the Vilikari. They staff the undermarkets, send engineers to repair bridges in Viterra, and treat the surface as a resource to be managed, not a threat to be shunned. They prefer soft power: standardised measures, certified weights, and bellcode protocols that make others *want* to trade on Aeler terms. They are also the most likely to send expeditions into the deep, seeking lost holds – and the most likely to lose miners to the pressure. *Clocks: TRADE ROUTE PROSPERITY [6], CULTURAL FRICTION [4]*.
- **Isolationist / “Silent Stone”** – Deep holds that have not answered a Kingsmoot call in living memory. Their gates are lost, their peoples rumoured to have turned inward, worshiping forgotten depths – or to have become part of the pressure’s hoard. They neither help nor harm the surface – but when a White Flood or a gas flare occurs, their silence becomes a hazard of its own. The Deep Drake is said to lair somewhere beneath the Silent Stone holds. *Clocks: SILENT HOLD AWAKENS [8], ANCIENT GRUDGE [6]*.

Most Aeler characters and settlements fall somewhere between these poles, and the same hold might shift its stance over a season, depending on grain prices, a new VaultQueen, or a disaster that forces its hand.

The Breath Count – Habit, Not Function

Among the Aeler, counting breaths is not merely a safety measure – it is a cultural reflex, as automatic as a human’s heartbeat. Aeler children learn to count in eights before they learn to speak. They tap

their fingers, their bells, their spoons in rhythms of eight. They never, ever count to nine aloud. The ninth breath is not a number; it is a *gap* the space where the pressure listens. Aeler who forget to count in eights are considered unreliable, possibly touched by the deep. Those who deliberately count to nine are shunned; they are thought to have invited the pressure to notice them.

Mechanical note: Breathcounting is not a skill roll or a resource to track. It is a narrative and cultural tic. The GM may use a characters failure to observe the count as a trigger for a complication (e.g., the mountain shifts, a bell rings falsely, a character feels watched). Conversely, an Aeler who scrupulously counts their breaths in eights may gain a small boon (e.g., +1 die to resist fear in confined spaces) as the mountains attention slides past them.

Prominent NPCs of Aeler

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Valthor Aezelbron	High King Beneath the Peaks	Preserve the ancient concord and balance the crownlands	He has not spoken above a whisper in seven years. The court reads his will by bellcode.
Grunhelda Thrainsdottir	Vault-Queen of Irondeep	Expand trade routes while keeping the Old Ways satisfied	She keeps a pet geode that hums when a contract is fair and goes silent when the pressure is near.
Maeva Kaelen	Legate of the Under-Seal	Negotiate passage rights and standard measures with lowland realms	Her sealrod is carved from a fossilised root. She has never lost a tariff dispute.
Thromm StoneTongue	Under-Mason (Commoner exemplar)	Hear the mountains warnings and keep the tunnels safe	He can identify a false weight by tapping it once with his hammer. He has never counted to nine.

Orthen WhiteRib-bon	Tunnel Courier	Deliver sealed writs across hostile jurisdictions	He has run the Spine Underway in darkness without a lamp. Twice. He says the dark has a voice, but it only asks questions.
Lumenor Saela	Keeper of the Under-Altars	Maintain the breathrites and the old flame	She speaks only in bell tones during services. Her mundane voice is never heard.

Names of Aeler

Aeler names blend flowing vowels and soft diphthongs (ae, ei, ou, ui) with harsh consonants (k, th, z, r, g). Surnames are carved from mountain-roots: a hold, a forge, a seam, or a trade.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Thrain	Grunhelda	Aezenbron	<i>the Iron</i>
Kaelen	Maeva	Thrainkhar	<i>Breath-Steady</i>
Orthen	Saela	Valdurg	<i>Seal-Keeper</i>
Rurik	Aeldis	Kaelthane	<i>Bell-Tongue</i>
Bromm	Helka	Zarkul	<i>the Under-Mason</i>
Zelgur	Thorunn	Dornvael	<i>White-Ribbon</i>

Spades — Places (vaultmouths, descents, underways, crown seats)

- (Security/Gatekeeping) Vaultmouth Gate in a hillslope: bronze lungs for breath-tests, tally-niches for lamps.
- (Tradition/Oaths) Crown-Crypt Porch where oaths are sworn to sleeping kings.
- (Commerce/Underground) Under-Market: lantern alleys between cistern pillars; damp coin, dry wit.
- (Labor/Danger) Smoke-Shaft Stair spiraling up to a soot hatch; handprints black as seals.
- (Mystery/Whispers) Gloam Cistern—black water, lead scales, whispers carry too far.
- (Maintenance/Travel) Lamplighter's Mile on the Under-Road; niches sting with spent wicks.
- (Precision/Authority) Measure Vault: standard rods and weights chained under glass and oath.
- (Sacred/Knowledge) Reliquary Arcade: bell-chimes answer drafts; saints keep their own tallies.
- (Military/Strategic) Twin-Throne Gate—surface fortress straddling a chasm bridge.

- J (Knowledge/Secrecy) Deep Archive Stacks behind grillwork; scriptoria cells breathe ink and dust.
- Q (Royalty/Privilege) Queen’s Descent: private stair from palace to royal vault-house.
- K (Politics/Power) Kingsmoot Cavern—crownstones in a ring around a bottomless dark.
- A (Infrastructure/Majesty) The Spine Underway, a great tunnel linking crownlands beneath the peaks.

Hearts — People & Factions (crowns, keepers, guilds, legates)

- 2. (Apprenticeship/Dedication) Lamplighter apprentice with a jingling key-ring and soot in the lungs.
- 3. (Craft/Knowledge) Under-Mason who can hear stone shift a room away.
- 4. (Authority/Duty) Vault Warden with breath-ledger and seal-rods; patient as granite.
- 5. (Protection/Faith) Censer-Knight of the Dawn – fights miasma and men with equal zeal.
- 6. (Sacred/Craft) Key-Sister (monastic locksmith) who names wards like prayers.
- 7. (Commerce/Authority) Under-Market assessor whose stamp can starve or save a stall.
- 8. (Engineering/Expertise) Engineer of Underways (geometer) with rod, hammer, and the right maps.
- 9. (Tradition/Law) Oath-Keeper of the Crown Crypt – memory like iron, smile like law.
- 10. (Diplomacy/Authority) Legate of the Under-Seal, royal commissioner between kingdoms.
- J (Communication/Loyalty) White-Ribbon tunnel courier; runs blind, rings true.
- Q (Royalty/Authority) Vault-Queen of a crownland, sovereign above and below.
- K (Supreme Authority/Tradition) High King Beneath the Peaks, first among crowns by ancient concord.
- A (Spiritual Power/Resolution) Lumenor of the Under-Altars, one sentence opens doors and closes debates.

Clubs — Complications/Threats (air, water, stone, rite, jurisdiction)

- 2. (Danger/Disorientation) Bad air pocket—candles gutter blue; lungs complain, schedules fail.
- 3. (Disruption/Flood) Drip-flood from a burst cistern reroutes corridors without asking.
- 4. (Accident/Destruction) Gas flare kisses a lamp; eyebrows and evidence vanish.
- 5. (Error/Security) Seal misread—the wrong door opens, the right one will not.
- 6. (Quarantine/Delay) Under-mold quarantine shuts the market just as your crate arrives.
- 7. (Danger/Warning) Settling crack—dust snow warns the roof wants down.
- 8. (Accusation/Suspicion) Stolen key turns up in your kit; accusations ring like bells.
- 9. (Conflict/Jurisdiction) Bell-code conflict—two authorities claim the same chime.
- 10. (Political Conflict/Violence) Vault-right feud: crown guards face basilica wardens on a stair.
- J (Disaster/Trapped) Cave-in behind—proof, friends, and retreat on the far side.
- Q (Religious Conflict/Inquisition) Heresy inquest in the under-chapel; arrests in whispers.
- K (Authority/Restriction) General Under-Seal—all vault traffic halted by royal decree.
- A (Natural Disaster/Destruction) White Flood—mountain thaw becomes a river through your route.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage (keys, passes, breath, priority, precedent)

2. (Utility/Time) Lamp-priority tally—skip one lamplighter queue.
3. (Safety/Access) Breath-measure allotment—lawful time in a sealed chamber (once).
4. (Security/Authority) Key-Writ—operate a named lock one time, witnessed.
5. (Travel/Security) Underway Pass—escorted travel between two vaultmouths.
6. (Commerce/Rights) Stall-Right in the under-market for a season.
7. (Engineering/Safety) Engineer Shoring—a crew stabilizes your chosen corridor on your timetable.
8. (Commerce/Trust) Assay Mark—your coin/metal accepted sight unseen below.
9. (Protection/Law) Crypt Asylum—temporary sanctuary under crown law.
10. (Authority/Access) Vault Inventory License—remove a named cache under witness.
- J (Military/Authority) Under-Guard Commission—command a vault detachment for a day.
- Q (Royalty/Privilege) Private Descent with the Vault-Queen or High King’s chancellor.
- K (Supreme Authority/Access) High King’s Sealed Writ—doors open, mouths close across crownlands.
- A (Exception/Power) The Under-Seal Clause—temporary exception to any lock, levy, or rite below.

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: **Spade** = place, **Heart** = actor, **Club** = pressure, **Diamond** = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5→4, 6–10→6, J/Q/K→8, A→10).
- Treat **Diamonds** as codified outcomes (keys/passes/rights) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any **A** appears, echo stone & breath motifs keys click, bells answer, and the mountain listens (and remembers). Also, the pressure that thinks may manifest as a whisper, a warmth, or a knock in the dark.

Additional Features

- **Count the Air:** When a scene establishes scarce air, a character who actively paces their breathing (counted steps, measured rests) may shift *Position* one step safer on their next physical action in a confined space. This is habit, not a resource; Aeler characters may do this reflexively.
- **Bell-Code Courtesy:** If the party adopts local bell etiquette (asking a warden which chime applies and heeding it), gain +1 assist die on negotiations or passage requests within a vault or under-market. Ignoring the bells invites the mountain’s attention.
- **Measure is Mercy:** Presenting a certified measure (rod, weight, sealed tally) calms a dispute: cancel the first SB generated by commerce or jurisdictional friction in the scene. A false measure, however, may draw the pressure’s curiosity.
- **The Ninth Breath (Cultural Tic):** An Aeler character never counts to nine aloud. If forced to do so (or if they deliberately break the taboo), they must test Resolve (DV 3) or gain the *Marked by the Pressure* condition (the next environmental hazard automatically triggers a

complication). This is not a mechanical resource; it is a narrative and cultural constraint.

Stone & Sovereignty

In the deep places, survival depends on precision and tradition. The Aeler understand that stone does not forgive error — a misread seal can mean death, a miscalculated air measure can doom an expedition, and a broken bell-code can spark jurisdictional war. But beneath the law, beneath the ledgers, there is the pressure. It does not hate. It does not judge. It simply *thinks*. And when it thinks of you, you will feel a warmth in the stone, a whisper in the dark, a knock that comes in threes. The wise pretend not to notice. The foolish walk toward it.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **vault wardens or lamplighter companies**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **under-guards or echo bats**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or assessors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable air**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Breath warden or vault warden** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **air shift or seal change**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival crown’s guard or gas wraith** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **crown guards, true masons, or lamp companies** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **seal misread/cave-in/flare ignites**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.
- **Pressure Whispers:** A character hears their name spoken from a crack in the stone. They must test Resolve (DV 3) or be compelled to move toward the sound.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Vault-Queen, High King’s Legate, or Lumenor** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **gas floods/water breaks/floor collapses**.

- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests.**
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.
- **The Deep Drake's Attention:** The pressure that thinks focuses on a character. They gain a *Marked by the Deep* condition. The GM gains 2 SB to spend on environmental or psychic complications in future scenes.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Aeler (Stone & Breath):** Keys click in the wrong locks, bells answer without being rung, mountain air grows thin without warning.
- **Aeler (Authority & Tradition):** A seal is misread, bell-codes conflict between jurisdictions, a vault warden demands proper credentials.
- **Aeler (Underground Hazards):** Bad air pockets form, settling cracks warn of collapse, gas flares ignite unexpectedly.
- **Aeler (The Pressure That Thinks):** A distant knock in threes, a warmth from a cold wall, a whisper that sounds like a dead relative, a shadow that moves independently.

Aeler — UnderVault Tensions

Starting Location: An Underway junction lit by guttering brass lanterns, its stone walls scored with tallymarks from a dozen forgotten crowns.

“Among the Aeler, stone remembers the weight of oaths, and every echo calls a reckoning. But some echoes call from the deep, where the pressure thinks. Do not answer.”

In... An Underway junction, a Geometer halts the party with a tally-rod. “The Spine shifts,” he says, stone-dust in his beard. “Choose a crown or be buried by one. And if you hear a knock in threes, pretend you did not. The pressure is listening tonight.”

Regional Motifs Load-bearing oaths, fault-prayers, crown-rights, catacomb guilds.

Whispers to Offer “Cut a supporting tie,” “Sign for another’s debt,” “Take a shortcut through the sealed tunnel,” “Answer the knock it might be a friend.”

External Clocks Threat: “The Spine Slips”; Fracture: “Maps Reorder”; Community: “Surface Panic”; Deep: “The Pressure Wakes [8]”.

Complications Load-lights dim; echoes reply in politics; crown agents arrive early; a miner goes missing in the deep.

Anchors at Risk A PC’s workshop; a shared refuge tunnel; a relative who works in the deep galleries.

Escalation Beat The tally-rod points to the most guilty PC. Then a knock sounds from the darkness three times.

Relief Shore a vault with sacrifice (1 anchor), or complete a truce between crowns; Spirit + Resolve (5) to hold a cave-in long enough to evacuate. Or offer a memory to the pressure it will accept, but it will remember.

Faction Entanglements

- **Edgewalkers (Prospectors):** If you accept their escort or intel, start a 4-segment *Opportunity* clock you can cash for +1 Effect on one venture. If you refuse a posted hazard, they post *your* route as “open” (first stealth or smuggling roll this leg suffers –1 die). Edgewalkers are the most likely to have heard the pressure’s whisper and survived.
- **True Masons (Infrastructure Orders):** Pledge tools or labor to earn a *Mason’s Stamp* (treat as papers to traverse construction zones). Cross a marked barrier without their leave and gain the *Tampered Work* tag—first structural mishap SB against you is free. True Masons are the ones who seal the tunnels that grow warm.
- **Lamplighter Companies:** Donate wick, oil, or time on the Mile to bank a *Lamp Credit*; spend to ignore darkness penalties once on the Under-Road. Skip a service bell and all under-market buys that scene cost +1 clock tick (queues & suspicion). Lamplighters are the first to notice when a light goes out for no reason.
- **Under-Market Assessors:** Submit to measure/weigh and reduce Commerce DV by 1 this scene. Try to pass unassayed goods—on a Miss, lose the load *or* accept a *Caveat Stamp* that poisons your price two markets downstream. Assessors have a sixth sense for false weights; they claim the pressure tells them.
- **Breath Wardens:** Register bodies & flames before sealed work; compliance cancels the first air-hazard SB. Skipping registry adds a *Thin Air* tick to the leg (applies –1 die to the first exertion test in confinement). Breath Wardens are the ones who count every exhalation. They never speak of what they hear in the silence between breaths.

Cross-Regional Ties & Soft Power

- **Agrarian Reliance (Human Breadbelts):** Grain, timber, tallow, and fleece convoys from Acasia/Vhasia/Viterra sustain vault populations. Famine or levy spikes uprange impose night rationing: Under-Road checks +1 DV and food trades add +1 SB pressure until relief.
- **Standards Diplomacy:** Aeler *Measure Vault* rods adopted abroad grant +1 die to settle disputes in foreign markets; rejecting Aeler standards increases toll and inspection frequency (first border scene gains a free “Lock/Barrier” SB).
- **True Mason Missions Abroad:** Accept a Mason cadre to “stabilize” bridges, ports, or sluices: reduce Travel DV by 1 on that route for the arc, but the route now respects Aeler closure bells (authorities can halt traffic with one writ).
- **Edgewalker Concessions:** Prospect notes traded to frontier lords exchange for wayleaves and salvage rights; cash once for an *Under-Seal Clause (local)* or accept a rival claimant clock that will mature if you delay.
- **Kahfagian Interface (Sea Monopoly):** Aeler export hard-goods via Kahfagian factors; storm seasons or privateer scares add a *Harbor Quarantine* tick to any surface leg feeding those ports (customs DV +1).
- **Aelerem/Aelinnel Fallout:** When *Valewood Weather* is signaled, Aeler works creak; all bell-codes in mixed settlements (Aelerem/Aelinnel) are one step easier to misread (first bell-etiquette scene: add a free “Error/Security” SB unless you consult a local).

Trade Goods & Consequences

- **Airworks & Wick (Oil, Char, Filters):** Donate to a vault—bank a *Breath Favor* to cancel the next bad-air complication. Hoard in a shortage and your lot is flagged; all purchases beneath that crown suffer –1 die until you settle a fine or tithe.
- **Stonework & Ironwork (Beams, Keys, Rods):** Selling to foreign keeps spreads Aeler codes: once per arc, treat a foreign gate as if it used Aeler warding (gain +1 die with Key-Sisters/warders there). Counterfeit measure rods trigger a cross-border inquest clock.
- **Foodflows (Grain, Fleece, Tallow):** Move relief trains to clear one *Rationing* tag for a settlement (DV –1 for social checks there). Divert a relief train and gain an *Audit* clock that follows you three markets hence.
- **Cistern-Right & Water Engineering:** Fund a sluice or cistern abroad to gain *Water Priority* (skip one queue during drought). Neglect maintenance and the keeper may invoke *Aeler Liability*—pay or lose access to the route for a season.

Patron Networks (Below and Beyond)

- **The Sealed Gate:** Consecrated door-nails from True Mason kits act as single-use *stay* writs (negate one forced entry this scene).
- **The Traveler:** Spine milestones double as wayshrines; leave a brass chit to reroll one failed travel test on that segment this arc.
- **Inquisitor Prime:** Breath-pure censers sanction “clean rooms”; once per delve, dispel one ambient miasma or ward-rot effect at cost of +1 Obligation to local abbey-knights.
- **Maelstraeus:** Under-Market stalls tithe to the Great Ledger; cash a *Market Dominance* tick to flip one price band in your favor for a scene, then mark a 4-segment *Karmic Debt* with assessors.

Survival-Horror Procedures (Use Often)

- **Headcount & Flamecount:** At scene start in confinement, ask “Who breathes, what burns?” If headcount+flamecount exceeds posted limit, add a free “Thin Air” SB and start a 4-segment *Stale Air* clock.
- **Two Bells to Safety:** Any time the fiction stalls underground, ring two nearby bells (authority vs. sanctum). PCs must pick one to heed; ignoring both increases the next hazard’s Cap by +1 (stone holds grudges).
- **Measure or Mistrust:** Producing a certified rod/weight cancels the first commerce/jurisdiction SB this scene; failing to present one imposes –1 die on haggling or passage until appeased.
- **The Knock in Threes:** If a character hears three knocks from the darkness, they must test Resolve (DV 3) or be compelled to walk toward the sound. The knock may be the pressure or it may be a lost miner. The difference is not always clear.

Diplomatic Favor & Reputation Echoes

- **Breath Favor (minor resource):** Earned by donating wick/oil or assisting air wardens. Spend to downgrade one underground hazard outcome or to bypass a lamplighter queue.
- **Stamps & Seals:**

- *Mason-Marked*: Doors to worksites open; smugglers avoid you (harder to buy contraband, easier to cross safely).
- *Edge-Trusted*: Prospectors share fresh maps—first detour per leg is free; officials eye you as opportunists (first civic audience DV +1).
- *Assessor-Clean*: Under-markets honor your assay; rivals spread rumors—add a trailing *Audit* clock if you score a windfall.

Boss Archetypes in Aeler

Systemic / Economic / Conspiracy

- **Under-Market Syndic (Cartel/Measure Fraud)**: Price-fixes breath, wick, and water; wields corrupt assay marks to starve rivals. *Win by exposing forged measures or seizing the Assay Chain.*
- **True Mason Provost (Infrastructure Coup)**: Locks cities behind “safety closures,” weaponizes detours and permits. *Win by forcing a public bell-code audit or breaking the Permit Clock.*
- **Edgewalker Concessionaire (Route Monopolist)**: Controls salvage and short-cuts, posts hazards to strangle traffic. *Win by proving route tampering or opening a sanctioned bypass.*
- **Bell-Code Inquisitor (Silent Coup)**: Rewrites chimes to shift jurisdiction; arrests arrive as echoes. *Win by restoring canonical bell charts or capturing the Chime Key.*

Survival Horror (Environment as Boss)

- **White Flood (Water/Pressure)**: Thaw-swollen river through the halls; phases at *trickle* → *surge* → *roar*. *Win by sluicework, sacrificial breach, or riding the flood.*
- **Bad Air (Miasma/Invisible)**: Candles gutter blue; thoughts slow; corridors choose the slowest. *Win by air discipline, filter rites, or opening a lung-shaft.*
- **Hungry Stone (Creep/Collapse)**: Settling cracks hunt noise and heat; shudders on every miss. *Win by shoring, silence, and rerouting stress through old ribs.*
- **Lamp Famine (Darkness/Isolation)**: Wicks fail in sequence; last lights lure you deeper. *Win by restoring the Lamplighter’s Mile or kindling a saint-wick.*

Undead / Fallen Kingdom / Eldritch / Demonic

- **Crown-Lich of the Crypt (Undead Sovereign)**: Keeps ancient offices; binds petitioners with oaths to the dead. *Win by repealing a mortmain writ or severing the Oath-Chain.*
- **Echo-King in the Deep (Eldritch Memory)**: A throne of voices; answers every argument you will ever make. *Win by changing the Measure (new precedent) or striking the Silent Note.*
- **Seal-Devil (Demonic Contract)**: Lives in locks and signatures; eats exceptions. *Win by offering a flawless counter-seal or starving it of loopholes.*
- **The Hollow Architect (Fallen Works)**: A ghost-guilder rebuilding the empire wrong on purpose. *Win by unkeying the master plan or collapsing the false load paths.*
- **The Deep Drake (The Pressure That Thinks)**: Not a boss to be fought, but a presence to be negotiated with or escaped. *Phases: Whisper* → *Knock* → *Invitation* → *Collection*. *Cracks: offer a memory of sunlight, speak a true regret, or allow a willing sacrifice to walk into the deep in your place.*

Boss Mechanics Notes

- **Air & Light Tracks:** In confined scenes, track *Headcount*, *Flamecount*. If *Headcount* + *Flamecount* exceeds posted limit, add a free “Thin Air” SB and start **Stale Air** [4]. Each tick imposes −1 die to exertion until vented.
- **Jurisdiction Clocks:** Many bosses run a **Bell-Code Conflict** [4] or **Seal Dispute** [6]. On fill, the boss gains *Authority Surge*: increase their social DV by +1 and seize initiative once.
- **Lair Actions (choose 2–3):**
 - *Collapse Probe*: Mark “Settling Crack”; nearest noisy PC tests PROWESS or risk *Pin/Separate*.
 - *Breath Tax*: Reduce *Flamecount* by 1; next exertion in zone costs Fatigue 1 on a miss.
 - *Blackout/Glare*: Snuff or flare lamps; impose Disorient (−1 die) until a *Lamplighter Action* restores balance.
 - *Bell Override*: Swap which faction’s law applies; social actions vs. boss gain +1 DV this round.
 - *White Flood Surge*: Advance environment clock; force MOVE/WRECK or be *Separated*.
 - *Pressure’s Knock (Deep Drake only)*: A character hears three knocks. They must test Resolve (DV 4) or be compelled to move one range band toward the sound.
- **Phase Triggers:** Environment bosses phase when *Air* hits 2/4, *Water* hits 3/6, or *Light* hits 0; Conspiracy bosses phase when *Audit* or *Permit* clocks fill.
- **Truth & Measure:** Producing a certified rod/weight cancels the first commerce/jurisdiction SB each phase; forging one gives the boss 1 SB and a free *Expose Fraud* reaction.
- **Crowd Pressure:** In under-markets, add **Panic Crowd** [4]; each tick adds +1 DV to precise actions (shoot, pick, ritual) unless calmed with bell-code or coin.
- **Fear Hooks (optional):** *Bad Air* inflicts FEAR vs. suffocation; *Echo-King* inflicts FEAR vs. isolation; *Seal-Devil* inflicts FEAR vs. helplessness; *Pressure’s Knock* inflicts FEAR vs. the unknown. On Fail: mark *Shaken*; on Critical Fail: drop a resource (*lamp, key, breath*).

Chapter 8

The Mistlands

Bells, Salt, and Breath.

The bells here do more than mark time they weave the very fabric of reality, keeping the mist at bay and the dead in their proper places. Each chime is a thread in the pattern that holds the world together.

I am a Bell-Warden. I refuse to write down the ninth note. It lives only in my memory and that memory is fading.

The Mistlands are a protectorate of the Aeler in name only. The fog here doesn't just hide the land; it hides the law, and oh, how the wraiths love that ambiguity. The bell-lines aren't just defence they're the only thing keeping the wraiths from dragging whole villages into the mist. The Aeler built them. The Aeler charge for them. The Aeler will leave when the money runs out. And when that happens, the fog will remember every single soul they abandoned.

Never answer a voice that calls your name from the fog. The mist collects names, and once it has yours, the ferryman will always know where to find you. I've seen men answer. I've watched them walk into the white, still talking, still smiling, until their voices came back from a direction they hadn't gone.

Warden Kael, who has seen the ninth bell rung once and will not speak of it

The Almanac of Ordinary Days

What do people eat for breakfast? Salt fish and sour bread the fish is smoked over peat fires, the bread is leavened with fog-damp yeast. The yeast is caught in cloth traps hung from the bell-towers. The traps are emptied at dawn. The yeast is not alive. It is not dead either.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To ring a bell. Every Mistlands child is given a small bronze bell at birth. By age three, they can ring the eight notes of the ward-chime in their sleep. The ninth note is never taught. The ninth note is discovered.

Discovery is fatal.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their salt-pouch. Every Mistlander carries a leather pouch of consecrated salt. A stranger without a pouch is either a fool or a wraith. A stranger whose pouch is empty is a fool who is about to become a wraith.

What is the most common crime? Ward-salt theft. The Aeler control the salt pans, and the salt is the only thing that keeps the dead from rising. A stolen pouch can buy a week's protection. The price is a year's debt to the Aeler. The debt is collected in labour. The labour is collecting salt. The salt is stolen. The cycle is perpetual.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Bell-Wardens are not chosen they are volunteered. A village that loses a warden must send a replacement to the Aeler training holds. The holds are in the mountains. The mountains are cold. The trainees do not always return. The ones who do return do not speak of what they learned. Their bells ring at a different pitch.

Where do people go when they die? To the fog. Bodies are not buried in the Mistland the ground rejects them. Corpses are carried to the edge of the bell-line and left for the mist. The mist takes them. Sometimes, at dusk, you can see them walking the lanes. They do not speak. They do not need to. Their presence is a question.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You ring the Bell of Atonement a cracked bronze bell that hangs in every village square. The bell rings once for each wrong confessed. If the bell rings true, you are forgiven. If it cracks further, you are not. If it shatters, you are banished to the fog. The banished never return. Their voices still answer from the white.

What is the most important festival? The Rehangings of the Lines (autumn). Every bell-line is taken down, cleaned, and rehung. The work takes three days. The villages are silent for three nights. The dead listen. The dead wait. The dead do not ring.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Legate of the Mists is a wraith. She died in 803 AR, during a bell-line failure. The Aeler rebuilt her from fog and memory. She does not know she is dead. She attends council meetings. She signs documents. Her signature fades after sunset. The documents are refiled every morning.

8.1 Mistlands — “Bells, Salt, and Breath”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The mist counts your breaths. The bells remember your name.*

Legate of Mists (Elite): “The bells here do more than mark time—they weave the very fabric of reality, keeping the mist at bay and the dead in their proper places. Each chime is a thread in the pattern that holds the world together. The Aeler gave us bells. The fog taught us to ring them.”

Salt-Monk (Commoner): “Salt don’t just preserve the fish—it holds back the things that shouldn’t walk. Every grain blessed is a prayer, and every prayer keeps the mist from remembering your name. The Aeler tax our salt. We pay in silence.”

Genre / Mood: Folk horror, coastal gothic, supernatural debtcollection.

Starting Location: A BellLine levee veiled in fog, where bellropes sway though no wind stirs, and each ring tastes like a heartbeat. A Ferryman demands a name as toll. When the party hesitates, a BellWarden steps forward. “The Ninth Bell rings tonight. Will you answer—or flee? The Aeler won’t save you. The fog doesn’t care. Only the bells keep the line.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Mistlands lie north of the Aelerian mountains, where the Aberderrin Sea laps against reedfens and drowned shores. To the west, the Direwood breathes; to the east, the salt tides of the Aberderrin. It is a Protectorate of the Aeler, but their iron passes only hold the southern roads—the land itself belongs to fog and bells. Every levee hums with wardnotes, every ferry takes salt as tithe, and every shadow is measured against the Direwood’s endless breath. The people here live by the weight of salt, the echo of bells, and the hope that their names will not be spoken by the mists.

The Aeler Protectorate maintains order with ledgers, patrols, and breathbonds, but the real law is older: salt lines drawn at dusk, iron nails hammered into threshold posts, and the unspoken knowledge that the ninth bell must never ring. The Mistlands do not forgive forgetfulness. The mist has a long memory, and it shares its grudges freely.

What you notice first: The constant, distant chime of bells—never quite in sync. The taste of salt on your lips even inland. The way everyone holds their breath when crossing a bridge. The silence when a bell fails to ring.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never answer a voice that calls your name from the fog. The mist collects names, and once it has yours, the ferryman will always know where to find you.

Regional Mood: Bells and Breath

Here, breath is currency and silence a sin. Every exhalation is counted by the wardbells, and every stolen inhalation feeds something that should not be. The Aeler Protectorate maintains order with ledgers and patrols, but the real law is older: salt lines drawn at dusk, iron nails hammered into threshold posts, and the unspoken knowledge that the ninth bell must never ring. The Mistlands do not forgive forgetfulness. The mist has a long memory, and it shares its grudges freely.

The tension between the Aeler governor (Legate Halvar) and the local bellwardens is constant. The Aeler want standardized bellcodes, efficient salt taxes, and compliant villages. The wardens want the old ways: counting in eights, never the ninth, and the right to refuse a name to the fog. Payden's Port, the only true city, is a battleground of ledgers and lanterns. Grain ships leave each autumn, carrying the Protectorate's tithe east and returning with iron, engineers, and the occasional missionary who rarely stay.

Prominent NPCs of the Mistlands

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Legate Halvar	Aeler governor of the Protectorate	Keep the belllines intact and the grain flowing east	She carries a bell that has never been rung. It will ring once, at the end of her reign.
Mother Anja	SaltMonk of the White Pans	Preserve the old wards against the Direwood	Her tongue is white with salt; she speaks only in blessings or silence.
Warden Kael	BellWarden of the High Line	Protect his village from the mist and the Aeler taxmen	He refuses to write down the ninth note; it lives only in his fading memory.
Sister Darya	Healer of the Grey Hospice of the Unnamed (Temple of Light)	Tend the fogsick and the drowned	Her grey robes never stain, and she asks no payment only a name for her ledger.
Notary Voss	Covenant judge (Mykkiel)	Impose Aeler law on local customs	He carries a waterclock to measure the shifting of legal moods. The mist ignores it.

The Ferryman	Oathferryman of the Ghost Slip	Collect fares in salt and whispered names	His left hand is always gloved; underneath, the names are carved into his palm.
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Names of the Mistlands

Inspired by the coastal fens and the Aeler protectorate: clipped, breathy, with soft vowels and hard endings. Surnames often denote a marsh, a craft, or a ward.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Halvar	Anja	Foss	<i>the BellSworn</i>
Kael	Darya	Mork	<i>FogBorn</i>
Voss	Pia	Saltvedt	<i>the Unnamed</i>
Torben	Lise	Kyst	<i>BreathThief</i>
Stian	Ragna	Dyrep	<i>WardKeeper</i>
Vidar	Signe	Tangen	<i>AshFinger</i>

(Fen/Levee/Bellline) Reedfen causey with chalked wardrunes on every milestone; BellLine levee with iron posts and eight bells per span.

Spades — Places

- Reed-Fen Causey** — Chalked wardrunes on every milestone; safe path through the mist. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *Step only on the chalked stones. The mud between has no bottom.*
- Bell-Line Levee** — Iron posts, eight bells per span; one bracket empty, one note forbidden. ‘[WARD]’ *The empty bracket is for the bell that never rings. The rope is still there.*
- Ghost-Ferry Slip** — Rope crosses black water; fares paid in salt and whispered names. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The ferryman never blinks. Some say he traded his eyelids for the right to collect.*
- Pall Watch-Tower** — Piles above mire; mirrors face west to the Direwood’s breath. ‘[WARD]’ *The mirrors are silvered on both sides. The wardens watch their own reflections as much as the trees.*
- Mist-Chapel** — Stilted planks; votive lanterns gutter under damp rafters. ‘[RITUAL]’ *The icon has no face. Worshippers say it lost its features to the fog, one by one.*
- Dead-Cut Canal** — Old imperial ditch; patrolled by eel boats and law. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The eels have eyes like men. Fishermen throw back any that blink.*
- Drowned Copse** — Roottangles clutch tide like old hands; bones in the bark. ‘[DEATH]’ *The trees were planted on a mass grave. They grew twisted, hungry.*
- Fogmill Ridge** — Wind vanes vanish into cloud; gears hiss like prayers to fog. ‘[WEATHER]’ *The miller grinds salt, not grain. His customers pay in breath, not coin.*

10. **Salt-Pan Terraces** — Patched with peat; wardsalt dries under nets, watched by monks. ‘[RESOURCE]’ *The monks chant without ceasing. If they stop, the salt spoils and so does the warding.*
- J **Fort-Stair** — Stacked timber and stone; flags swallowed by mist, guards by routine. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The flags are changed daily. The ones that vanish are never spoken of again.*
- Q **Witchlight Bridge** — Over black runnel; ninth plank “counted” but unseen. ‘[THRESHOLD]’ *The missing plank is there you just can’t see it. Step where it should be, or don’t step at all.*
- K **High-Mist Pass** — Through Aelerians; cairns ringed in iron nails, bells in the stones. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *Each cairn holds a bell that rang once at the death of a warden. They ring again when mist takes another.*
- A **Weeping Gate** — Western palisade facing Direwood; bells wired to bones of trees. ‘[WARD]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *The gate weeps sap that smells of iron and old grief. Wardens collect it in silver cups.*

(**Warden/Ferryman/Aeler**) Bellwarden whose ringbook decides which notes keep which ghosts; oathferryman collecting fares in salt and names.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Reed-Cutter** — Peatblack hands, precise opinion on fog; knows every safe path. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *She cuts reeds in a pattern one snip, two snips, then a pause for the ninth.*
3. **Salt-Monk** — Blesses pans, keeps wardmeasure honest; salt as both shield and vow. ‘[RITUAL]’ *His tongue is white with salt. He speaks only in blessings or silence.*
4. **Bell-Warden** — Ringbook decides which notes keep which ghosts at bay. ‘[WARD]’ *She refuses to write down the ninth note. It lives only in her memory and that memory is fading.*
5. **Oath-Ferryman** — Fares in salt and names; remembers both, collects both. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[SOCIAL]’ *His left hand is always gloved. Underneath, the names are carved into his palm.*
6. **Lantern Acolyte** — Trims wicks and arguments; light as law in the mist. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *He carries a bell on his belt. It rings once for each lie he hears.*
7. **Mist-Pilot** — Linn refugee; ghosts ships through reedlace if paid in breath. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *She never speaks above a whisper. Her voice is currency, and she spends it carefully.*
8. **Protectorate Clerk** — Aeler oilskin ledgers, narrow smile; law in triplicate. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *His stamp is a bell. He presses it twice once for the crown, once for the Hollow.*
9. **Shroud-Diver** — Harvests tokens from drowned fields before dawn’s false light. ‘[STEALTH]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *He wears a bell around his ankle. If it rings, he’s stayed too long.*
10. **Direwood Refugee** — Cold breath, colder stories; knows what the trees whisper. ‘[FEAR]’ *She carved out her own tongue. The trees still speak through her in a voice not her own.*
- J **Fog-Knight** — Cavalry rides levee crowns by bellcode; mist as their steed. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *Their horses have no shadows. Some say they traded them for fogsight.*
- Q **Legate of Mists** — Aeler governor; equal parts mercy and decree, bells at their command. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *She carries a bell that has never been rung. It will ring once, at the end of her reign.*
- K **Lord Warden** — Local strong hand sworn to Legate’s seal; law walks the fens. ‘[AUTHOR-

ITY]‘ *He lost an eye to a wight. He wears a bell in the socket.*

A **Mist-Seer** — Bargains breath for answers; candles shorten when she speaks. ‘[MAGIC]‘
‘[FEAR]‘ *She has no shadow. The mist took it as a down payment.*

(**Undead/Weather/Law**) Groundmist lifts off fen and eats tracks by the yard; witchlights try to count you; step wrong and bridge forgets you.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Ground-Mist** — Lifts from fen; eats tracks by the yard, names by the breath. ‘[WEATHER]‘
‘[DEATH]‘ *Your footfalls vanish behind you. The mist is following, not rising.*
 3. **Witchlight Count** — Trying to count you; step wrong and bridge forgets your path.
‘[MAGIC]‘ ‘[FEAR]‘ *The lights flicker in a pattern two short, two long. They’re signaling someone.*
 4. **Ward-Salt Short** — Pans go green; bells ring, nothing answers from the other side. ‘[RE-
SOURCE]‘ ‘[WARD]‘ *The salt is grey, not white. Someone cut it with grave dust.*
 5. **Wrong Bell** — Cracked note opens a door the Legate can’t close; mist takes the gap.
‘[MAGIC]‘ *The bell’s clapper is a finger bone. The original owner wants it back.*
 6. **Linn Raid** — Slips reedmaze; hearths douse, horns travel on the fog. ‘[COMBAT]‘ *The
raiders wear bells on their belts stolen from the last village.*
 7. **Direwood Moan** — At dusk; Weeping Gate ropes go taut by themselves. ‘[DEATH]‘ ‘[FEAR]‘
The moan has words. You don’t want to understand them.
 8. **Valewood Wind** — Crosses Aberderrin; voices sweet, landmarks false. ‘[WEATHER]‘
‘[MAGIC]‘ *The wind smells of honey and rot. Do not follow it.*
 9. **Bell-Line Failure** — Levee breaks silence; wraith steps across like it owns the road. ‘[WARD]‘
‘[DEATH]‘ *The wraith carries a lantern. The light is blue the colour of drowned breath.*
 10. **Marsh-Quake** — Sod heaves, dyke slumps; proofs and bodies sink together. ‘[DISASTER]‘
The ground exhales. Your name rises from it like smoke.
- J **Protectorate Interdiction** — All ferries sealed “until review”; routes dry up. ‘[AUTHOR-
ITY]‘ ‘[TRAVEL]‘ *The seals are stamped with a bell. The wax is mixed with bone ash.*
- Q **Rite-Purge** — Inspectors call local customs heresy; tempers at a boil. ‘[AUTHORITY]‘
‘[SOCIAL]‘ *The inspectors carry blank ledgers. They fill them with names of the accused.*
- K **General Alarm** — Pall horns sound; every lantern becomes law, every shadow suspect.
‘[AUTHORITY]‘ ‘[FEAR]‘ *The horns are made from the tusks of a sea beast. The beast’s ghost is angry.*
- A **Tide-Mist** — Rolls from Aberderrin; spirits ride the white and won’t be named. ‘[WEATHER]‘
‘[DEATH]‘ *The spirits have no faces only the faces of the drowned.*

(**Pass/Seal/Token**) Wardsalt allotment draws safe circle once; ferry token crosses named black runnel regardless of curfew.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Ward-Salt** — Pure measure draws safe circle once; mist parts, briefly. ‘[WARD]’ *The salt is warm. It knows it will be used.*
3. **Ferry Token** — Cross named black runnel regardless of curfew or tide. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The token is a knuckle bone. The ferryman accepts it without comment.*
4. **Bell-Key** — Unlock and set one bell on the Line to your note; change the song. ‘[MAGIC]’ *The key is a tuning fork. Strike it once to claim your note.*
5. **Lantern Writ** — Lawful travel at night along levee crown with escort. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The writ is written on dried bladder. It crinkles when you lie.*
6. **Exorcist’s Seal** — Stamped clause downgrades “haunt” to “nuisance.” ‘[MAGIC]’ *The seal is a bell without a clapper. It’s silent, like the wraiths it binds.*
7. **Codeleaf** — Today’s mirror and horn sequences; fog cannot hide what you know. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The leaf is soaked in brine. Read it before it dries.*
8. **Protectorate Mark** — Priority rations and rope from FortStair stores. ‘[RESOURCE]’ *The mark is a brand. It smokes when you show it.*
9. **Wraith-Indemnity** — Legal immunity for actions taken under apparition threat. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The indemnity is signed in salt water. It will dissolve if you misuse it.*
10. **Bone-Field License** — Salvage rights at drowned hamlet (with witnesses). ‘[RESOURCE]’ *The license is a map drawn on a shroud. Follow the stitch marks.*
- J **Refuge-Right** — Move a named household through Gate unchallenged; breath as passport. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The right is a bellrope. Tie it to your belt. Nonna will ask.*
- Q **Legate’s Audience** — One whisper exits as policy; bells ring your decree. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The Legate’s ear is a silver bell. Speak into it once.*
- K **Warden’s Commission** — Raise levee guards; local doors open, purses too. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The commission is a whistle. Blow it, and the fens answer.*
- A **Pall Indulgence** — Temporary exception to ward law, spoken and sealed by bell. ‘[MAGIC]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The indulgence is a single bellnote, held in a jar. Break the jar to release it.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (25 4, 610 6, J/Q/K 8, A 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (passes/seals/tokens) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **breath and boundary** bells answering across water, salt that won’t dry, voices returning late.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Breath-Toll:** Many claim the mist remembers every breath. Travelers hold breath crossing bridges, fearing the mist will count them wrong. Mechanically, when you cross a threshold without a wardsalt or bell, roll Spirit + Resolve (DV 3). On a failure, the mist learns your name gain the **MARKED** condition (the next spirit encounter starts at Desperate Position).

- **Salt as Promise:** A handful of salt is more than warding—it is a vow. Spill it on plank or stone to swear safety. Once per session, a character may spend a handful of wardsalt to create a **Salt Oath** [4] clock. While the clock has segments, the oath-taker gains +1 die to resist fear or possession. If the oath is broken, the clock fills and the breaker takes Harm 1 (spiritual backlash).
- **The Ninth Bell:** Legends say a ninth bell once rang on the Line. The note is not in any ringbook; no warden speaks of it. Some nights, though, it rings—and gates open where none should be. When the GM spends 3+ SB in a scene, they may declare that the Ninth Bell rings. All characters must test Spirit + Resolve (DV 4) or lose 1 Fatigue (the sound steals breath).
- **Payden’s Port:** The only true city in the Mistlands, huddled on the western coast of the Aberderrin. Its wharves are built from salvaged longship timber, and its law is split between the Aeler Legate’s seal and the old bellwardens’ traditions. Grain ships leave from its harbour each autumn, carrying the Protectorate’s tithe east—and returning with iron, engineers, and the occasional missionary. The port’s inn, the *Drowned Rat*, has a bell that rings once for every sailor lost at sea. It rings often.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Bell-Keeper** The Sealed Gate. *A bell that never rings, yet holds the threshold closed.*
 - **The Salted One** Oath of Mercy and Grace. *A prayer that preserves body and soul, but demands a name in return.*
 - **The Mist-Father** Khemesh. *The pressure beneath the fog; the hunger that waits in still air.*
 - **The Lantern Bearer** The Traveler. *The light that guides lost ships—and lost souls.*

Lore Echoes (CrossExpansion Hooks)

- **Saint Kael of the Iron Bell (The Sealed Gate):** The bellwardens venerate a legendary warden who hammered a ninth bell into the Weeping Gate to seal a Direwood breach. The bell cracked, but the breach closed. His chisel is kept at Payden’s Port; it is said to quench the mist for an hour if struck against an iron post. The Aeler Protectorate has tried to confiscate it twice; both attempts ended with the confiscators lost in fog.
- **Saint Anja of the White Pans (Oath of Mercy and Grace):** A saltmonk who died blessing the pans during a tidemist. Her body never decayed, and her chapel now serves as a hospice for fogsick sailors. The Temple of Light sends offerings of fresh water each spring; the Everflame considers her a heretic. Pilgrims who pray at her shrine may ask one question of a drowned ancestor—but the answer is always a single word, and that word is a tithe.
- **The Grey Hospice of the Unnamed:** Sister Darya runs a hospice near Payden’s Port. She asks no payment, but she records every patient’s name in a ledger that never dries. The Aeler clerks suspect she is erasing records, not healing wounds. She has been investigated three times; each time, the investigator vanished into the fog and returned with no memory of why they came.
- **The Bellringer’s Covenant (The Keeper of the Silent Seal):** Notary Voss is the Protectorate’s appointed judge, charged with imposing Aeler law on local customs. He carries a waterclock to measure the shifting of legal moods, but the mist ignores it. His rulings are always delivered in triplicate, and the bellwardens obey them—slowly. Those who lie before him find that their next passage through the GhostFerry Slip is denied; the ferryman refuses

to name them.

- **The Ninth:** In any Mistlands scene, the ninth person to speak in a room draws the mist's attention. The wise hold their tongues until someone else breaks the count. Those who speak ninth are said to see a pale figure standing at the foot of the bed that night waiting to collect a breath.
- **The Black Barrow Keep (Aelinnel Ruin):** Looming over Payden's Port, this ancient workshop of bellautomata and wardforges is sealed by the Protectorate but smugglers and treasurehunters still enter. Locals whisper that the lowest catacombs connect to the Ways Between. The Aeler have tried to collapse the upper levels three times; each time, the rubble was found cleared by morning, with no tracks in the fog.

Mistlands Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Fog:** Toss a crust into the mist before crossing a bridge. Ignore the first *Ground-Mist* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Hold the Ninth Breath:** Cross a threshold while holding your breath. Cancel *Witchlight Count* or take 1 die on your next action (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the Salt:** Whisper a dead enemy's name into a salt pan. Gain +1 Effect against undead for the scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Legate. '[SUPERSTITION]'

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **wardens or fog-knights**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **spirits or patrol boats**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or mist-spirits**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favourable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** Protectorate forces or local warden becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **mist shift or bell failure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A wraith, raiding party, or inspector arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **fog-knights, spirits, or Aeler forces** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes **bell-line fails/ward broken/mist claims name**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Legate, Lord Warden, or Mist-Seer** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically **mist thickens/bells ring/forest breathes**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Mistlands (Bells & Breath):** Bells ring without cause, breath forms visible words, mirrors reflect wrong faces.
- **Mistlands (Salt & Warding):** Salt refuses to dry, ward-runes bleed colour, protection tokens crack.
- **Mistlands (Direwood Threat):** Trees whisper your name, roots shift position, forest breath grows stronger.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Navigation):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Fog Bank*.
- **Silence the Bell (Presence + Stealth):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a wardsalt pouch is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Tide (Resolve + Survival):** On a hit in *Tide-Mist*, you pick who keeps their bearings; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Bell & Breath)

- **The Ninth Bell Ringer (Direwood herald)** *Phases:* Lost Names → Broken Lines → Open Gate. *Cracks:* restore a ringbook; trade a breath; rehang a forbidden bell with copper nails.
- **Queen of Counting Lights (fae arbiter)** *Phases:* Courteous Tithes → Geas-Market → Ledger of Leaves. *Cracks:* return stolen waymarks; speak said and meant; gild the iron.
- **Reed-Wolf Captain (Linn raider)** *Phases:* Smoke Signals → Night Oars → Thing Verdict. *Cracks:* name a feudtoken; win a skaldduel; force harbourtruce under bell and banner.

Patronage & Power

In the Mistlands, power flows through ritual, warding, and the careful balance between the living and the dead. The Aeler Protectorate maintains nominal control through military presence and legal frameworks, but true authority lies with those who understand the bells, the salt, and the breath of the land itself. Local wardens, saltmonks, and bellkeepers hold sway over daily life, while the Legate of the Mists mediates between imperial law and ancient custom.

For the GM: Patronage in the Mistlands revolves around protection from mist, from spirits, from the encroaching forest. Rewards often take the form of tokens, seals, or safe passage

that can be leveraged into greater security. To emphasise the folkhorror feel:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (salt, bells, lanterns) that can be challenged, depleted, or voided by the mist itself.
- Let rival factions (Protectorate vs. bellwardens vs. Direwood refugees) issue conflicting protections, forcing players to choose whose favour matters more.
- Use the levees, ferries, and watchtowers as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of the old ways (counting breaths, naming spirits, offering salt) determines success.

In the Mistlands, your safety is your standing, and your standing depends on who remembers your name.

Black Barrow Keep The Ruin Above Payden's Port

Looming over the eastern edge of Payden's Port, Black Barrow Keep is a jagged wound in the skyline. Its basalt walls weep salt, and its broken towers lean into the fog like old men listening for a bell that never rings. The Aelinnel built it in a forgotten agenot as a fortress, but as a *workshop*. Here, they forged bellautomata, copper sentinels, and the first wardlines that still keep the Direwood at bay. When the Mistlands became a Protectorate, the Aelinnel sealed the deep forges and retreated. The locals say the keep is haunted. The truth is worse: it is not haunted it is *occupied*.

Below the keep, the catacombs stretch down through nine known levels. Each level was sealed by a different generation of wrights: Aeler engineers, Aelinnel bellsmiths, Linn shipwrights, and older crafts whose names are scrubbed from the records. The lowest level is said to contain a working that has been ticking since before the Hollow learned to count.

Accessing the Keep: The main gate is chained with a bellock that requires a copper key and the correct sequence of rings (eight, never nine). Side entrances include a collapsed ropeway from the salt pans, a flooded stair from the GhostFerry Slip, and a smugglers' tunnel that exits near the Grey Hospice. The Protectorate has officially sealed the keep, but wardens look the other way for a share of salvage or a story about what moves in the deep.

Generator Black Barrow Keep: Rooms & Encounters

d12	Area / Encounter
1	The Hanging BellGarden. A collapsed floor reveals a chamber where bells grow from the ceiling like stalactites. Each bell has a clapper shaped like a finger bone. <i>Effect: A bell that rings once for each secret spoken beneath it. The ringing can be heard throughout the keep.</i>
2	The Copper Forge. Still warm, though the fire went out centuries ago. A halfcompleted automaton sits on the anvil. Its brass skull is hinged open; inside, a nest of salteels writhes. <i>Effect: The forge can be reactivated with a bellkey, producing a single wardsalt token per scene.</i>

3	The Oubliette of the Unnamed. A pit lined with counting marks eight scratches, a gap, eight scratches. At the bottom, a wrights skeleton still holds a hammer. The hammer rings when you touch it. <i>Effect: The hammer can drive a copper nail into any surface, sealing a threshold for one scene.</i>
4	The Echo Scriptorium. Shelves of slate tablets, each inscribed with a single number. The numbers are not in sequence. A ghost wright sits at a desk, writing the same number over and over. <i>Effect: The ghost will answer one question about the keeps history, but will then ask for a number you have never written.</i>
5	The Drowned Armoury. Sealed by a slow leak from the salt pans. Weapons float in brine. One of them a bellhilted sword hums when you near it. <i>Effect: The sword counts your heartbeats. If you draw it in combat, you gain+1 die, but the sword will demand a name at the end of the scene.</i>
6	The Weeping Cistern. A stone basin filled with black water. The water rises when you speak. A voice from below asks, What is the ninth number? <i>Effect: Answer with silence, and the water recedes, revealing a sealed door. Answer incorrectly, and the cistern floods the room.</i>
7	The Cogwheel Choir. A chamber of interlocking copper gears, each tooth stamped with a rune. When the wind blows through the broken wall, the gears turn and the runes sing a cracked hymn. <i>Effect: A character who learns the tune may reroll one failed navigation test while in the Mistlands (once).</i>
8	The SaltLiches Studio. A wright who refused to die. Its flesh is replaced by saltcured leather and copper wire. It still tries to finish a bell that has no clapper. <i>Effect: The saltliche is not hostile, but will trade a bellkey for a memory of fresh water.</i>
9	The Unstable Lift. A chainhoist that descends into darkness. The chains are warm. The lift stops at every eighth floor, never the ninth. <i>Effect: Riding the lift skips two levels of the catacombs, but ticks the FOG ATTENTION clock by1.</i>
10	The Bone Gallery. A corridor lined with the remains of wrights from every generation. Each skeleton wears a different style of bellmakers apron. The newest apron is still damp. <i>Effect: A PC may spend a scene searching; on a Wits+Lore roll (DV4), they find a key, a token, or a warning.</i>
11	The Ticking Heart. A sealed chamber behind a copper door. Something inside ticks at a steady rhythm. The rhythm changes when you lie. <i>Effect: The door requires a blood offering and a true confession to open. Inside is a working that can reset one broken bellline but it will ask for a year of your life.</i>

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| 12 | The Ninth Gate. A door that appears only when the keeps bells have rung eight times in sequence. Beyond it, a spiral stair descends into absolute silence. No echo returns. <i>Effect: This leads to the lowest catacomb, where the first wrights original bellline generator still turns. Activating it would drive the Direwood back a mile but the noise would wake the Ninth Bell Ringer.</i> |
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To use: Roll once for the room, then optionally roll again for a resident, hazard, or treasure from the appropriate tables in §8.1, §8.1, or §8.1. For the deeper catacombs, increase the DV of all spiritrelated rolls by1 and add a STALE AIR clock[4] at the start of each scene.

Factions in the Keep

- **The BellWrights Ghosts:** Ancient Aelinnel spirits who still maintain the lower forges. They ignore the living unless the forges are disturbed. Offerings of copper nails or a correctly rung bell will buy safe passage.
- **The Protectorate Salvage Team:** Aeler engineers and a squad of fogknights, ostensibly surveying the keep for hazards. They will confiscate any working bell they find and arrest anyone without a Protectorate writ. Their captain has a brass hand that is also a tuning fork.
- **The Hollows Anticipators:** A cult that believes the keep was built to contain the Hollows attention. They leave offerings of salt and silence. They are not dangerous but they will follow you, writing down every bell you ring and every name you speak.

Catacombs Depth Clock For expeditions that descend below the first sublevel, track a **Depth Clock** [6]. Each time the party descends a stair, uses the unstable lift, or passes a sealed door, tick the clock. At 3 segments: all navigation rolls gain +1 DV (the walls shift). At 6 segments: the party reaches a sealed level that requires a bellkey, a blood offering, or a true name to open. The deepest level (Depth 6 or more) connects to the Ways Between a mistake may drop the party into the Hollows own threshold.